Company teardowns

One-page teardowns of 44 products across 14 industries: strategy, customers, portfolio metrics, business model, friction, competition and recent news. North star, key metrics and guardrails are PM estimates for interview practice, not company-published figures.

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Razorpay

Full-stack payments and business banking infrastructure for Indian businesses

Founded: **2014, Harshil Mathur and Shashank Kumar** HQ: **Bengaluru; reverse-flipped domicile to India 2025** Owner/Listed: **Private; confidential DRHP filed with SEBI Jun 2026**
Revenue: **FY25 ₹3,783 cr (+65% YoY)** Profit: **FY25 net loss ₹1,209 cr (one-time ESOP/flip costs)** Scale: **~12M+ merchants; ~$180B annualised TPV (company claim)**
Valuation: **$7.5B (2021); IPO target ~$5–6B** CEO: **Harshil Mathur (co-founder)** Global: **Malaysia (Curlec), Singapore since 2025**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make money movement simple for every business: accept, process and disburse payments, then bank and lend on top.
- **Vision:** Become the operating system for business money in India and emerging Asia, from checkout to payroll to credit.
- **Core strategy:** Land with the payment gateway, expand into RazorpayX banking, POS, payroll and Capital to raise revenue per merchant.
- **Moat:** Developer-first APIs, best-in-class success rates via routing, RBI payment aggregator licence and deep enterprise integrations.
- **Key bet:** Agentic payments: AI Agent Studio (Mar 2026), UPI Reserve Pay pilots with NPCI, OpenAI and Zomato/Swiggy-style merchants.
- **Your view:** With UPI MDR near zero, can Razorpay earn enough beyond gateway fees to justify an IPO valuation below 2021's?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Razorpay
Startups and D2C	Online brands, SaaS, edtech, creators	Need fast onboarding, all payment modes, high checkout success	Plug-and-play APIs, Magic Checkout, payment links; live in hours, not weeks
Enterprises	Large e-commerce, BFSI, airlines, food delivery	Failed transactions and downtime cost crores at peak volumes	Optimizer multi-gateway routing, reliability SLAs, custom pricing and dedicated support
SMBs (offline)	Retailers using POS and QR	Fragmented terminals, settlement delays, no working-capital access	Razorpay POS (Ezetap) plus instant settlements and Capital loans in one dashboard
Finance teams	CFOs and ops teams in mid-market firms	Manual payouts, payroll, vendor payments and reconciliation	RazorpayX current accounts, Payouts and Payroll automate money-out with reconciliation
Cross-border sellers	Indian exporters, SEA merchants	High FX fees and slow international settlements	International payments, Curlec Malaysia and Singapore stack cut cross-border cost

Product portfolio and metrics

Payments (money in)

Payment Gateway	Cards, UPI, netbanking, wallets, EMI in one integration
Magic Checkout	One-click checkout with saved addresses, COD risk scoring
Optimizer	Routes transactions across gateways to maximise success rate
Payment Links and Pages	No-code collection for social sellers and SMBs
Subscriptions	Recurring billing on UPI Autopay, cards, eMandates
Razorpay POS	Offline card and QR terminals from Ezetap acquisition
North Star	Successful payment volume (TPV) processed per active merchant
Key metrics	Payment success rate, take rate in bps, active merchants, integration time
Guardrails	Fraud and chargeback rate, downtime minutes, RBI compliance incidents

RazorpayX (money out and banking)

Current Accounts	Neo-banking accounts with partner banks for businesses
Payouts	Bulk vendor, refund and gig-worker disbursals via API
Payroll	Salary, compliance, TDS and PF automation
Corporate Cards	Spend management cards for teams
North Star	Monthly money-out volume from merchants also using gateway
Key metrics	Cross-sell rate, account balances, payout volume, payroll seats
Guardrails	Failed payouts, partner-bank incidents, support ticket resolution time

Capital and AI

Razorpay Capital	Working-capital and cash-advance loans underwritten on payment data
AI Agent Studio	Agents for failed-payment recovery, disputes, cash-flow (2026)
Agentic payments	UPI Reserve Pay checkouts inside AI assistants, pilot stage
North Star	Revenue per merchant from non-gateway products
Key metrics	Loan disbursals, NPA rate, agent-recovered GMV, agent adoption
Guardrails	Credit losses, unauthorised agent transactions, merchant complaints

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Payment gateway MDR	Online merchants and enterprises	Merchant	~2% on cards/wallets; UPI near-zero MDR; negotiated enterprise pricing
Value-added services	Merchants needing checkout, routing, subscriptions	Merchant	Per-transaction or SaaS fees for Magic Checkout, Optimizer, Subscriptions
RazorpayX banking	Finance teams of SMBs and mid-market	Merchant plus partner bank float share	Payout fees, payroll per-seat SaaS, interchange on corporate cards
Lending (Capital)	Merchants needing working capital	Borrowing merchant	Interest and fees, often deducted from settlements
Offline POS	Retailers and enterprise stores	Merchant	Device rental plus MDR on card and QR transactions

- **Revenue mix:** Payment gateway dominates; RazorpayX, POS and international drove FY25's 65% growth to ₹3,783 cr.
- **Users vs payers:** Consumers pay at checkout but never pay Razorpay; merchants are both users and payers (pure B2B).
- **Unit economics:** Gross profit ₹1,277 cr FY25 (~34% margin); low UPI take rate squeezes gateway margins, cross-sell offsets.
- **Growth levers:** Raise revenue per merchant via banking, lending, POS; SEA expansion; agentic commerce; possible UPI MDR for large merchants.

Friction points to discuss

- UPI zero-MDR makes core volume barely profitable
- Settlement holds and KYC re-checks frustrate small merchants
- Chargeback and dispute handling feels opaque to SMBs
- Pricing tiers and add-on fees hard to compare
- Partner-bank dependency for RazorpayX causes outages, limits

Competitors and market

- **Gateways:** PayU, Cashfree, Juspay (orchestration), CCAvenue, Stripe India
- **Offline/POS:** Pine Labs (listed 2025), Paytm, PhonePe, bank POS
- **Business banking:** Open, bank current accounts, Zoho Payroll
- **Global:** Stripe, Adyen, Checkout.com for cross-border merchants
- **Edge:** Developer love, product breadth, success-rate routing, early AI/agentic bets
- **Risk:** Commoditised UPI pricing, RBI regulatory actions, IPO at down-round valuation

Recent news and direction

- **Jun 2026:** Filed confidential DRHP with SEBI; targets ₹5,000–6,000 cr IPO.
- **Mar 2026:** Launched AI Agent Studio at FTX 2026; agentic payments push.
- **Jun 2025:** Singapore operations live after Malaysia's Curlec grew ~10x.
- **Watch:** IPO pricing, FY26 profitability, UPI MDR for large merchants decision.

Sources: Company statements and RoC filings FY25 (via Inc42/Entrackr), SEBI DRHP coverage, press coverage 2025–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

PhonePe

India's largest UPI app, expanding into lending, insurance and wealth

Founded: **2015, Sameer Nigam, Rahul Chari, Burzin Engineer** HQ: **Bengaluru; domicile shifted to India 2022** Owner/Listed: **Walmart majority; IPO deferred Mar 2026**
Revenue: **FY26 ₹7,920 cr (+11% YoY)** Profit: **FY26 net loss ₹2,792 cr (FY25: ₹1,727 cr)** Users: **70 cr+ registered users (Apr 2026)** Merchants: **5 cr+ registered merchants, 98% pincodes**
UPI share: **~45–46% by volume (NPCI, mid-2026)** CEO: **Sameer Nigam (co-founder)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Unlock the flow of money and access to services for every Indian, starting with free, reliable UPI.
- **Vision:** Become India's financial services platform: payments as distribution, lending, insurance and wealth as the profit pool.
- **Core strategy:** Use UPI ubiquity and SmartSpeaker merchant network as low-cost acquisition, then monetise via credit, insurance, broking.
- **Moat:** Habit and scale: 70 cr users, 5 cr merchants, Bharat reach, reliability at ~11 billion monthly transactions.
- **Key bets:** Lending revenue doubled to ₹945 cr FY26; Share.Market broking; Indus Appstore versus Google Play.
- **Your view:** If NPCI enforces the 30% cap, should PhonePe cede volume gracefully or fight it, and why?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose PhonePe
Mass consumers	Smartphone users, Tier 2+ heavy	Need free, instant, reliable payments everywhere	Fast UPI, highest merchant acceptance, recharges and bills in one app
Kirana merchants	Small offline shops, street vendors	Cash handling, payment confirmation fraud, no credit history	Free QR, SmartSpeaker audio confirmation, merchant loans from transaction data
Borrowers	New-to-credit salaried and self-employed	Banks reject thin-file applicants; slow paperwork	Pre-approved personal, gold, merchant loans via partner lenders in-app
Insurance and wealth buyers	First-time investors and insurance buyers	Complex products, agent mis-selling, high minimums	Simple term, health, motor policies; low-ticket SIPs and stock broking via Share.Market
Online businesses	Merchants, app developers, advertisers	Need checkout, distribution and payments reach	PhonePe PG, Indus Appstore lower commissions, ads on high-traffic app

Product portfolio and metrics

Payments

UPI P2P and P2M	Free bank-to-bank and merchant payments, market leader
Recharge and Bills	Mobile, DTH, utilities, FASTag, credit card bills
SmartSpeaker and POS	Audio payment alerts and card terminals for merchants
Payment Gateway	Online checkout for merchants and apps
Credit on UPI	RuPay credit cards and credit lines linked to UPI
North Star	Monthly transacting users completing 4+ payments
Key metrics	UPI volume share, success rate, merchant actives, speaker rentals
Guardrails	Fraud losses, downtime, NPCI 30% share cap compliance

Financial services

Lending	Personal, merchant, gold, home loans via NBFC/bank partners
Insurance broking	Term, health, motor, travel policies distributed in-app
Share.Market	Stock broking and mutual fund platform
Wealth	SIPs, digital gold, tax-saving funds
North Star	Monthly financial-services revenue per transacting user
Key metrics	Disbursals, policies sold, SIP book, cross-sell from payments
Guardrails	Loan delinquencies, mis-selling complaints, regulator observations

New platforms

Indus Appstore	Android app store with low developer commission
Pincode	Now B2B ERP/sourcing; B2C hyperlocal wound down Dec 2025
Ads	Brand and performance ads on payment surfaces
North Star	Monthly active installs via Indus Appstore
Key metrics	Developers onboarded, OEM preloads, ad revenue per DAU
Guardrails	Cash burn, payment-app UX clutter, malware incidents

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Consumer payments	Consumers paying bills, recharges	Billers, telcos, some users via platform fees	Commissions on recharges/bills; small platform fees on some payments
Merchant payments	Offline and online merchants	Merchants	SmartSpeaker rentals, PG MDR on cards; UPI MDR is zero today
Lending distribution	Borrowers and merchants	Partner lenders	Origination and sourcing fees; FY26 revenue ₹945 cr
Insurance and wealth	Retail investors and policy buyers	Insurers, AMCs, traders	Broking commissions, distribution fees, trading brokerage
New platforms	Developers, advertisers	Advertisers, developers	Ads and app-store fees; currently loss-making

- **Revenue mix:** Payments still the majority; financial services fastest growing; real-money gaming revenue collapsed after 2025 RMG ban.
- **Users vs payers:** 70 cr users pay almost nothing; lenders, insurers, billers and merchants pay for distribution.
- **Unit economics:** UPI loses money per transaction without MDR; FY26 loss widened to ₹2,792 cr on ads and new bets.
- **Growth levers:** UPI MDR for large merchants, credit cross-sell, insurance, broking scale, Indus Appstore monetisation.

Friction points to discuss

- Home screen cluttered with offers, loans and ads
- Failed or pending UPI payments with slow refunds
- Fraud and fake-screenshot scams hurt merchant trust
- Loan and insurance push feels intrusive to users
- Customer support hard to reach for disputes

Competitors and market

- **UPI apps:** Google Pay, Paytm, Navi, super.money, BHIM, WhatsApp Pay
- **Merchant QR:** Paytm Soundbox, BharatPe, Google Pay for Business
- **Lending and wealth:** Paytm, Groww, Zerodha, Bajaj Finserv, Policybazaar
- **App store:** Google Play, Samsung Galaxy Store
- **Edge:** Largest UPI user and merchant base; trusted brand in Bharat
- **Risk:** 30% cap from Jan 2027, zero MDR, widening losses, IPO timing

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** FY26 revenue ₹7,920 cr (+11%); loss widened to ₹2,792 cr.
- **Apr 2026:** Crossed 70 cr registered users and 5 cr merchants.
- **Mar 2026:** Deferred ~$1.3B OFS-only IPO citing volatility; SEBI nod valid 18 months.
- **Watch:** NPCI 30% cap at 31 Dec 2026, UPI MDR rules, IPO by Mar 2027.

Sources: PhonePe DRHP and RoC filings FY25–FY26, NPCI UPI data, press coverage (Inc42, Outlook Business) 2025–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Google Pay

Google's payments app: UPI leader-challenger in India, Wallet globally

Founded: **Sep 2017 as Tez (India), Google** HQ: **Mountain View; India product hub Bengaluru** Owner/Listed: **Alphabet (NASDAQ: GOOGL)** Revenue: **FY25 ₹1,547 cr India entity (+4%), PAT ₹50 cr**
UPI share: **~33–35% by volume (NPCI, 2026)** Volume: **~7.6B UPI transactions in Jul 2026** India entity: **Google India Digital Services Pvt Ltd**
Head: **Sundar Pichai (CEO); Sharath Bulusu leads Pay product** Global: **Google Wallet/Pay in ~80+ countries; NFC cards**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make paying simple, secure and helpful for everyone, anchored in Google's mission to organise information.
- **Vision:** Be India's default trusted payments and credit layer, and a global wallet for cards, passes and IDs.
- **Core strategy:** Win UPI on simplicity and trust, then layer credit (Credit on UPI, Flex card, loans) via bank partners.
- **Moat:** Android distribution, Google brand trust, fraud ML, and Play/Ads ecosystem integration rather than standalone monetisation.
- **Key bet:** Credit on UPI and partner-led lending; NFC card tap-to-pay testing in India (Feb 2026); UPI Circle for families.
- **Your view:** Google Pay barely earns in India; is it a strategic data and Android asset, or should it monetise harder?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Google Pay
Urban consumers	Android-first, salaried, metro and Tier 1	Want clean, fast, safe payments without clutter	Simple UI, Google trust, strong fraud warnings, rewards and scratch cards
Families and dependents	Parents, teens, elderly without bank accounts	Dependents cannot pay digitally on their own	UPI Circle delegation with limits and approvals, Pocket Money controls
Credit seekers	Young earners with thin credit files	Card approvals slow; small-ticket credit unavailable	Credit on UPI, Flex co-branded card, partner personal and gold loans
Merchants	Kiranas and SMBs via Google Pay for Business	Need free acceptance and visibility to nearby customers	Free QR, SoundPod alerts, integration with Google Maps and Business Profile
Banks and lenders	PSP banks, NBFCs, card issuers	Need low-cost distribution to digital customers	Access to a large engaged base with Google-grade underwriting signals

Product portfolio and metrics

Payments (India)

UPI P2P and P2M	Bank transfers, QR and contact payments
Bills and Recharges	Utilities, mobile, FASTag, credit card bills
UPI Circle	Delegated payments for family members with limits
UPI Lite and Autopay	PIN-less small payments; subscriptions incl. Play Store
Tap to pay cards	NFC card payments, testing in India 2026
North Star	Weekly transacting users with successful payments
Key metrics	UPI share, success rate, P2M share of volume, retention
Guardrails	Fraud rate, NPCI 30% cap, complaint resolution time

Credit and financial services

Credit on UPI	RuPay credit cards and credit lines on UPI
Flex card	Co-branded card for everyday spends, managed in-app
Personal and gold loans	Partner bank and NBFC loans distributed in-app
Google Pay for Business	Merchant app, QR, SoundPod, merchant loans
North Star	Monthly active credit users on Google Pay
Key metrics	Disbursals, card activations, approval rate, partner revenue
Guardrails	Delinquency rate, RBI digital lending compliance, mis-selling complaints

Global (Google Wallet)

Google Wallet	Tap-to-pay cards, passes, tickets, digital IDs
Google Pay checkout	One-click payments on web, Android apps, Play
Pix and local rails	Local real-time rails support in markets like Brazil
North Star	Monthly active wallets with a payment or pass use
Key metrics	Cards provisioned, tap volume, checkout conversion lift
Guardrails	Token fraud, issuer coverage gaps, privacy incidents

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Bills and convenience fees	Users paying bills by card	User (0.5–1% + GST since Feb 2025)	Convenience fee on card bill payments; UPI from bank stays free
Credit distribution	Borrowers and cardholders	Partner banks and NBFCs	Sourcing fees and revenue share on loans and cards
Merchant and biller	Billers, merchants, brands	Billers, brands	Biller commissions, rewards and offers funded by brands
Ecosystem value	Android, Play, Ads users	Advertisers, Play developers	Indirect: payment data improves Ads, Play conversion via UPI

- **Revenue mix:** India entity revenue ₹1,547 cr FY25 is tiny versus Google India gross ads of ~₹34,700 cr.
- **Users vs payers:** Hundreds of millions use free UPI; banks, billers and a few card-bill users actually pay.
- **Unit economics:** Profit halved to ₹50 cr FY25; UPI processing cost unrecovered under zero MDR.
- **Growth levers:** Credit on UPI, UPI MDR for large merchants, NFC cards, ads and Play cross-sell.

Friction points to discuss

- Pending transactions and slow refund resolution
- Little human support; chat-bot dead ends
- Scratch-card rewards shrank, reducing delight
- New card-bill convenience fees surprise users
- Bank server failures blamed on the app

Competitors and market

- **India UPI:** PhonePe (leader), Paytm, Navi, super.money, WhatsApp Pay, BHIM
- **Credit on UPI:** PhonePe, Paytm Postpaid, CRED, bank apps
- **Global wallets:** Apple Pay, Samsung Wallet, PayPal, local wallets
- **Merchant:** Paytm Soundbox, PhonePe SmartSpeaker, BharatPe
- **Edge:** Android distribution, trust, clean UX, Google ML fraud detection
- **Risk:** 30% NPCI cap, zero MDR economics, antitrust scrutiny of Google

Recent news and direction

- **Feb 2026:** Began testing NFC card tap-to-pay in India beyond UPI.
- **May 2026:** PhonePe plus Google Pay UPI share fell below 80% for first time.
- **Feb 2025:** Introduced 0.5–1% convenience fee on card-based bill payments.
- **Watch:** NPCI 30% cap deadline 31 Dec 2026; UPI MDR for large merchants.

Sources: Google India Digital Services RoC filings FY25, NPCI UPI data, press coverage (Storyboard18, Business Today) 2025–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Paytm

Listed payments-plus-credit super app rebuilding after its bank's collapse

Founded: **2010 by Vijay Shekhar Sharma (One97, 2000)** HQ: **Noida, Uttar Pradesh** Owner/Listed: **One97 Communications; NSE/BSE listed Nov 2021** Revenue: **FY26 ₹8,437 cr (+22% YoY)**
Profit: **FY26 PAT ₹552 cr, first full-year profit** Latest qtr: **Q1 FY27 rev ₹2,448 cr (+28%), PAT ₹220 cr** UPI share: **~8% by volume (NPCI, mid-2026)** CEO: **Vijay Shekhar Sharma, MD and CEO**
Regulatory: **PPBL licence cancelled Apr 2026; PA licence Nov 2025**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Bring half a billion Indians into the mainstream economy through payments and financial services.
- **Vision:** Be India's AI-first financial super app: payments as the hook, merchant devices and credit as the profit engine.
- **Super-app lesson:** Shrank from everything-app (ticketing sold to Zomato 2024, PPBL shut) to a focused payments-plus-finance super app.
- **Moat:** Soundbox and card-machine base with crores of merchants, brand recall, and full PA licences regained 2025.
- **Key bets:** Merchant and personal loan distribution (+45% YoY), Postpaid credit on UPI, AI app with Perplexity, AI soundboxes.
- **Your view:** Is Paytm's future a super app, or a merchant-payments-and-credit company that also has a consumer app?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Paytm
Device merchants	Kiranas, shops with Soundbox and POS	Need instant payment confirmation and working capital	Soundbox audio alerts, card machines, merchant loans on transaction history
Online merchants	E-commerce, apps, utilities	Need reliable gateway and high success rates	Paytm Payment Gateway back after RBI PA licence; bundled with lending
Consumers	UPI users, Tier 2+, long-time wallet users	Want payments, bills, travel and offers in one place	Familiar brand, cashback, bills, travel, gold, UPI Lite in one app
Borrowers	Thin-file salaried and self-employed	Small-ticket credit hard to get from banks	Personal loans and Postpaid credit on UPI via partner lenders
Lenders and AMCs	Banks, NBFCs, insurers, AMCs	Need low-cost digital customer acquisition and collections	Paytm sources, underwrites with data, and supports collections; paid per disbursal

Product portfolio and metrics

Payments

Paytm UPI	Consumer UPI, UPI Lite, RuPay credit on UPI
Soundbox and Card Machine	Subscription devices for offline merchants
Payment Gateway	Online and offline PA via Paytm Payments Services
Bills and Recharges	Utilities, FASTag, credit card bill payments
North Star	Monthly transacting merchants on Paytm devices
Key metrics	Merchant GMV (₹7.1 lakh cr Q1 FY27), device subscriptions, UPI share
Guardrails	Payment failure rate, KYC/AML compliance breaches, device churn

Financial services distribution

Merchant loans	Working capital loans to device merchants via partners
Personal loans	Partner-funded loans to app users
Paytm Postpaid	Credit line on UPI, relaunched Sep 2025
Paytm Money and Insurance	Stock broking, mutual funds, insurance distribution
North Star	Monthly disbursals sourced through Paytm
Key metrics	Disbursal value, take rate, repeat borrowers, collection efficiency
Guardrails	Partner portfolio NPAs, FLDG exposure, RBI digital lending compliance

Super-app and AI

Travel	Flights, trains, buses booking
Digital gold and rewards	Gold-coin rewards and gold investments
AI assistant	Perplexity-powered search and money insights in app
AI Soundbox	Merchant insights, translation, business agent features
North Star	Weekly active users using two or more services
Key metrics	Cross-category usage, AI query engagement, travel GMV
Guardrails	App clutter, contribution margin per category, marketing spend

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Payment services	Merchants and consumers	Merchants (MDR, device fees)	Soundbox subscriptions, card/PG MDR; Q1 FY27 ₹1,384 cr (+33%)
Financial services	Borrowers, investors, insurance buyers	Partner lenders, AMCs, insurers	Sourcing and collection fees; Q1 FY27 ₹814 cr (+45%)
Marketing services	Travel bookers, advertisers	Airlines, brands, advertisers	Commissions on travel, ads, deals
Consumer fees	Users paying bills or recharges	User	Small platform fees on some recharges and card bills

- **Revenue mix:** Q1 FY27: payments ~57%, financial services ~33%, rest marketing; lending is the fastest-growing line.
- **Users vs payers:** Consumers mostly pay nothing; merchants pay for devices, lenders pay for distribution.
- **Unit economics:** EBITDA margin 8% Q1 FY27 versus FY25 loss of ₹1,506 cr; marketing and ESOP costs cut.
- **Growth levers:** Device merchant base, credit distribution, gateway licence restored, UPI MDR for large merchants, AI upsell.
- **Lesson:** Regulatory trust is a product feature: PPBL compliance failures erased wallet and bank businesses.

Friction points to discuss

- Brand trust damaged by Payments Bank shutdown
- Cluttered home screen from super-app legacy
- Wallet and FASTag migration confused existing users
- Aggressive loan and offer pushes in app
- Support slow for failed transactions and refunds

Competitors and market

- **Consumer UPI:** PhonePe, Google Pay, Navi, super.money, WhatsApp Pay
- **Merchant devices:** PhonePe SmartSpeaker, BharatPe, Pine Labs, Razorpay POS
- **Lending:** PhonePe, Bajaj Finserv, Navi, KreditBee, bank apps
- **Super app:** Tata Neu, Jio Financial, Amazon Pay, MakeMyTrip
- **Edge:** Profitable, listed, largest device-merchant base, full PA licences
- **Risk:** RBI scrutiny history, partner-lending credit cycles, UPI share stuck ~8%

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q1 FY27: revenue +28% to ₹2,448 cr, record EBITDA ₹203 cr.
- **May 2026:** First full-year profit: FY26 PAT ₹552 cr on ₹8,437 cr revenue.
- **Apr 2026:** RBI cancelled Paytm Payments Bank licence citing governance lapses.
- **Watch:** UPI MDR rules, Postpaid scale-up, 30% cap reshuffling UPI share.

Sources: One97 Communications shareholder letters FY26 and Q1 FY27, RBI and NPCI data, press coverage 2024–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

WhatsApp Pay

UPI payments and bill pay inside India's most-used messaging app

Launched: **Nov 2020 in India (pilot 2018), Meta** HQ: **Menlo Park; India ops Gurugram/Mumbai** Owner/Listed: **Meta Platforms (NASDAQ: META)**
Revenue: **Not disclosed; no direct payment fees (est.)** Volume: **167.9M UPI txns, ₹12,957 cr (Jul 2026)** UPI share: **<1% by volume; #8 UPI app**
Reach: **500M+ WhatsApp users in India; cap lifted Dec 2024** Head: **Kunal Shah, global head of WhatsApp (Jun 2026)** Global: **Brazil (Pix, cards), Singapore business payments**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make sending money as easy as sending a message, inside the conversations Indians already have.
- **Vision:** Turn WhatsApp into India's commerce and service layer: chat, discover, pay, get support in one thread.
- **Core strategy:** Payments as an enabler of Business Messaging monetisation, not a standalone profit centre.
- **Lesson:** Regulation shapes distribution: NPCI caps (4 cr, then 10 cr users) delayed scale until incumbents locked in habit.
- **Key bets:** Bill pay via Bharat Connect (Sep 2026), in-chat business checkout, Meta's $900M CRED stake, Kunal Shah leadership.
- **Your view:** Should WhatsApp chase UPI share, or own conversational commerce and let any UPI app complete payment?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose WhatsApp Pay
Chat-first users	Families, friends splitting or sending money	Switching apps to pay breaks the conversation	Pay inside the chat with UPI, no new app needed
Bill payers	Households paying utilities, cards, loans	Remembering due dates across many biller sites	22,700+ billers via Bharat Connect, reminders in a familiar app
Small businesses	Kiranas, D2C sellers on WhatsApp Business	Orders in chat but payments via separate links	Catalogue, order and UPI checkout in one conversation
Large enterprises	Telcos, airlines, banks, e-commerce	Low engagement on emails, app notifications ignored	Business API messages with in-chat payments convert better
Advertisers	Brands running click-to-WhatsApp ads	Ad clicks drop off before purchase	Ad to chat to payment closes the loop, measurable on Meta

Product portfolio and metrics

Consumer payments

UPI P2P in chat	Send money to contacts from the chat composer
UPI QR scan	Pay any merchant UPI QR
Bill Payments	Utilities, FASTag, insurance, cards, loans via Bharat Connect
North Star	Monthly transacting users among India WhatsApp users
Key metrics	Payment activation rate, repeat payers, txns per user, success rate
Guardrails	Scam/fraud reports, chat experience clutter, NPCI compliance

Monetisation layer

Business Messaging API	Per-message pricing for marketing, utility, auth messages
Click-to-WhatsApp ads	Facebook and Instagram ads opening a chat
Meta AI in chat	AI assistant for discovery and support
North Star	Business messaging revenue per India active business
Key metrics	Paid conversations, ad-to-chat conversion, AI-assisted orders
Guardrails	User opt-outs, message fatigue, privacy and data-localisation issues

Business payments

Payments on WhatsApp Business	In-chat checkout via UPI apps, cards, netbanking
Catalogues and Carts	Browse and order products within chat
Payment gateway partners	Razorpay, PayU integrations for enterprises
Flows	Forms and bookings inside conversations
North Star	Business conversations ending in a completed payment
Key metrics	Checkout conversion, paid message volume, active paying businesses
Guardrails	Spam complaints, business block rates, refund disputes

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
P2P and bill payments	Consumers	No one directly (free UPI)	Engagement and retention play; possible biller commissions
Business messaging	Enterprises and SMBs	Businesses	Per-message fees on WhatsApp Business Platform
Click-to-WhatsApp ads	Brands and sellers	Advertisers	Ad spend on Facebook/Instagram driving chats
Commerce checkout	Businesses selling in chat	Merchants via PG partners	Gateway MDR goes to partners; Meta gains conversion data

- **Revenue mix:** Payments revenue negligible; value flows to Meta's business messaging and ads (Family of Apps).
- **Users vs payers:** 500M+ users pay nothing; businesses and advertisers pay Meta for conversations.
- **Unit economics:** UPI costs absorbed as customer acquisition for messaging; no standalone P&L disclosed.
- **Growth levers:** Bill pay habit, in-chat checkout, Meta AI commerce, CRED partnership, Kunal Shah's fintech playbook.

Friction points to discuss

- Payments tucked behind rupee icon, low discoverability
- Users already loyal to PhonePe or Google Pay
- Scams in chats erode trust in payments
- Bank linking and UPI PIN setup feel cumbersome
- Few rewards versus cashback-driven rivals

Competitors and market

- **UPI apps:** PhonePe, Google Pay, Paytm, Navi, super.money, CRED
- **Conversational commerce:** Instagram shops, Google Business messages, Telegram
- **Bill pay:** PhonePe, CRED, Amazon Pay, bank apps
- **Global:** Pix apps in Brazil, WeChat Pay, Line Pay as models
- **Edge:** Unmatched daily engagement and social graph; zero acquisition cost
- **Risk:** Late to habit, privacy/antitrust scrutiny, payments seen as non-core

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Launched bill payments via Bharat Connect with 22,722 billers.
- **Aug 2026:** July UPI volume up ~125% YoY; overtook CRED and Amazon Pay.
- **Jun 2026:** Meta invests $900M in CRED; Kunal Shah named WhatsApp global head.
- **Watch:** Whether 30% cap redistributes share to WhatsApp; in-chat commerce traction.

Sources: NPCI UPI app data, Meta newsroom, press coverage (Business Today, TechCrunch, Outlook) 2024–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Groww

India's largest retail broker: stocks, F&O, mutual funds, credit, one app

Founded: **2016, Bengaluru; Lalit Keshre and three ex-Flipkart cofounders** Owner/Listed: **Billionbrains Garage Ventures; NSE/BSE listed Nov 2025** IPO: **₹6,632 cr at ₹100; 17.6x subscribed**
Revenue: **FY26 ₹4,645 cr (+19%); PAT ₹2,083 cr** Latest quarter: **Q1 FY27 rev ₹1,501 cr (+66%), PAT ₹735 cr** Active clients: **1.34 cr NSE active, Sep 2026 (#1)**
Market share: **29.2% of NSE active clients (Zerodha 14.7%)** Customer assets: **₹3.6 lakh cr, Q1 FY27 (+38% YoY)** CEO: **Lalit Keshre (cofounder, MD and CEO)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make financial services simple, transparent and accessible so every Indian can invest, trade and borrow from one app.
- **Vision:** Become the default full-stack money app for India's next 100 million investors, from first SIP to wealth management.
- **Core strategy:** Win acquisition with simple UX and Tier 2-3 reach, then cross-sell MTF, F&O, credit, AMC and wealth to raise ARPU.
- **Moat:** Largest active base (29% NSE share) and low-cost organic acquisition; brand trusted by first-time investors.
- **Key bet:** De-risk from SEBI F&O curbs: grow MTF, loans against securities, commodities, Groww AMC and Fisdom-led affluent wealth.
- **Your view:** Is Groww a broker priced like a platform? Can it earn wealth-style margins without leaning on derivatives?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Groww
First-time investors	Young, Tier 2-3 salaried, starting SIPs	Finance feels complex, jargon-heavy and untrustworthy for small amounts	Clean onboarding, zero-commission direct mutual funds, simple language and mass brand recall
Active traders	Retail F&O, intraday and commodity traders	Need fast execution, charts, margin and low costs during volatile sessions	Integrated F&O, MTF and commodity trading in the same app they already use
Affluent investors	HNI and mass-affluent with larger portfolios	Fragmented holdings, little advice, liquidity locked in investments	Fisdom wealth, loans against securities and MTF, without leaving the app
Borrowers	Existing users needing personal or secured credit	Slow bank loans, need liquidity without selling investments	Pre-approved personal loans and LAS from the in-house NBFC, fully digital
Fund partners (supply)	AMCs, exchanges, Groww AMC itself	Need cheap distribution to millions of new retail investors	Biggest retail funnel; strong SIP flows; own AMC captures fund economics

Product portfolio and metrics

Broking and trading

Stocks and ETFs	Cash-market equity investing and intraday trading
F&O	Equity index and stock derivatives; largest revenue line today
Commodities	MCX commodity derivatives, a fast-growing new segment
MTF	Margin trading facility, interest-earning leveraged delivery buys
915 / Terminal	Pro trading tools for active traders
North Star	Monthly active traders placing 3+ orders
Key metrics	Orders per user, F&O share, MTF book, ARPU, active-client share
Guardrails	Retail F&O loss rates, outages during peak, complaints per lakh clients

Wealth and asset management

Mutual funds and SIPs	Direct plans, zero commission; core acquisition hook
Groww AMC	Own mutual fund house (ex-Indiabulls AMC), AUM ~2.4x YoY
Fisdom / Groww Wealth	Acquired ~$150M; advisory and PMS for affluent users
Groww Pay / UPI	UPI payments to stay in daily habit loop
North Star	Customer assets on Groww growing via net inflows
Key metrics	SIP book, AUM, affluent users, assets per user, AMC market share
Guardrails	Redemption rate, mis-selling complaints, AMC/wealth losses before FY28 breakeven

Credit

Personal loans	Digital unsecured loans from Groww's NBFC
Loan against securities	Borrow against shares and mutual funds without selling
Credit marketplace	Partner loans and cards for broader reach
North Star	Healthy disbursements to existing investors
Key metrics	Disbursements (₹388 cr Q4 FY26), yield, cross-sell rate
Guardrails	GNPA, delinquency by cohort, collections complaints

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Broking (F&O, stocks, commodities)	Retail traders and investors	Traders, per order	Flat ~₹20 or 0.1% per order; F&O ~55% of Q4 FY26 revenue
Interest income (MTF, float, LAS)	Leveraged traders, borrowers	Borrowing users	Interest on margin book, client float and secured loans; ~22% of revenue
Asset management (Groww AMC)	Mutual fund investors	Fund investors via expense ratio	Total expense ratio on AUM; still loss-making but scaling fast
Wealth (Fisdom)	Affluent and HNI users	Clients and product manufacturers	Advisory fees, PMS/AIF distribution commissions
Consumer credit	Existing Groww users	Borrowers	Net interest margin and processing fees from in-house NBFC

- **Revenue mix:** Q4 FY26: equity derivatives 55%, stocks 16%, float 8%, PL+LAS 7%, MTF 5%, commodities 4%; derivatives share falling.
- **Users vs payers:** Most MF investors pay nothing; a minority of F&O and MTF users generate the bulk of revenue.
- **Unit economics:** Q1 FY27 EBITDA margin ~68%; organic acquisition keeps CAC low; operating leverage drives profit growth.
- **Growth levers:** MTF and commodities, affluent wealth via Fisdom, AMC scale, secured credit; reduce dependence on F&O.
- **Regulation:** SEBI F&O curbs since Nov 2024 cut retail derivative traders ~20% in FY26; Groww hurt less than peers.

Friction points to discuss

- App outages during market open hurt trader trust
- Easy F&O access nudges novices into loss-making trades
- Advanced charting weaker than Zerodha Kite for pros
- Customer support slow during disputes and failed orders
- Too many cross-sell prompts clutter a simple app

Competitors and market

- **Discount brokers:** Zerodha, Angel One, Upstox, Dhan, INDmoney
- **Bank brokers:** ICICI Direct, HDFC Sky, Kotak Neo, SBI Securities
- **MF / wealth:** PhonePe Wealth, Paytm Money, ET Money, Kuvera
- **Credit:** Bajaj Finserv, banks, fintech lenders, LAMF players
- **Edge:** Top active base, low CAC, fastest net adds, listed currency for M&A
- **Risk:** Further SEBI curbs, market downturn, rich valuation, credit losses

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Added ~1.01 lakh NSE active clients, ~63% of industry net adds; 29.2% share
- **Jul 2026:** Q1 FY27: revenue ₹1,501 cr (+66%), PAT ₹735 cr (+94%), MTF and commodities lead
- **Nov 2025:** IPO lists at 12-14% premium; market cap briefly tops ₹1 lakh cr
- **Watch:** Fisdom integration, AMC breakeven, credit quality, F&O share, next SEBI derivatives moves

Sources: Billionbrains (Groww) results FY26 and Q1 FY27, NSE active-client data Sep 2026, SEBI FY26 F&O study, Inc42/Business Standard. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Zerodha

Bootstrapped discount broker that built India's retail trading habit, profitably

Founded: **2010, Bengaluru; Nithin and Nikhil Kamath** Owner/Listed: **Private, bootstrapped, founder-owned; no IPO plans** Revenue: **FY26 ~₹8,847 cr (flat YoY; FY24 ₹9,993 cr)**
Net profit: **FY26 ₹4,283 cr (+1.2% YoY)** Active clients: **67.9 lakh NSE active, Sep 2026 (#2)** Market share: **14.7% of NSE active clients; steadily declining** Client assets: **~₹9.05 lakh cr AUC, FY26**
CEO: **Nithin Kamath (founder and CEO)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Break every barrier traders and investors face in India: cost, support and technology.
- **Values:** No ads, no spam, no dark patterns; discourage overtrading; build for decades; customer trust over short-term growth.
- **Core strategy:** Flat-fee broking plus best-in-class tools (Kite, Console, Coin); grow by word of mouth and Varsity education.
- **Moat:** Trust and pro-trader loyalty, lean team, 45%+ net margins, ecosystem via Rainmatter and Kite APIs.
- **Key bet:** Diversify beyond F&O: Zerodha Fund House, MTF, merchant banking for new-age IPOs, US investing on Kite.
- **Your view:** Is no-marketing still a moat when Groww wins new investors 2x faster? Should Zerodha advertise, list, or stay put?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Zerodha
Active traders	Intraday and F&O traders, mostly metro	Need reliable, fast platform with low costs and pro tools	Kite stability, charts, APIs, flat ₹20 pricing and long track record
Long-term investors	Salaried equity and direct-MF investors	Hidden fees, mis-selling and spammy upsells at bank brokers	Free equity delivery, direct mutual funds via Coin, honest no-push brand
Algo / API developers	Quant traders and fintech builders	Few brokers offer stable, documented trading APIs	Kite Connect APIs and partner ecosystem (Streak, Sensibull, smallcase)
Fintech partners (supply)	Rainmatter startups, smallcase, Sensibull, Tijori	Need distribution and broker integration to reach investors	Access to Zerodha's base via Kite integrations and Rainmatter capital
Fund investors	Passive, low-cost index fund seekers	High expense ratios and complex active fund choices	Zerodha Fund House: simple, low-cost passive index funds and ETFs

Product portfolio and metrics

Trading platforms

Kite	Flagship web and mobile trading platform; adding MF, US investing
Kite Connect	Paid trading APIs for algo traders and partners
Console	Back office: P&L, tax reports, holdings analytics
MTF	Margin trading book ~₹9,000 cr; ~10% of revenue
North Star	Monthly active traders retained 12+ months
Key metrics	Orders per active, F&O and cash ADTO share, MTF book, uptime
Guardrails	Order latency, outages, retail F&O loss share, MTF risk exposure

Education and ecosystem

Varsity	Free market education modules and app
Rainmatter	Fintech, climate and health investments; foundation grants
Nudge / Kill switch	Risk nudges and self-imposed trading limits
Zerodha Capital	NBFC for loans against securities
North Star	Investor trust measured by referral and NPS
Key metrics	Varsity users, organic signups, partner app usage
Guardrails	Complaint ratio, data breaches, regulatory actions

Investing and asset management

Coin	Direct mutual funds, zero commission, SIPs
Zerodha Fund House	Passive index funds JV with smallcase; FY26 revenue ₹17 cr
Zerodha Gold / bonds	Sovereign gold bonds, G-secs, T-bills, IPO applications
North Star	Long-term investor assets held on Zerodha
Key metrics	AUC, SIP count, Fund House AUM, investor-only share
Guardrails	Churn to rivals, fund tracking error, fee creep

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Brokerage	F&O and intraday traders	Traders	Flat ₹20 or 0.03% per order; equity delivery free; ₹2,738 cr FY26
Interest income	MTF users, client float	Borrowing clients; float yield	Interest on MTF book and margins/float; ~₹2,269 cr FY26
Account maintenance (AMC)	All demat holders	Clients with holdings	Annual demat charge; ~₹180 cr, about 2% of revenue
Fund House and NBFC	Index fund investors, LAS borrowers	Investors via TER; borrowers	Expense ratio on AUM; interest on loans against securities

- **Revenue mix:** Brokerage and interest dominate; F&O-linked income still the profit engine despite SEBI curbs and lost exchange rebates (₹400 cr).
- **Users vs payers:** Long-term investors pay little; a small cohort of active F&O traders generates most brokerage.
- **Unit economics:** Near-zero CAC (no ads, ~30% referrals historically); ~48% net margin; lean team keeps cost per client tiny.
- **Growth levers:** MTF, Fund House scale, merchant banking, US investing, wealth for affluent; win back share from Groww.
- **Headwinds:** SEBI F&O rules from Nov 2024 cut F&O activity 20-30%; FY26 lost ~10 lakh active clients.

Friction points to discuss

- Kite feels intimidating for first-time investors versus Groww
- Separate apps (Kite, Coin, Console) fragment the journey
- Support is ticket-based and slow for urgent issues
- Account opening and re-KYC still clunky for some
- Few hand-holding or advisory features for beginners

Competitors and market

- **Discount brokers:** Groww, Angel One, Upstox, Dhan, Fyers
- **Bank brokers:** ICICI Direct, HDFC Sky, Kotak Neo
- **Wealth / MF:** Groww, PhonePe Wealth, INDmoney, Paytm Money
- **Pro trader tools:** Dhan, Fyers, Sensibull-style option platforms
- **Edge:** Trust, pro-grade tech, highest profit margins, no outside investors to please
- **Risk:** Share loss to Groww, F&O dependence, key-person risk, slow diversification

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** NSE active clients 67.9 lakh, 14.7% share; Angel One close behind
- **Aug 2026:** FY26: profit ₹4,283 cr (+1%), revenue flat; Kamath flags MTF contagion risk
- **Apr 2026:** Applies for SEBI merchant banking licence to manage new-age IPOs
- **Watch:** Third place threat from Angel One, US investing on Kite, Fund House scale

Sources: Zerodha FY26 financials via Inc42/YourStory, NSE active-client data Sep 2026, SEBI FY26 F&O study, Nithin Kamath posts. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

smallcase

B2B2C platform for model portfolios of stocks and ETFs via brokers

Founded: **2015, Bengaluru; Vasanth Kamath, Anugrah Shrivastava, Rohan Gupta** Owner/Listed: **Private; Peak XV largest external holder (~16%)**
Funding: **~$120M raised; $50M Series D, Mar 2025** Valuation: **~$285-290M (est., Series D)** Revenue: **FY25 ₹106 cr (+57%); net loss ₹34 cr**
Users: **10M+ investors; ₹1.2 lakh cr transacted (FY25)** Partners: **250+ brokers, advisors, managers, wealth platforms** CEO: **Vasanth Kamath (cofounder and CEO)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make thematic, rules-based portfolio investing simple, transparent and accessible to every Indian investor.
- **Vision:** Become the infrastructure layer for managed portfolios in India across stocks, ETFs, mutual funds and global assets.
- **Core strategy:** B2B2C: plug into brokers via Gateway APIs; investors buy portfolios in their own demat accounts, no new KYC.
- **Moat:** Distribution across most major brokers plus 250+ SEBI-registered managers; two-sided network hard to replicate.
- **Key bet:** Expand product shelf: MF model portfolios, US stocks via GIFT City, loans against mutual funds, fixed income.
- **Your view:** If Zerodha and Groww build in-house baskets, does a broker-dependent B2B2C model keep its distribution?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose smallcase
DIY investors	Salaried investors wanting curated stock baskets	Picking and rebalancing stocks is time-consuming and confusing	Themed portfolios with one-click rebalance, held in their own demat
Portfolio managers (supply)	SEBI RIAs and research analysts	Hard to distribute research and execute for retail at scale	Ready distribution, subscription billing, execution via partner brokers
Brokers (supply)	Zerodha, Groww-style brokers, banks, wealth apps	Need sticky investing products to raise engagement and AUC	Plug-and-play Gateway API adds managed portfolios without building them
Borrowers	MF investors needing short-term liquidity	Selling funds breaks compounding and triggers tax	Digital loans against mutual funds, from ~9.99% interest
Affluent investors	Investors wanting global and multi-asset exposure	Global investing is fragmented and paperwork-heavy	US stocks via GIFT City and MF portfolios in one place

Product portfolio and metrics

Investment and credit products

smallcases	Thematic, rules-based stock and ETF model portfolios
Windmill Capital	In-house SEBI-registered manager running free and paid smallcases
MF model portfolios	Curated mutual fund baskets, launched Jun 2026
Global smallcases	US stock investing via GIFT City, Feb 2026
Loan against mutual funds	Pledge MFs for ₹25k-₹5 cr credit line, lender partners
North Star	Investors holding an active portfolio for 12+ months
Key metrics	Subscriptions, AUM in smallcases, rebalance compliance, repeat purchases
Guardrails	Underperformance vs benchmark, mis-selling complaints, unsubscribe rate

Platform and infrastructure

Gateway	APIs letting any app transact via user's broker account
Publisher platform	Tools for managers to create, price and manage smallcases
Broker integrations	Investing inside major partner broker apps and websites
North Star	Transaction value flowing through partner integrations
Key metrics	Active partners, transactions per partner, API uptime, revenue per broker
Guardrails	Partner concentration, order failures, data security incidents

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Broker transaction fees	Investors buying smallcases on broker apps	Partner brokers	Fee per transaction or share of brokerage; bulk of revenue
Manager subscriptions	Investors in paid smallcases	Investors; smallcase takes a cut	Subscription fee split between manager and platform
Windmill and research	Investors in in-house portfolios	Investors	Subscription fees on paid Windmill smallcases
Lending distribution	LAMF borrowers	Lending partners	Distribution commission and processing fees on loans

- **Revenue mix:** Mostly broker transaction fees; subscriptions, research and lending distribution growing. FY26 results not yet public.
- **Users vs payers:** Investors often pay nothing directly; brokers and managers pay to access the investor base.
- **Unit economics:** FY25 EBITDA loss narrowed to ~₹9 cr; asset-light, but revenue depends on market cycle volumes.
- **Growth levers:** New asset classes, more partners, paid manager marketplace, credit, global investing.
- **Market cycle:** SEBI F&O curbs push traders to long-term products; weaker markets since late 2024 hurt volumes.

Friction points to discuss

- Users must log in to broker for each order
- Rebalance updates ignored, portfolios drift from model
- Paid manager quality and returns hard to judge
- Minimum investment high for portfolios with pricey stocks
- Fragmented experience across many partner broker apps

Competitors and market

- **Broker baskets:** Zerodha baskets, Groww, Dhan, Angel One in-house portfolios
- **Wealth platforms:** INDmoney, Fisdom (Groww), ET Money, Kuvera
- **Mutual funds / PMS:** Index funds, thematic MFs, PMS houses
- **Advisory:** SEBI RIAs on direct platforms, Liquide, Sahi
- **Edge:** Broker-neutral rails plus largest manager network; investors keep own demat
- **Risk:** Broker disintermediation, prolonged losses, market downturn, SEBI advisory rules

Recent news and direction

- **Jun 2026:** Launches mutual fund model portfolios, expanding beyond stocks and ETFs
- **Feb 2026:** Opens US stock investing via GIFT City; global themes planned
- **Mar 2025:** Raises $50M Series D led by Elev8; total ~$120M raised
- **Watch:** FY26 profitability, broker partner retention, IPO readiness, uptake of new asset classes

Sources: smallcase press releases, Entrackr FY25 financials, Moneycontrol/Business Standard funding coverage, ET and BusinessLine 2026. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Zomato

India's #1 food delivery app, flagship of listed Eternal Ltd

Founded: **2008 as Foodiebay, Deepinder Goyal and Pankaj Chaddah** HQ: **Gurugram, Haryana** Owner/Listed: **Eternal Ltd (renamed from Zomato Ltd, 2025); NSE/BSE**
Revenue: **Group FY26 ₹54,364 cr (+169%); PAT ₹366 cr** Food delivery: **Q1 FY27 NOV ₹10,769 cr (+20%), 5.6% adj EBITDA** Users: **27.2M monthly transacting customers (Q1 FY27)**
Supply: **328K restaurants, 638K delivery partners (Q1 FY27)** Market share: **~57% of food delivery GOV vs Swiggy ~43%** Leaders: **Eternal CEO Albinder Dhindsa; Food CEO Aditya Mangla**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Better food for more people: make food delivery cheaper, faster and more reliable across India.
- **Vision:** Eternal as a multi-business consumer platform: Zomato (food), Blinkit (quick commerce), District (going out), Hyperpure (B2B supplies).
- **Core strategy:** Profitable growth: ~20% NOV growth with rising margins, funded by platform fees, ads and Gold, recycled into targeted discounts.
- **Moat:** Largest restaurant selection and densest delivery fleet create liquidity; ad-tech and data let it monetise restaurants beyond commission.
- **Key bet:** Bistro 10-minute kitchens and selective discounting to counter low-commission rivals like Rapido's Ownly and Swiggy's Toing without margin war.
- **Your view:** Is food delivery now a cash cow funding Blinkit, and does that leave Zomato exposed to zero-commission disruptors?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Zomato
Urban habitual orderers	Metro professionals ordering 4+ times monthly	Rising fees, inconsistent ETAs, cold food, opaque surge charges	Widest selection, reliable delivery, Gold free-delivery perks, trusted ratings and reviews
Value seekers / Tier-2	Students, young earners, smaller cities	Menu markups plus platform, delivery and packaging fees make orders expensive	Targeted discounts, deals and broad restaurant coverage beyond metros
Restaurants	328K partners, cloud kitchens to QSR chains	18-28% effective commissions, forced discounts, ad spend pressure, deductions	Access to India's largest demand pool; ads and analytics drive incremental orders
Delivery partners	638K gig riders, mostly two-wheeler	Volatile per-order pay, heat and rain risk, limited social security	Flexible hours, high order density, insurance and instant payouts
Advertisers / brands	Restaurants and F&B brands buying visibility	Hard to prove ROI on sponsored listings	Intent-rich placements at moment of ordering, measurable order lift

Product portfolio and metrics

Food delivery

Zomato app	Restaurant discovery and on-demand food delivery across hundreds of Indian cities
Zomato Gold	Paid membership: free delivery and discounts above order thresholds
Bistro	10-minute food from own kitchens, standalone app
Zomato for Enterprise	Corporate meal allowances and office food ordering
Zomato Ads	Sponsored listings and banners sold to restaurants
North Star	Weekly delivered orders arriving on time and as ordered
Key metrics	NOV, MTC, order frequency, AOV, adj EBITDA % NOV, Gold penetration
Guardrails	Restaurant churn, delivery partner earnings/hour, complaint rate, cancellation rate

Restaurant and supply tools

Restaurant Partner app	Menu, orders, payouts, promotions and ratings management
Hyperpure	B2B ingredient and kitchen supplies for restaurants (Eternal)
Delivery Partner app	Rider onboarding, order allocation, earnings and insurance
North Star	Active restaurants growing profitable online sales on Zomato
Key metrics	Active restaurants, ad revenue per restaurant, payout accuracy, rider utilisation
Guardrails	Commission disputes, forced-discount complaints, rider attrition

Group context (Eternal)

Blinkit	Quick commerce; now Eternal's largest revenue line
District	Going-out: dining reservations, movies, events tickets
North Star	Cross-app customers transacting across two or more Eternal services
Key metrics	Cross-sell rate, shared rider fleet utilisation, group adj EBITDA
Guardrails	Food delivery margin not diluted to fund Blinkit

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Restaurant commissions	Restaurants listed on Zomato	Restaurants	Percentage of order value, typically ~18-25% plus payment gateway fees
Customer fees	Ordering customers	Customers	Platform fee ₹14.90/order, delivery fees, ₹5-20 cash-on-delivery fee
Advertising	Restaurants and brands	Restaurants, F&B brands	Cost-per-click sponsored listings and banner placements
Zomato Gold	Frequent orderers	Members	Paid membership fee for free delivery and discounts

- **Revenue mix:** Food delivery revenue ~₹3,100 cr/quarter; commissions dominate, with ads and platform fees the fastest-growing high-margin lines.
- **Users vs payers:** Customers pay food plus fees; restaurants pay commission and ads; riders paid per order from both pools.
- **Unit economics:** Adj EBITDA 5.6% of NOV in Q1 FY27; ~₹600 cr quarterly profit, among world's most profitable food delivery businesses.
- **Growth levers:** Tier-2 penetration, cheaper Bistro/value formats, Gold frequency, ad yield, enterprise ordering, faster delivery.
- **Reporting shift:** From Q1 FY27 Eternal reports Net Order Value (after discounts) instead of GOV, complicating Swiggy comparisons.

Friction points to discuss

- Stacked platform, delivery and COD fees feel hidden
- Menu prices higher than restaurant dine-in prices
- ETA promises missed during rain and peaks
- Refund and missing-item disputes are slow
- Restaurants resent forced discounts and deductions

Competitors and market

- **Duopoly rival:** Swiggy Food (~43% share), Swiggy Toing budget delivery
- **Disruptors:** Rapido Ownly zero-commission, Swish 10-min food, Flipkart food pilot, ONDC
- **Restaurant direct:** Domino's, McDonald's own apps; Thrive and WhatsApp ordering
- **Quick food:** Swiggy Bolt, Zepto Cafe, Blinkit-adjacent snacking
- **Edge:** Scale, ~5.6% margins, ad engine, Eternal cash to outlast price wars
- **Risk:** Commission backlash, gig-worker rules, GST on delivery, zero-commission entrants

Recent news and direction

- **Oct 2026:** GST Council proposes 5% GST on e-commerce delivery services, no input tax credit.
- **Sep 2026:** Introduced ₹5-20 cash-on-delivery fee; Aug cut 250 support roles, shut Hyderabad centre.
- **Aug 2026:** Bengaluru restaurants' boycott deferred after Zomato agreed opt-in, OTP-approved discount campaigns.
- **Watch:** Can Zomato keep ~20% growth and margins as Ownly, Toing, Flipkart chase price-sensitive users?

Sources: Eternal Q1 FY27 and FY26 results, earnings call coverage (MediaNama, Kotak Neo), press reports 2025-26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Swiggy

India's No.2 food delivery app inside a multi-service convenience platform

Founded: **2014, Bengaluru; Majety, Jaiminy, Reddy** Owner/Listed: **Swiggy Ltd, NSE/BSE listed Nov 2024** Revenue: **FY26 ₹23,053 cr (+51%); net loss ₹4,154 cr**
Food delivery: **Q1 FY27 GOV ₹9,490 cr (+17.4%), 3.1% EBITDA** Users: **19.2M food MTUs; 27.5M platform MTUs (Q1 FY27)** Supply: **2.7 lakh restaurants, 6.5 lakh delivery partners**
Market share: **~43% of food delivery vs Zomato ~57%** Leaders: **Sriharsha Majety MD & Group CEO; Rohit Kapoor, Food** Cash: **~₹14,400 cr, debt-free after Dec 2025 QIP**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Elevate the quality of life of the urban consumer by offering unparalleled convenience.
- **Vision:** One app, one membership (Swiggy One) for food, groceries and dining out, unlocking the next 100M food users.
- **Core strategy:** Value-led food growth: affordability formats like Toing and Bolt widen the funnel while profitable food funds Instamart.
- **FY31 targets:** ₹2.5 lakh cr group GOV and ₹10,000 cr adj EBITDA; food ~₹5,000 cr EBITDA on 2.5-3.5x GOV.
- **Moat:** Swiggy One cross-category membership, deep Bengaluru/South density and a shared fleet across food, Instamart and Dineout.
- **Your view:** Should Swiggy fight Zomato for share in food, or accept No.2 and maximise cash for quick commerce?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Swiggy
Urban regulars	Metro professionals, frequent multi-category orderers	Fee stacking and app prices above restaurant menus	Swiggy One benefits across food, Instamart and Dineout; strong South India coverage
Budget eaters	Students, first-jobbers, Tier-2 users	Regular food delivery feels too expensive for everyday meals	Toing budget app and value menus; two of three Toing users are new
Restaurants	2.7 lakh partners, small eateries to chains	High commissions, unapproved discount campaigns, payout deductions	Second large demand pool; dependence on one platform is risky
Delivery partners	6.5 lakh gig riders	Unpredictable earnings, weather risk, delayed cash access	Shared food and Instamart orders raise utilisation; Early Cashout instant payouts
Diners going out	Couples and groups booking restaurants, events	Finding deals and tables at good restaurants	Dineout discounts and Scenes events bundled with Swiggy One

Product portfolio and metrics

Food delivery

Swiggy Food	Core restaurant delivery across 720+ cities
Bolt	10-minute delivery from nearby restaurants for quick items
Toing	Standalone budget food delivery app, live in 50 cities
Food on Train	Meals delivered to train seats via IRCTC partnership
Swiggy Ads	Sponsored listings and brand campaigns for restaurants
North Star	Weekly food orders per active user delivered on time
Key metrics	Food GOV, MTUs, frequency, AOV, adj EBITDA % GOV, Toing new-user share
Guardrails	Restaurant churn, cancellations, rider earnings per hour, complaint rate

Out-of-home and membership

Dineout	Table reservations and bill-payment discounts at restaurants
Scenes	Curated events and experiences discovery
Swiggy One	Paid membership across food, Instamart and dining out
North Star	Members transacting in two or more Swiggy services monthly
Key metrics	OOH GOV (+44.8% YoY), membership penetration, cross-sell rate
Guardrails	Membership subsidy cost, restaurant discount fatigue

Group context

Instamart	Quick commerce, 1,171 dark stores; covered in separate sheet
Partner apps	Restaurant and delivery partner apps with payouts, analytics
North Star	Shared fleet utilisation across food and quick commerce
Key metrics	Orders per rider-hour, group adj EBITDA, consolidated GOV
Guardrails	Food margins not sacrificed to subsidise Instamart losses

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Restaurant commissions	Partner restaurants	Restaurants	Percentage of order value plus payment and campaign charges
Customer fees	Ordering customers	Customers	Platform fee (~₹14-15), delivery, packaging and surge fees
Advertising	Restaurants and brands	Restaurants, FMCG brands	Sponsored listings, banners, performance ads
Swiggy One	Frequent multi-service users	Members	Membership fee for free delivery and discounts
Dineout / OOH	Diners and event-goers	Restaurants, event organisers	Commission on discounted bills and ticket sales

- **Revenue mix:** Group FY26 revenue ₹23,053 cr; Instamart now drives growth, food delivery drives profit.
- **Users vs payers:** Customers pay food and fees; restaurants pay commission and ads; riders paid per order from both.
- **Unit economics:** Food adj EBITDA ₹292 cr (3.1% of GOV) vs Zomato 5.6%; scale and ad gap explain difference.
- **Growth levers:** Toing affordability, Bolt speed, Swiggy One cross-sell, ad yield, Tier-2 expansion, Dineout profitability.
- **Capital:** ₹10,000 cr QIP (Dec 2025) and Rapido stake exit gave ~₹14,400 cr cash runway.

Friction points to discuss

- Same meal costs noticeably more than offline menu
- Multiple fees revealed late at checkout
- Instamart promos clutter the food ordering experience
- Order issues resolved via slow chatbot refunds
- Restaurants complain of unapproved discount deductions

Competitors and market

- **Leader:** Zomato (~57% share), Bistro 10-minute kitchens
- **Disruptors:** Rapido Ownly zero-commission, Swish and Swish Go, Flipkart food
- **Quick food:** Zepto Cafe, Blinkit-adjacent snacking, Bistro
- **Direct ordering:** QSR own apps, ONDC sellers, WhatsApp ordering
- **Edge:** Multi-service app, Swiggy One bundle, strong South India base
- **Risk:** Thin food margin, Instamart cash burn, restaurant revolt, gig regulation

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** FSSAI action on Swiggy Instamart dark stores over food safety violations.
- **Aug 2026:** Bengaluru restaurant boycott deferred after Swiggy agreed consent-based campaigns and refunds.
- **Jul 2026:** Q1 FY27: loss narrows to ₹791 cr; food EBITDA up ₹100 cr YoY.
- **Watch:** Can Toing grow new users without cannibalising Swiggy Food margins and restaurant trust?

Sources: Swiggy Q1 FY27 press release, FY26 results, FY31 targets coverage, press reports 2025-26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Dunzo

Bengaluru hyperlocal 'get anything delivered' app that collapsed despite Reliance backing

Founded: **2014, Bengaluru; Kabeer Biswas and co-founders** Status: **Defunct: ops stopped 2024; NCLT insolvency admitted Sep 2025**
Funding: **~$485M raised; Google's first direct India startup bet (2017)** Reliance: **$200M for 25.8% stake, Jan 2022; written off** Peak valuation: **~$775M (Jan 2022, est.)**
FY23: **Revenue ₹227 cr; loss ₹1,802 cr (~8x revenue)** Write-off: **Reliance Retail wrote off ₹1,645 cr in FY25** Founders now: **Biswas, Jha, Suri now run AI and health startups**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Help urban Indians get anything done in their city: pick up, drop and deliver from any local store.
- **Original model:** Task-based 'Dunzo it' concierge: pick-up-drop, medicines, groceries, food; verb-level brand love in Bengaluru.
- **Pivot:** 2021 Dunzo Daily: 19-minute grocery from dark stores, entering quick commerce against Blinkit, Zepto and Instamart.
- **Key bet:** Reliance's $200M to become JioMart's hyperlocal delivery arm; synergy never materialised and follow-on funding dried up.
- **Lesson:** Hyperlocal needs density and AOV; burning ₹8 per ₹1 revenue in a funding winter with no moat is fatal.
- **Your view:** Was Dunzo killed by quick-commerce strategy, by capital timing, or by never owning one high-frequency use case?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Dunzo
Busy urban users	Bengaluru professionals, young families	No time to run errands across the city	One app to send packages, fetch keys, buy medicines, any store
Grocery top-up buyers	Households needing items within 20 minutes	Forgotten essentials, unreliable kirana delivery	Dunzo Daily dark stores promised 19-minute delivery
Local merchants	Kiranas, pharmacies, restaurants, florists	No own delivery fleet or online presence	Plug-in delivery and discovery without building logistics
Delivery partners	Gig riders in metro cities	Delayed payouts as cash ran out	Flexible task-based earnings during peak growth years
Enterprise / B2B	Reliance, D2C brands needing hyperlocal logistics	Last-mile delivery cost and speed	Dunzo for Business on-demand fleet

Product portfolio and metrics

Consumer delivery

Pick Up & Drop	Send anything across the city by bike courier
Dunzo Daily	Dark-store quick commerce for groceries and essentials
Food & stores	Delivery from local restaurants, pharmacies and shops
Dunzo Mo	Parallel app for items Play Store disallowed
North Star	Weekly completed tasks per active user (pre-pivot)
Key metrics	Orders per day, AOV, delivery time, contribution per order
Guardrails	Cash burn per order, refund rate, rider payout delays

Business services

Dunzo for Business	On-demand hyperlocal logistics for merchants and brands
Merchant partner app	Store catalogue, orders and payouts
Reliance/JioMart tie-up	Planned last-mile delivery for Reliance retail stores
North Star	B2B deliveries with positive contribution margin
Key metrics	B2B order share, fleet utilisation, cost per delivery
Guardrails	Client concentration, SLA breaches, receivable days

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Delivery fees	Consumers sending or ordering items	Consumers	Distance and surge-based delivery fees per task
Grocery margin	Dunzo Daily shoppers	Consumers, brands	Retail margin via marketplace sellers plus brand promotions
Merchant commission	Local stores and restaurants	Merchants	Percentage commission on orders fulfilled
B2B logistics	Brands, Reliance retail	Enterprise clients	Per-delivery fees for hyperlocal last-mile

- **Revenue mix:** Mostly delivery fees and grocery margins; FY23 operating revenue only ₹227 cr despite national brand.
- **Users vs payers:** Consumers loved free or cheap delivery; subsidies meant almost nobody paid true cost.
- **Unit economics:** FY23 loss ₹1,802 cr: dark-store rent, rider costs and discounts far exceeded low AOV contribution.
- **Collapse path:** 2023 layoffs, salary delays, vendor suits (Google, Meta); co-founders exit; ops halt 2024; insolvency 2025.
- **Lesson:** Strategic investors don't guarantee rescue; Reliance chose JioMart in-house and wrote off ₹1,645 cr.

Friction points to discuss

- Delivery times slipped as rider supply shrank
- Dark-store stockouts after vendor payments stalled
- Refunds delayed during the cash crunch
- Too many use cases, no clear habit
- Shrinking city coverage eroded user trust

Competitors and market

- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy Instamart, BigBasket Now, Flipkart Minutes
- **Pick-up-drop:** Swiggy Genie, Porter, Rapido parcel, Uber Connect
- **Food:** Zomato, Swiggy
- **Strategic owner:** Reliance JioMart built its own quick delivery
- **Edge:** Early first mover; 'Dunzo it' verb-level brand in Bengaluru
- **Risk:** Realised: out-spent by focused, better-funded rivals; ran out of cash

Recent news and direction

- **Apr 2026:** Kabeer Biswas raises $11M from Peak XV, Blume for consumer AI startup.
- **Sep 2025:** NCLT Bengaluru admits Dunzo into insolvency on vendor pleas; IRP appointed.
- **Aug 2025:** Reliance Retail formally writes off entire ₹1,645 cr Dunzo investment in FY25.
- **Watch:** Any asset or brand sale in insolvency; lessons for Zepto and Swiggy Instamart burn.

Sources: Inc42, Mint, YourStory, Reliance FY25 annual report coverage, NCLT reports, Wikipedia. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Swiggy Instamart

Swiggy's quick-commerce arm delivering groceries and essentials in minutes

Founded: **Aug 2020, Bengaluru, inside Swiggy** Owner/Listed: **Swiggy Ltd (listed Nov 2024); Swiggy Instamart Pvt Ltd** GOV: **Q1 FY27 ₹7,907 cr (+40% YoY)**
Users: **13.5M monthly transacting users, Q1 FY27** Dark stores: **1,171 across 131 cities, Jun 2026** AOV: **₹508 net AOV, Q1 FY27 (+12% YoY)**
Profitability: **CM -0.2% of GOV Q1 FY27; breakeven May 2026** Market share: **~21% of top-3 orders FY26 (34% FY24)** CEO/Head: **Amitesh Jha (Instamart CEO); Sriharsha Majety (Swiggy)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Elevate the quality of life of urban consumers by offering unparalleled convenience (Swiggy group mission).
- **Vision:** Be the default app for anything a household needs in minutes, from milk to electronics.
- **Core strategy:** Pause blitz-scaling; densify stores, lift AOV via Maxxsaver and bigger megapods, chase contribution and then EBITDA breakeven.
- **Moat:** Swiggy's shared fleet, One membership and food-delivery traffic cut CAC; cross-sell from food users.
- **Key bet:** IOCC status (foreign holding capped 49.5%) to own inventory, raising margins; ₹10,000 cr QIP war chest (Dec 2025).
- **Your view:** Instamart's order share fell from 34% to 21%. Was slowing store expansion for margins the right call versus Blinkit?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Swiggy Instamart
Urban top-up shopper	Metro households, 22-40, ordering daily essentials	Forgot milk, bread or veggies; no time for kirana trips	Fast delivery, wide assortment, and same app as Swiggy food orders
Stock-up family	Families buying monthly grocery baskets	Quick commerce felt expensive and limited for big baskets	Maxxsaver discounts on larger carts (28% order penetration) plus Swiggy One free delivery
Impulse/gifting buyer	Young professionals buying gifts, gadgets, beauty	Last-minute needs; e-commerce takes days	Electronics, toys, beauty and gifting categories delivered within minutes
Brands/advertisers	FMCG, D2C and electronics brands	Need fast-growing digital shelf and measurable performance ads	Search and display ads, sampling, and city-level demand data on 13.5M users
Delivery partners	Gig riders shared across Swiggy food and Instamart	Income volatility, safety pressure from speed promises	Batching across food and grocery raises utilisation and per-hour earnings

Product portfolio and metrics

Quick commerce core

Instamart app/tab	Groceries, fresh, household essentials in minutes
Maxxsaver	Extra discounts unlocked on larger baskets
Megapods	Larger dark stores carrying 50,000+ SKUs
Electronics & gifting	Phones, gadgets, toys, flowers delivered fast
North Star	Weekly contribution-positive orders per active household
Key metrics	GOV, AOV, order frequency, store throughput, % stores CM-positive
Guardrails	Delivery-time SLA, stock-outs, wastage, rider safety incidents

Monetisation & membership

Swiggy One	Cross-category membership with free delivery perks
Instamart Ads	Sponsored listings, banners and sampling for brands
Fees	Delivery, handling, small-cart and surge fees
North Star	Take rate per order without hurting repeat rate
Key metrics	Ad revenue % of GOV, member penetration, revenue per order
Guardrails	Fee-driven churn, ad clutter in search, price perception

Adjacent bets

Snacc / Bolt	Fast snacks and meals via shared Swiggy fleet
Private labels	Own-brand staples to lift gross margin
Fresh & meat	Fruits, vegetables, dairy and meat with freshness promise
North Star	Incremental orders per user from new categories
Key metrics	Category attach rate, gross margin, repeat purchase
Guardrails	Cannibalising core, ops complexity, quality complaints

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Commissions/margin on sales	Consumers buying groceries and essentials	Sellers and brands (inventory-led after IOCC)	Commission now; buy-sell margin once Instamart owns inventory
Customer fees	All Instamart shoppers	Consumers	Delivery, handling, small-cart and late-night fees per order
Advertising	FMCG, D2C, electronics brands	Brands	CPC search ads, display, sampling and data insights
Membership	Frequent Swiggy users	Consumers	Swiggy One subscription bundling food and grocery benefits

- **Revenue mix:** Est. mostly commissions plus customer fees; ads a fast-rising high-margin slice; revenue per order ₹108 in Q1 FY27.
- **Users vs payers:** Consumers pay fees; brands pay commissions and ads; riders paid per trip by Swiggy.
- **Unit economics:** CM moved from about -4.6% to -0.2% of GOV in a year; 45%+ stores CM-positive; guided EBITDA breakeven ~Jun 2027.
- **Growth levers:** Higher AOV categories, ads, owned inventory margin, tier-2 cities, Swiggy One cross-sell from food users.

Friction points to discuss

- Stock-outs and substitutions on fresh produce
- Hidden handling, surge and small-cart fees at checkout
- Delivery slower than Blinkit in many pin codes
- Separate app and tab confuse first-time users
- Refunds for damaged or expired items feel slow

Competitors and market

- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit (leader, 2,443 stores), Zepto, BigBasket BB Now
- **E-commerce entrants:** Amazon Now, Flipkart Minutes, JioMart quick delivery
- **Offline:** Kiranas, DMart, Reliance Smart, local fruit sellers
- **Edge:** Shared Swiggy fleet and Swiggy One bundle lower cost per order
- **Risk:** Losing scale race to Blinkit; Amazon/Flipkart deep pockets compress margins

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q1 FY27: GOV ₹7,907 cr, CM breakeven reached in May, 1,171 stores
- **Jan 2026:** Dropped 10-minute delivery claims after Labour Ministry nudge on rider safety
- **Dec 2025:** Swiggy raised ₹10,000 cr via QIP, mostly for Instamart network and marketing
- **Watch:** IOCC inventory model, EBITDA breakeven by Jun 2027, share vs Blinkit

Sources: Swiggy Q1 FY27 shareholder letter, Inc42, Business Standard, Outlook Business coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

BigBasket (BB Now)

Tata-owned online grocer that pivoted fully to quick commerce

Founded: **2011, Bengaluru; Hari Menon and co-founders** Owner/Listed: **Tata Digital ~64%; unlisted, IPO repeatedly delayed** Revenue: **FY26 B2C ₹8,223 cr (+7.7% YoY)**
Net loss: **FY26 B2C ₹3,073 cr (+66% YoY)** Dark stores: **~800-900; trimming from 76 to ~40 cities** Mix: **~80% revenue via BB Now quick commerce**
Parent: **Tata Digital FY26 loss ₹4,974 cr** CEO/Head: **Amit Nanda (ex-Amazon), since Jun 2026**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Give Indian households a trusted, convenient way to buy quality groceries at fair prices.
- **Vision:** Be the Tata Group's everyday commerce engine, powering grocery inside the Tata Neu super-app.
- **Core strategy:** Shift from scheduled delivery to BB Now in minutes (Aug 2024), keeping deep fresh and staples assortment.
- **Reset:** New CEO exits ~half the cities to cluster in dense metros; profitability target in 12-15 months.
- **Lesson:** Incumbent pivoting late into a speed war burns cash; losses rose 66% while revenue grew under 8%.
- **Your view:** Should BigBasket win on speed, or retreat to planned big-basket grocery where Tata trust and fresh matter more?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose BigBasket (BB Now)
Monthly stock-up family	Metro households buying large staple baskets	Heavy staples, need quality fresh produce and reliable slots	Deep assortment, fresh quality reputation, bbstar membership and Tata trust
Top-up shopper	Urban users needing items within minutes	Small urgent needs; tired of kirana stock-outs	BB Now delivery with broader fresh range than rivals
Tata Neu loyalist	Users earning NeuCoins across Tata brands	Want rewards across groceries, electronics, travel	NeuCoins earn and burn, Tata Neu HDFC card benefits
Brands/suppliers	FMCG brands, farmers via fresh supply chain	Need reliable offtake and visibility online	Direct farm sourcing, ads and sampling, private label partnerships
Delivery staff	Riders and store pickers, largely on payroll	Speed targets, shift stability	More employee-led model than gig rivals, steadier income

Product portfolio and metrics

Grocery delivery

BB Now	Quick delivery of groceries and essentials from dark stores
Slotted delivery	Scheduled larger baskets, legacy BigBasket model
bbstar	Membership with free delivery and member prices
Private labels	Fresho, bb Royal, BB Popular own brands
North Star	Weekly profitable baskets per household in core cities
Key metrics	AOV, orders per store per day, fresh share, repeat rate
Guardrails	Freshness complaints, wastage, delivery SLA, store-level losses

Food & adjacencies

BB Now cafe/food	Quick ready-to-eat meals and beverages from dark stores
Electronics & lifestyle	Expanded non-grocery categories to lift AOV
Tata Neu integration	Grocery tile inside Tata super-app with NeuCoins
North Star	Incremental non-grocery orders per active user
Key metrics	Attach rate, category gross margin, NeuCoin redemption
Guardrails	Food safety, cannibalisation, ops complexity in stores

Supply chain & B2B

Farm sourcing	Collection centres buying direct from farmers
BB B2B	Supplies to retailers and HoReCa
North Star	Fresh cost per kg vs mandi benchmark
Key metrics	Farm-to-shelf time, fill rate, B2B margin
Guardrails	Farmer payment delays, spoilage, quality rejections

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Grocery retail margin	Households ordering via app or Tata Neu	Consumers	Inventory-led buy-sell margin, higher on fresh and private labels
Fees & membership	Frequent shoppers	Consumers	Delivery and handling fees; bbstar subscription
Brand advertising	FMCG and D2C brands	Brands	Sponsored listings, banners, sampling, trade promotions
B2B supply	Retailers, restaurants	Businesses	Wholesale margin on staples and fresh

- **Revenue mix:** Mostly product sales; ~80% now via BB Now; ads and private label are margin levers.
- **Users vs payers:** Consumers pay for goods; brands fund ads and discounts; Tata Digital funds losses.
- **Unit economics:** Loss ₹3,073 cr on ₹8,223 cr revenue (FY26) implies ~37% negative net margin; city cuts aim to fix.
- **Growth levers:** Store density in top cities, private label, ads, Tata Neu traffic, higher-AOV fresh baskets.

Friction points to discuss

- Slower than Blinkit and Zepto in many pin codes
- Service withdrawn in cities being exited
- Inventory gaps after shrinking store network
- Tata Neu and BigBasket apps feel duplicated
- Fee changes and coupon rules confuse loyal users

Competitors and market

- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit (leader), Zepto, Swiggy Instamart
- **E-commerce:** Amazon Now and Fresh, Flipkart Minutes, JioMart
- **Offline:** DMart, Reliance Smart, kiranas, Star Bazaar
- **Edge:** Fresh supply chain, private labels and Tata balance sheet trust
- **Risk:** Sub-scale vs Blinkit's 2,443 stores; Tata patience with mounting losses

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** FY26 B2C loss widened 66% to ₹3,073 cr; revenue ₹8,223 cr
- **Jul 2026:** Plans to cut footprint from 76 to ~40 profitable cities
- **Jun 2026:** Amit Nanda replaces co-founder Hari Menon as CEO
- **Watch:** Profitability within 15 months, IPO revival, Tata capital infusion

Sources: RoC filings via YourStory, BW Retail, Inc42, Outlook Business coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Amazon Fresh & Amazon Now

Amazon's grocery delivery, now racing into India quick commerce

Founded: **Fresh: 2007 Seattle; India ~2019; Now: Jun 2025** Owner/Listed: **Amazon.com Inc (NASDAQ: AMZN)** Amazon Now GMV: **$1B+ annualised gross sales, Sep 2026**
Growth: **Amazon Now orders doubling every quarter** Dark stores: **500+ in India; target 1,000+ by end-2026** Reach: **Target 300+ cities using More Retail stores**
Investment: **₹2,800 cr (~$300M) quick-commerce push** Global: **US Fresh stores closing (2026); same-day grocery 2,300+ towns**
CEO/Head: **Samir Kumar, Amazon India Country Manager**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Be Earth's most customer-centric company, where people find anything they want to buy online.
- **Vision:** Make Amazon the default for every grocery mission: minutes (Now), hours (Fresh), days (Pantry-style bulk).
- **Core strategy:** Bundle groceries into Prime; reuse logistics, More Retail stores and seller base for asset-light scale.
- **Moat:** Prime base, payments (Amazon Pay), ad stack and deep pockets to subsidise a late entry.
- **Lesson:** Globally Amazon closed Fresh stores; delivery beat physical retail. In India it entered q-comm late but fast.
- **Your view:** Can a late entrant with Prime win quick commerce, or is store density a first-mover moat?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Amazon Fresh & Amazon Now
Prime households	Metro and tier-2 Prime members	Juggling multiple apps for groceries and shopping	One app, Prime benefits, trusted returns and Amazon Pay rewards
Urgent top-up buyer	Urban users needing essentials in minutes	Forgot items; e-commerce takes a day	Amazon Now tab inside main app, no new download
Planned grocery shopper	Families buying weekly baskets	Want price value and scheduled slots	Amazon Fresh slotted delivery, bank offers, Great Indian Festival deals
Brands/sellers	FMCG brands, local partners, More Retail	Need reach beyond metros and ad ROI	Amazon Ads, huge traffic, fulfilment network
Delivery partners	Riders in Amazon Flex and partner fleets	Earnings, safety under speed targets	Steady volume across Amazon's delivery programs

Product portfolio and metrics

India grocery

Amazon Now	Quick-commerce delivery from dark stores in minutes
Amazon Fresh	Scheduled grocery delivery within hours
More Retail stores	Supermarkets doubling as fulfilment for smaller cities
Prime grocery perks	Free delivery thresholds and member deals
North Star	Weekly grocery-active Prime households
Key metrics	Orders per store/day, AOV, Prime cross-shop rate, delivery time
Guardrails	Fresh quality complaints, stock-outs, cost per order, rider safety

Global grocery

Same-Day perishables	US same-day grocery delivery in 2,300+ towns
Whole Foods Market	Premium stores; 100+ new stores planned
Amazon Fresh online	Online grocery delivery in US, UK and others
North Star	Grocery share of Prime household wallet
Key metrics	Grocery GMV, perishables growth, repeat rate
Guardrails	Store losses, waste, delivery cost per unit

Monetisation layers

Amazon Ads	Sponsored products and brand ads on grocery searches
Amazon Pay	Payments, cashback and credit at checkout
North Star	Ad and payment revenue per grocery order
Key metrics	Ad attach, Amazon Pay share, take rate
Guardrails	Search relevance, discount dependency

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Grocery marketplace	Prime and non-Prime shoppers	Sellers and brands	Commissions and fees under India's marketplace FDI rules
Customer fees	Shoppers below free-delivery threshold	Consumers	Delivery and handling fees per order
Prime	Members across shopping, video, music	Consumers	Annual or monthly subscription bundling grocery perks
Advertising	FMCG and D2C brands	Brands	CPC sponsored listings, display, retail media

- **Revenue mix:** India: seller commissions, fees and ads; globally grocery is part of Amazon online and physical store revenue.
- **Users vs payers:** Shoppers pay for goods; sellers pay commissions; brands buy ads; Prime subsidises frequency.
- **Unit economics:** Not disclosed; est. deeply negative in India as Amazon funds launch discounts and store build-out.
- **Growth levers:** Prime cross-sell, 300-city rollout via More stores, ads, festival sales, electronics in minutes.

Friction points to discuss

- Amazon Now unavailable in many pin codes
- Now vs Fresh vs main app confuses users
- Smaller fresh assortment than Blinkit or BigBasket
- Delivery-time promise varies by city
- Marketplace FDI rules limit owning inventory

Competitors and market

- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit (2,443 stores, leader), Zepto, Swiggy Instamart, BB Now
- **E-commerce:** Flipkart Minutes, JioMart, Myntra M-Now
- **Global:** Walmart, Instacart, Kroger, DoorDash grocery
- **Edge:** Prime base, logistics reuse and deepest pockets in Indian commerce
- **Risk:** Late entrant vs Blinkit density; regulatory scrutiny on marketplace discounting

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Amazon Now crosses $1B annualised gross sales in India
- **Jun 2026:** Andy Jassy in India: Amazon Now to expand to 300+ cities
- **Jan 2026:** Amazon closing US Fresh and Go stores, refocusing on Whole Foods, same-day
- **Watch:** 1,000 dark stores by Diwali-end 2026, share vs Blinkit, Flipkart Minutes

Sources: Amazon announcements, Business Standard, YourStory, Inc42, Retail Insight Network coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Zepto

Pure-play quick-commerce startup delivering groceries and essentials in minutes

Founded: **2021, Mumbai; Aadit Palicha, Kaivalya Vohra** Owner/Listed: **Private (public Ltd entity); IPO deferred to 2027** Revenue: **FY26 ₹22,623 cr (~2x YoY, principal model)**
Net loss: **FY26 ₹5,905 cr; adj. EBITDA loss ₹5,041 cr** GOV / orders: **FY26 NRV ₹24,815 cr; 640M orders** Users: **4.79 cr annual transacting users, Mar 2026**
Dark stores: **1,139 at Mar 2026; plans ~1,900 more** AOV: **~₹390, flat over three years** CEO/Head: **Aadit Palicha (Co-founder, CEO)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make quick commerce the default way India shops for daily needs, with speed and selection.
- **Vision:** Become India's largest consumer platform for everyday purchases, then layer ads, cafe and fintech on top.
- **Core strategy:** Out-execute on store density and speed in top metros; own inventory after shifting to principal model in Jan 2025.
- **Key bet:** Zepto Cafe, Zepto Atom data and ads business raise contribution per order while EBITDA loss per order falls (₹136 to ₹79).
- **Lesson:** Public investors priced Zepto at ~$2.3B vs $7B private mark; growth without profit path no longer clears IPO.
- **Your view:** Should Zepto cut burn to list at a lower valuation, or keep funding share gains privately until 2027?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Zepto
Gen Z/young professionals	18-30 urban renters, often living alone	No time to cook or shop; want snacks, essentials instantly	Fast delivery, snacks, Zepto Cafe coffee and meals in one app
Value-seeking households	Metro families topping up groceries weekly	Quick commerce prices and fees feel higher than DMart	Zepto Pass free delivery, Super Saver pricing and frequent discounts
Brands/advertisers	FMCG, D2C brands and new launches	Need visibility and fast sell-through data by pin code	Sponsored listings, sampling and Zepto Atom analytics on demand
Sellers/suppliers	Distributors and brands supplying dark stores	Payment terms, margin pressure, data opacity	High-velocity offtake across 1,100+ stores in top cities
Delivery partners	Gig riders near dark stores	Speed pressure, safety, income stability	Short trips within ~2-3 km, dense order flow, weekly payouts

Product portfolio and metrics

Quick commerce

Zepto app	Groceries, fresh, personal care, electronics in minutes
Super Saver	Value mode with lower prices for price-sensitive users
Zepto Pass	Membership with free delivery and extra discounts
Private labels	Own brands in staples and household for margin
North Star	Weekly ordering households with contribution-positive baskets
Key metrics	Orders/store/day, AOV, retention, EBITDA loss per order
Guardrails	Delivery SLA, fill rate, wastage, rider safety, fee complaints

Food & cafe

Zepto Cafe	In-store kitchens serving coffee, snacks and quick meals
Cafe standalone app	Separate app to scale food beyond grocery users
North Star	Cafe orders per active user per week
Key metrics	Cafe attach rate, gross margin, kitchen throughput
Guardrails	Food safety incidents, prep time, quality ratings

Monetisation platforms

Zepto Ads	Search, display and sampling for brands
Zepto Atom	Paid demand and sales analytics for brands
Customer fees	Handling, small-cart, rain and late-night fees
North Star	Non-product revenue per order
Key metrics	Ad revenue % of NRV, advertiser count, Atom subscribers
Guardrails	Search relevance, fee-driven churn, brand ROI

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Product sales (principal)	Consumers ordering groceries and essentials	Consumers	Buy-sell margin on owned inventory via Indian-owned entity
Advertising & data	Brands and D2C sellers	Brands	Ads, sampling, Zepto Atom analytics subscriptions
Customer fees	All shoppers	Consumers	Delivery, handling, small-cart, surge fees per order
Zepto Cafe	Snack and coffee buyers	Consumers	Prepared food margin from in-store kitchens

- **Revenue mix:** Inventory sales dominate reported revenue after Jan 2025 principal shift; ads and fees drive most margin.
- **Users vs payers:** Consumers pay for goods and fees; brands pay for ads and data; investors fund the losses.
- **Unit economics:** Adj. EBITDA loss per order improved ₹136 to ₹79 in FY26, but AOV stuck near ₹390.
- **Growth levers:** Raise AOV via electronics and Cafe, mature stores, ads, densify top 10 cities, cut CAC.
- **Funding:** ~$1.8B raised; $7B valuation Oct 2025; 2026 pre-IPO round at ~$4-4.6B led by domestic investors.

Friction points to discuss

- Many add-on fees inflate small-basket checkout price
- Delivery promise slips during rain and peak hours
- Fresh produce quality inconsistent across stores
- Hard to reach a human for refund disputes
- Aggressive notifications and dark-pattern upsells irritate users

Competitors and market

- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit (leader, ~50% share), Swiggy Instamart, BigBasket BB Now
- **E-commerce entrants:** Amazon Now, Flipkart Minutes, JioMart
- **Cafe/food:** Swiggy Bolt/Snacc, Blinkit Bistro, Starbucks, local cafes
- **Edge:** Fastest execution culture; #2 by orders (640M FY26) ahead of Instamart
- **Risk:** Cash burn plus IPO valuation reset; Blinkit profitable, Amazon subsidising entry

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** IPO deferred after anchors offered ~$2.3B; listing now targeted Feb-May 2027
- **Jun 2026:** Updated DRHP: ₹8,010 cr fresh issue; FY26 revenue ₹22,623 cr, loss ₹5,905 cr
- **Jan 2026:** Dropped 10-minute delivery branding after Labour Ministry rider-safety push
- **Watch:** EBITDA breakeven timeline, unlisted share price, 2027 IPO pricing

Sources: Zepto UDRHP (Jun 2026), Bloomberg, Inc42, Outlook Business, The Ken coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Uber

Global platform for rides, food and freight, now betting on robotaxis

Founded: **2009, San Francisco; Travis Kalanick, Garrett Camp** Listed: **NYSE: UBER (IPO May 2019)** Revenue: **FY25 $52.0B; Q2 2026 $14.2B (+12%)**
Gross bookings: **Q2 2026 $58.0B (+22% cc); trips +18%** Profit: **Q2 2026 adj EBITDA $2.8B; TTM FCF >$10B** Users: **208M monthly active platform consumers (Q2 2026)**
Leaders: **CEO Dara Khosrowshahi; CFO Balaji Krishnamurthy** India: **FY25 sales ₹3,849 cr; loss ₹1,512 cr; 225 cities**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** We reimagine the way the world moves for the better.
- **Vision:** The everyday app for moving people and things, and the world's largest platform for autonomous vehicles.
- **Core strategy:** Cross-platform flywheel: Uber One links Mobility and Delivery, raising frequency while ads and scale lift margins.
- **AV bet:** Aggregator of robotaxis: Waymo, Nuro/Lucid, Baidu, Pony.ai, WeRide, Wayve; $1.25B Rivian deal (Mar 2026).
- **Delivery M&A:** Takeover offer for Delivery Hero at €41.50/share (Jul 2026); bought Getir food, Trendyol Go.
- **Your view:** In India, should Uber copy Rapido's driver-subscription model across cabs, even at the cost of take rate?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Uber
Urban riders	Commuters, travellers, nightlife across 70 countries	Surge pricing, cancellations, long pickups at peak	Global reliability, safety features, consistent experience when travelling
Uber One members	Frequent riders and food orderers	Fees across rides and delivery add up	Discounts and $0 delivery fees across Mobility and Delivery
Drivers and couriers	~10M earners, often multi-apping	Opaque fares, commission cuts, deactivation fears	Highest demand density, instant pay; India autos keep 100% fare
Merchants and advertisers	Restaurants, grocers, CPG brands	Commissions and need for incremental orders	Global demand, Uber Ads, marketing tools
Businesses and AV partners	Corporates, shippers, robotaxi makers	Need demand and fleet operations at scale	Uber for Business, Freight, and demand aggregation for AV fleets

Product portfolio and metrics

Mobility

UberX / Go / Premier	Core car rides across price tiers
Moto and Auto	Bike taxis and autorickshaws, key in India
Uber Reserve / Intercity	Scheduled airport and outstation trips
Autonomous rides	Robotaxi trips via Waymo, WeRide, Baidu and others
North Star	Completed trips per MAPC per month
Key metrics	Trips, gross bookings, take rate, ETA, driver supply hours
Guardrails	Safety incidents, cancellation rate, driver earnings per hour

Delivery

Uber Eats	Restaurant delivery in global markets (exited India 2020)
Grocery and retail	Supermarket, convenience and retail delivery
Uber Ads	Sponsored listings for merchants and CPG brands
Uber Connect / Courier	Send packages within a city
North Star	Weekly delivery orders per active eater
Key metrics	Delivery GB growth (+25% cc), basket size, ad revenue, segment margin
Guardrails	Order accuracy, courier earnings, merchant churn

Platform and other

Uber One	Cross-product membership for discounts and free delivery
Uber for Business	Corporate rides and meals with central billing
Uber Freight	Digital freight brokerage and logistics software
North Star	Share of gross bookings from cross-platform members
Key metrics	Members, retention, cross-sell, Freight bookings
Guardrails	Membership discount cost, Freight losses

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Mobility take rate	Riders and drivers	Riders (fare); driver share retained	Service fee ~30% of fare; India autos via driver subscription
Delivery fees	Eaters, merchants, couriers	Merchants and eaters	Merchant commission plus consumer delivery and service fees
Advertising	Merchants and brands	Merchants, CPG advertisers	Sponsored listings, in-app and in-car ads
Uber One	Frequent consumers	Members	Monthly or annual subscription fee
Freight	Shippers and carriers	Shippers	Brokerage margin and software fees

- **Revenue mix:** Q2 2026 revenue: Mobility $7.4B, Delivery $5.2B, Freight $1.6B; Delivery fastest growing at +28%.
- **Users vs payers:** 208M consumers pay; drivers and merchants are suppliers but also pay fees or subscriptions.
- **Unit economics:** Adj EBITDA 4.9% of gross bookings; Mobility segment profit $2.2B, Delivery $1.1B in Q2 2026.
- **Growth levers:** Uber One, ads, AV partnerships, Delivery Hero scale, low-cost products like Moto in emerging markets.
- **India:** India FY25 loss ₹1,512 cr; Uber infused ₹2,921 cr (Feb 2026) to fight Rapido, now named top rival.

Friction points to discuss

- Surge pricing feels unpredictable and unfair
- Driver cancellations after accepting rides, India especially
- AC, cash and destination disputes with drivers
- Support is slow and chatbot-heavy
- Advance tip prompts seen as dark patterns

Competitors and market

- **US / global rides:** Lyft, Waymo One, Tesla robotaxi, Bolt, Didi, Grab
- **Delivery:** DoorDash, Instacart, Just Eat Takeaway, Amazon
- **India:** Rapido (largest by rides), Ola, Namma Yatri, Bharat Taxi, inDrive
- **Edge:** Global scale, cross-platform membership, AV demand aggregation, $10B+ FCF
- **Risk:** AV players going direct, gig regulation, India losses, Delivery Hero integration

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Issued €4.5B euro bonds to help fund Delivery Hero takeover.
- **Aug 2026:** Q2 bookings $58B (+22% cc); India hits 225 cities; Rapido merger talks reportedly failed.
- **Jul 2026:** Agreed €41.50/share takeover offer for Delivery Hero; closed Getir food acquisition.
- **Watch:** Delivery Hero regulatory approvals (H2 2027) and whether India moves to subscription cabs.

Sources: Uber Q2 2026 earnings release and 10-Q (SEC), 8-K filings, Uber India RoC filings via press, Wikipedia. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Ola

Former Indian ride-hailing leader, now shrinking under zero-commission pressure

Founded: **2010, Mumbai; Bhavish Aggarwal and Ankit Bhati** Owner: **ANI Technologies (Ola Consumer, ex-Ola Cabs), unlisted** Revenue: **FY25 ₹1,171 cr (-42% YoY from ₹2,012 cr)**
Loss: **FY25 ₹662 cr standalone, double FY24's ₹329 cr** Valuation: **Vanguard mark ~$70M (Jun 2026) vs $7.3B peak** Drivers: **Zero-commission subscription since Jun 2025; ~₹67/day pass**
Head: **Bhavish Aggarwal, Founder and Chairman** Group: **Sister cos: Ola Electric (listed), Krutrim AI** IPO: **Prep began May 2026 despite falling revenue**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Build mobility for a billion Indians: affordable, accessible rides across cabs, autos and bikes.
- **Vision:** Ola Consumer as an India-first super app spanning mobility, payments, food via ONDC and Ola Maps.
- **Core strategy:** Shift to SaaS-style driver subscriptions (0% commission) to win supply back from Rapido and Uber.
- **India-only focus:** Exited UK, Australia, New Zealand in 2024; in-house Ola Maps and Krutrim cloud to cut costs.
- **Lesson:** Founder attention split across Ola Electric and Krutrim let a focused Rapido out-execute Ola on price.
- **Your view:** Is a zero-commission subscription a moat, or a race to the bottom that removes Ola's revenue?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Ola
Budget commuters	Office-goers using autos and bikes daily	Cancellations, AC and cash disputes, long pickup waits	Low fares under zero-commission; wide auto and bike coverage
Cab riders	Airport, outstation and family travellers	Car quality, driver refusals, unpredictable fares	Price, Ola Rentals and Outstation options, habit from earlier years
Driver-partners	1M+ auto, bike and cab drivers	High commissions, incentive cuts, low ride volumes	Keep 100% fare for a flat daily or monthly pass
Fleet operators	Small fleet owners leasing cars	Low utilisation and EMI pressure	Demand access without per-ride commission
Govt / regulators	State transport departments, MoRTH	Fare caps, safety, driver welfare compliance	Aggregator licences required to operate

Product portfolio and metrics

Mobility

Ola Mini / Prime	App-based cab rides across price tiers
Ola Auto and Bike	Autorickshaw and bike-taxi rides for short trips
Rentals / Outstation	Hourly packages and intercity cab trips
Ola Parcel	Intra-city package delivery by bike
North Star	Completed rides per week with low cancellation
Key metrics	Daily rides, active drivers, subscription renewals, pickup ETA, share vs Rapido
Guardrails	Cancellation rate, safety incidents, driver net earnings per hour

Platform and services

Driver subscription passes	Daily/monthly passes replacing per-ride commission
Ola Maps	In-house mapping replacing Google Maps, also sold to developers
Ola Money / Pay	Wallet and UPI payments inside the app
Ola Foods (ONDC)	Food ordering via ONDC network
North Star	Paying subscribed drivers active daily
Key metrics	Pass revenue, pass renewal rate, Maps API usage, cost per ride
Guardrails	Driver churn after pass expiry, payment failures

Group context

Ola Electric	Listed EV scooter maker; share fell from ~49% to ~6.5%
Krutrim	AI and cloud venture; ~90% of revenue from Ola group firms
North Star	Group synergies without draining Ola Consumer focus
Key metrics	EVs on Ola fleet, Krutrim cost savings
Guardrails	Related-party dependence, founder bandwidth

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Driver subscriptions	Auto, bike and cab drivers	Drivers	Flat passes (~₹67/day) for unlimited rides, no commission
Rider fees	Riders	Riders	Platform or convenience fees on bookings
Ads and partnerships	Brands targeting riders	Advertisers	In-app placements and co-branded offers
Maps and tech	Developers, group companies	API customers	Ola Maps API usage fees

- **Revenue mix:** Shift from commissions to subscriptions cut reported revenue 42% in FY25; most income is service fees.
- **Users vs payers:** Under 0% commission, drivers are the payers; riders pay fares directly to drivers.
- **Unit economics:** Subscription revenue per driver capped and low; losses doubled to ₹662 cr as rides shrank.
- **Growth levers:** Win back supply, EV fleets, Tier-2 autos, Maps monetisation, IPO capital.
- **Valuation lesson:** Vanguard mark of ~$70M (99% below peak) shows investors price Ola as a fading No.3.

Friction points to discuss

- Drivers cancel or demand extra cash
- Long waits as active driver pool shrank
- Customer support hard to reach
- Advance tip prompts flagged by government
- Inconsistent car quality and AC refusals

Competitors and market

- **Leader:** Rapido: largest by rides, $3B valuation, subscription pioneer
- **Global:** Uber: 225 Indian cities, ₹2,921 cr fresh capital
- **Open / co-op:** Namma Yatri, Bharat Taxi cooperative (~11% cheaper), inDrive
- **Edge:** Brand recall, wide auto/bike network, in-house Maps cost advantage
- **Risk:** Cash burn, state aggregator rules, EV mandates, founder distraction

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Centre asks Ola, Uber, Rapido to remove advance tipping; Chandigarh bars aggregators.
- **Jun 2026:** Vanguard marks Ola Consumer down to ~$70M, 99% below 2021 peak.
- **May 2026:** Late FY25 filing: revenue -42%, loss doubles; Ola begins IPO preparation.
- **Watch:** Can Ola list, or will it be acquired or merged as Rapido consolidates?

Sources: RoC filings via Moneycontrol, FE, Mint, Inc42; Vanguard SEC filing coverage; Morning Context; press 2025-26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Amazon

World's largest online marketplace, logistics network and retail-media engine

Founded: **1994, Seattle, by Jeff Bezos** Listed: **NASDAQ: AMZN; AWS is separate sheet** Group revenue: **CY2025 $716.9B net sales** Latest quarter: **Q2 2026 $200.6B (+20% YoY), op inc $27.5B** Online stores: **Q2 2026 $70.4B (+15%); 3P services +16%** Advertising: **CY2025 $68.6B; Q2 2026 $19.8B (+26%)** Prime: **~220M+ members globally (est.)** CEO: **Andy Jassy; Stores led by Doug Herrington** India: **FY26 ASSPL rev ₹34,967 cr; group loss ₹2,793 cr**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Be Earth's most customer-centric company, where people can find and discover anything they want to buy online.
- **Vision:** Lowest prices, vast selection, fastest delivery: the flywheel where more selection drives traffic, sellers and lower cost structure.
- **Core strategy:** Regionalised fulfilment and same-day network cut cost-to-serve; paid units growth (+17% Q2 2026) funds price investment.
- **Moat:** Prime bundle plus owned logistics plus first-party shopper data feeding a $68B+ high-margin ads business.
- **Key bet:** AI shopping (Rufus, Alexa+), rural same-day, and quick commerce: Amazon Now in India with $3B committed by 2030.
- **Your view:** Is Amazon now an ad company that sells goods? Does rising ad load erode the customer-obsession promise?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Amazon
Prime shoppers	Urban households buying frequently, value speed	Need trusted fast delivery and easy returns across everything	Free fast shipping, Prime Video, deals and Prime Day lock in habit
Value shoppers	Price-sensitive buyers, India tier-2/3, deal hunters	Want lowest price without fake products or delivery uncertainty	Huge selection, A-to-z guarantee, low-price stores like Haul and Bazaar
Third-party sellers	SMBs, D2C brands, Indian MSMEs, exporters	Need demand, logistics and payments without building own infrastructure	Largest buyer base, FBA fulfilment, Global Selling to 18+ marketplaces
Advertisers	Brands, sellers, agencies, non-endemic marketers	Need closed-loop measurement proving ad spend drives sales	Sponsored ads at point of purchase plus Prime Video and DSP reach
Delivery partners	DSP owners, Flex drivers, Indian kirana partners	Want steady earnings and volume with flexible work	Massive daily package volume and Amazon-supplied tech, routing and vans

Product portfolio and metrics

Shopping and marketplace

Amazon.com / .in	1P retail plus 3P marketplace across ~20 country stores
Rufus	Generative-AI shopping assistant inside the app
Haul / Amazon Bazaar	Ultra-low-price store fighting Temu, Shein and Meesho
Amazon Now	10-30 minute quick commerce in India via dark stores
Amazon Fresh / Whole Foods	Online and physical grocery
North Star	Weekly purchasing customers receiving orders within promised delivery time
Key metrics	Paid units, conversion, delivery speed, selection in stock, repeat rate
Guardrails	Return rate, counterfeit complaints, contribution margin per unit, CSAT

Prime and subscriptions

Prime membership	Fast free delivery, Video, Music, deals; Lite tier in India
Prime Video	Streaming with ad tier by default, live sports
Alexa+	Agentic voice assistant bundled with Prime
Prime Day / GIF	Tentpole sales events incl. Great Indian Festival
North Star	Engaged Prime members using 2+ benefits monthly
Key metrics	Members, renewal rate, spend per member vs non-member
Guardrails	Cancellation complaints, FTC dark-pattern exposure, delivery cost per member

Seller and advertiser services

Fulfilment by Amazon	Storage, pick, pack, ship and returns for sellers
Sponsored Products/Brands	Search-result ads bought by auction
Amazon DSP	Programmatic ads across Prime Video, Twitch, partners
Amazon Pay	Wallet and UPI payments; loss-making in India
North Star	Seller sales growth attributable to Amazon services
Key metrics	3P share of units, ad ROAS, FBA adoption, active sellers
Guardrails	Seller fee burden, organic result quality, ad load per search page

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Online stores (1P)	Shoppers buying Amazon-owned inventory	Shoppers	Retail margin on goods; low margin, high volume
Third-party seller services	Sellers and shoppers	Sellers	Referral commission, FBA fulfilment and storage fees
Advertising	Shoppers and viewers see ads	Brands, sellers, agencies	CPC sponsored ads, DSP impressions, Prime Video ads
Subscriptions	Prime members	Members	Annual or monthly Prime fee; Video add-ons
Physical stores	Grocery shoppers	Shoppers	Whole Foods and Fresh store margins

- **Revenue mix:** Online stores ~37% of sales, 3P services ~24%, ads ~10%, subscriptions ~7%; AWS ~18% (separate sheet).
- **Users vs payers:** Shoppers pay for goods and Prime; sellers and brands pay fees and ads, which carry most profit.
- **Unit economics:** Retail near break-even per unit; ads and 3P fees fund free shipping. Regionalisation lowered cost-to-serve.
- **Growth levers:** Ads on Prime Video, AI shopping, rural same-day, low-price stores, India quick commerce.
- **India note:** Amazon India FY26 losses grew 48% to ₹2,793 cr as Now and Pay burn cash.

Friction points to discuss

- Search pages crowded with sponsored listings
- Fake reviews and counterfeit risk on 3P listings
- Rising seller fees push prices up
- Prime cancellation flow drew FTC action
- India: slower than quick commerce for daily needs

Competitors and market

- **Global retail:** Walmart, Temu, Shein, TikTok Shop, Alibaba
- **India:** Flipkart, Meesho, Reliance JioMart/Ajio, Myntra
- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit, Swiggy Instamart, Zepto, Flipkart Minutes
- **Retail media:** Google, Meta, Walmart Connect, Flipkart Ads
- **Edge:** Logistics scale, Prime habit and shopper data no rival matches globally
- **Risk:** Antitrust (FTC), India FDI rules, losing Indian MAUs to Flipkart

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Commits $3B to India quick commerce by 2030; Amazon Now to 300+ cities
- **Jul 2026:** Q2 2026 sales $200.6B (+20%); ads +26% to $19.8B
- **Jan 2026:** Further corporate layoffs (~16,000) after 30,000 cuts begun in 2025
- **Watch:** Q3 2026 results, festive Great Indian Festival share, Rufus monetisation

Sources: Amazon 10-K FY2025 and Q2 2026 release, RoC filings via Inc42/Entrackr, press coverage. Mix and metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Flipkart

India's largest homegrown e-commerce marketplace, majority-owned by Walmart

Founded: **2007, Bengaluru, Sachin and Binny Bansal** Owner: **Walmart ~80%+ since 2018; unlisted** Valuation: **~$38B (2025 ESOP buyback; est.)** Revenue: **FY25 Flipkart India ₹82,787 cr (+17%)**
Marketplace arm: **FY25 Flipkart Internet ₹20,807 cr; loss ₹1,494 cr** Loss: **FY25 Flipkart India net loss ₹5,189 cr** Users: **~35% of India e-com MAUs incl. Myntra (2026)**
CEO: **Kalyan Krishnamurthy (Group CEO)** IPO: **Redomiciled to India Dec 2025; IPO deferred to ~2028**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Transform commerce in India through technology, making quality goods accessible and affordable for every Indian.
- **Vision:** Be the default commerce, payments and quick-delivery platform for India's next 500 million online shoppers.
- **Core strategy:** Value-first marketplace for Bharat: tier-2/3 depth, vernacular UX, affordability via EMI, Pay Later and bank offers.
- **Moat:** Ekart logistics reach, Big Billion Days brand, smartphone and fashion category leadership, Myntra in the family.
- **Key bet:** Flipkart Minutes quick commerce: ~800 dark stores early 2026, targeting 2,000 by mid-2027; EBITDA breakeven by FY27.
- **Your view:** Should Flipkart burn cash on Minutes before IPO, or protect the profitability story Walmart now demands?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Flipkart
Bharat value shoppers	Tier-2/3 first-time online buyers	Low trust, limited cards, need affordable branded goods and COD	Vernacular app, COD, EMI and Pay Later, deep festive discounts
Metro power users	Urban Plus/Black members, electronics buyers	Want fast delivery and best price on high-ticket items	Exclusive phone launches, bank offers, Minutes for 10-minute delivery
Sellers and brands	1.4M+ sellers, MSMEs, D2C and OEM brands	Need national reach, logistics and working capital	Largest Indian buyer base, Ekart fulfilment, seller loans, lower-commission programs
Advertisers	Brands and sellers buying Flipkart Ads	Need measurable sales lift at point of purchase	Closed-loop retail media; ads revenue ₹6,317 cr FY25 (+27%)
Delivery workforce	Ekart riders, dark-store staff, kirana partners	Need steady income and festive-season work	Large hiring during BBD, predictable volumes, gig flexibility

Product portfolio and metrics

Core marketplace

Flipkart app	Electronics, fashion, home, grocery marketplace
Shopsy	Zero-commission value marketplace fighting Meesho
Flipkart Plus / Black	Loyalty tiers with early sale access and perks
Big Billion Days	Annual festive sale; 2026 edition from 9 Oct
North Star	Monthly transacting users completing a delivered, non-returned order
Key metrics	GMV, MAU to buyer conversion, AOV, tier-2/3 share, repeat rate
Guardrails	Return/RTO rate, delivery promise breach, contribution margin per order

Monetisation and fintech

Flipkart Ads	Sponsored listings, brand display and video ads
super.money	UPI and credit app launched 2024
Flipkart Pay Later / EMI	Partner-financed BNPL and card EMIs
Ekart	Logistics arm also serving third-party shippers
North Star	Take rate on GMV from fees, ads and fintech
Key metrics	Ad revenue per seller, ROAS, credit approvals, Ekart external volume
Guardrails	Ad load on search, credit defaults, seller fee churn

Quick and adjacent commerce

Flipkart Minutes	10-15 minute delivery from ~800-1,200 dark stores
Myntra	Fashion and beauty arm; profitable, M-Now quick fashion
Cleartrip	Travel booking for flights and hotels
Flipkart Wholesale	B2B supply to kiranas and retailers
North Star	Weekly Minutes orders per active user in live pin codes
Key metrics	Daily orders (1M+), dark-store throughput, delivery time, basket size
Guardrails	Burn per order, stockouts, rider safety, cannibalisation of core

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Marketplace fees	Sellers listing to Flipkart shoppers	Sellers	Commission, collection, shipping fees; FY25 ₹7,751 cr, doubled
Advertising	Shoppers see sponsored products	Brands and sellers	CPC and display ads; FY25 ₹6,317 cr (+27%)
Logistics	Sellers and external shippers	Sellers, D2C brands	Ekart delivery fees; FY25 ₹4,224 cr, down from ₹6,838 cr
Wholesale / 1P-like trading	Retailers and seller entities	Retailers	Flipkart India buys and resells goods; thin margin, most revenue
Fintech and fees	Shoppers paying by UPI or credit	Lenders, banks, shoppers	Lending referral fees, bank-offer co-funding, platform fees

- **Revenue mix:** Marketplace arm: fees and ads are two-thirds of ₹20,807 cr FY25. Group revenue dominated by wholesale trading.
- **Users vs payers:** Shoppers rarely pay directly; sellers fund the platform via commission, ads and logistics fees.
- **Unit economics:** Marketplace loss narrowed 37% in FY25, but group loss widened to ₹5,189 cr on Minutes and discounts.
- **Growth levers:** Minutes in 250+ cities, ads take rate, Shopsy for value, super.money credit cross-sell.

Friction points to discuss

- Fake or poor-quality items on some 3P listings
- Returns and refunds slow, often disputed
- Platform and handling fees add surprise costs
- Bank-offer pricing confusing; best price hard to find
- Minutes coverage patchy outside metros

Competitors and market

- **Horizontal:** Amazon India, Reliance JioMart, Tata Neu
- **Value:** Meesho, Shopsy rivals, Amazon Bazaar
- **Quick commerce:** Blinkit, Swiggy Instamart, Zepto, Amazon Now, BigBasket
- **Fashion:** Ajio, Nykaa Fashion, Meesho (vs Myntra)
- **Edge:** Indian MAU lead, Bharat reach, smartphone category leadership, Walmart backing
- **Risk:** Losses, FDI inventory rules, CCI probes, quick-commerce cash burn

Recent news and direction

- **Oct 2026:** Big Billion Days 2026 live from 9 Oct; Plus/Black early access 8 Oct
- **May 2026:** IPO put on hold; listing deferred to ~2028 pending EBITDA breakeven
- **Dec 2025:** NCLT approves redomicile from Singapore to India, a pre-IPO step
- **Watch:** FY26 filings, Minutes losses, DRHP timing, Amazon Now's $3B challenge

Sources: RoC filings via Inc42/Entrackr/Business Standard, Walmart disclosures, press coverage. MAU share and metrics are estimates for PM interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Myntra

India's leading online fashion and beauty marketplace, owned by Flipkart

Founded: **2007, Bengaluru, Mukesh Bansal and co-founders** Owner: **Flipkart Group (acquired 2014), Walmart-controlled** Revenue: **FY25 ₹6,043 cr (+18% YoY)**
Profit: **FY25 PAT ₹548 cr, up 18x** Ad revenue: **FY25 ₹914 cr (+28%)** Selection: **~6,000+ brands; M-Now 100K styles, 1,000 brands** CEO: **Sharon Pais since Apr 2026 (ex-Nandita Sinha)**
Quick fashion: **M-Now: 30-60 min, 10+ cities, 940+ pin codes**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make India look good: democratise fashion and beauty with the widest selection and trusted authentic brands.
- **Vision:** Be the default destination for discovering and buying fashion, beauty and lifestyle across India, at any speed.
- **Core strategy:** Brand-led marketplace with owned private labels, logistics and content-led discovery; profitable growth over discount-led GMV.
- **Moat:** Deep brand partnerships, size and fit data, fashion logistics and returns handling built over 15+ years.
- **Key bet:** M-Now quick fashion plus AI styling; Myntra Glam beauty; FWD for Gen Z; international brands partnerships.
- **Your view:** Does 30-minute fashion delivery create new demand or just raise cost-to-serve for already-profitable orders?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Myntra
Gen Z trend-seekers	18-25, Instagram-native, budget-conscious	Want trendy styles fast without overspending or poor fit	FWD feed, influencer content, deals at End of Reason Sale
Urban professionals	Metro 25-40, brand-loyal, time-poor	Need authentic branded fashion delivered quickly, easy returns	Wide brand catalogue, Insider loyalty, M-Now 30-60 min delivery
Beauty shoppers	Women 18-40 buying cosmetics, skincare	Worry about fake products and shade mismatch	Authentic brand stores, Myntra Glam, reviews and creator tutorials
Fashion brands and sellers	National, D2C and global brands	Need targeted reach and fashion-specific logistics, returns	Largest fashion audience in India, ads, size data, omnichannel tie-ups
Advertisers	Brands buying Myntra ad inventory	Need proof that spend drives fashion sales	Closed-loop retail media; ads ₹914 cr FY25 (+28%)

Product portfolio and metrics

Core fashion marketplace

Myntra app	Apparel, footwear, accessories marketplace for 6,000+ brands
Private labels	Roadster, HRX, Dressberry and other own brands
End of Reason Sale	Biannual flagship fashion sale
Myntra Insider	Loyalty program with early access and rewards
North Star	Monthly transacting customers keeping their purchase (net of returns)
Key metrics	Conversion, AOV, return rate, repeat purchase, brand mix
Guardrails	Return cost per order, fit complaints, discount depth, delivery TAT

Speed and discovery

M-Now	30-60 minute fashion and beauty delivery, 10+ cities
Myntra FWD	Gen Z trend feed with creator content
Maya / AI stylist	Gen-AI styling and outfit recommendations
Myntra Minis	Short-form shoppable video content
North Star	Weekly engaged users who buy from discovery surfaces
Key metrics	M-Now orders, delivery time, feed-to-cart rate, creator GMV
Guardrails	M-Now cost per order, cannibalisation of standard delivery, return rate

Beauty and monetisation

Myntra Glam	Beauty and personal care store
Myntra Ads	Sponsored listings and brand display
Global store	International brands sold into India
North Star	Beauty share of wallet among existing fashion buyers
Key metrics	Beauty GMV, ad ROAS, cross-category buyers
Guardrails	Ad load on browse, counterfeit complaints, seller fee churn

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Logistics services	Sellers shipping to Myntra customers	Sellers	Delivery and returns fees; ₹2,919 cr, ~48% of FY25 revenue
Marketplace services	Brands and sellers	Sellers	Commission and platform fees; ₹2,052 cr (+16%)
Advertising	Shoppers browsing feed and search	Brands	Sponsored listings and display; ₹914 cr (+28%)
Customer fees	Shoppers	Shoppers	Convenience, platform and M-Now delivery fees

- **Revenue mix:** Logistics 48%, marketplace 34%, ads 15% of FY25 operating revenue; private labels add margin.
- **Users vs payers:** Shoppers pay for goods; brands pay commission, logistics and ads, which form most revenue.
- **Unit economics:** Fashion's high returns are the key cost; PAT ₹548 cr shows scale beat returns cost.
- **Growth levers:** M-Now speed, beauty, ads, Gen Z via FWD, tier-2 cities like Patna, Jaipur, Lucknow.

Friction points to discuss

- Size and fit inconsistency drives returns
- Return pickups and refunds can be slow
- Heavy discounting trains users to wait for sales
- Convenience fees feel like hidden charges
- M-Now selection limited versus full catalogue

Competitors and market

- **Fashion e-com:** Ajio (Reliance), Nykaa Fashion, Tata Cliq, Amazon Fashion
- **Value fashion:** Meesho, Shein via Reliance, Flipkart Shopsy
- **Quick fashion:** Slikk, KNOT, Zulu Club, Blinkit and Zepto apparel
- **Beauty:** Nykaa, Tira (Reliance), Purplle
- **Edge:** Profitable at scale, deepest brand catalogue, Flipkart logistics and data
- **Risk:** Leadership churn (4 CEOs in 12 years), M-Now burn, Reliance pricing

Recent news and direction

- **May 2026:** M-Now reaches Chennai, adds AI outfit selection with 30-minute delivery
- **Apr 2026:** Sharon Pais replaces Nandita Sinha as CEO to drive M-Now push
- **Feb 2026:** M-Now expands to Patna, Jaipur, Lucknow, Ahmedabad; 10 cities
- **Watch:** FY26 profit, M-Now unit economics, Flipkart IPO bundling Myntra

Sources: RoC filings via Entrackr/YourStory/Inc42, press coverage. Mix and metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Instagram

Meta's visual social network for photos, Reels, Stories and DMs

Founded: **2010 by Kevin Systrom, Mike Krieger** Owner: **Meta Platforms (acquired 2012 for $1B)** HQ: **Menlo Park, California** Head: **Adam Mosseri (Head of Instagram)**
Users: **~3B MAU (Zuckerberg, late 2025)** Revenue: **Not disclosed; est. ~half of Meta ads** Parent rev: **Meta FY25 $201B (+22%); Q2'26 $60.8B**
India: **Largest market, ~480M users (2025 est.)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Bring you closer to the people and things you love.
- **Vision:** The default place to share with close friends and discover creators, from DMs to Reels.
- **Core strategy:** AI-ranked Reels for discovery, DMs for sharing; recommendations lifted IG time spent ~6% YoY in 2025.
- **Moat:** Social graph plus creator supply plus Meta ads stack (Advantage+) and shared infra across 3.6B daily people.
- **Key bet:** New surfaces (iPad, Instagram for TV, Edits) and AI ranking to win time from TikTok and YouTube.
- **Your view:** Has Instagram traded friends for strangers' Reels too far, and is DMs-first the right fix?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Instagram
Gen Z / young adults	16-34, mobile-first, India, US, Brazil	Want entertainment and private sharing without public pressure	Reels discovery, Close Friends, Notes and DMs where their friends already are
Creators	Influencers, artists, micro-creators	Need reach, audience ownership and steady income	Huge distribution, Edits app, subscriptions, brand-deal marketplace, cross-post to Facebook
Advertisers / SMBs	D2C brands, local shops, agencies	Need measurable, efficient reach to buyers	Advantage+ AI targeting, Reels and Stories ads, Shopping, click-to-message ads
Teens and parents	Under-18 users and guardians	Safety, harmful content, screen-time worries	Teen Accounts with PG-13 defaults, time limits, parental supervision

Product portfolio and metrics

Core sharing

Feed	Photos and carousels from follows plus recommendations
Stories	24-hour ephemeral posts; Close Friends lists
Direct (DMs)	Messaging, Notes, reshares; primary sharing loop
Instagram Map	Opt-in location sharing and place-based content
North Star	Daily users who send or receive a share with friends
Key metrics	DAU, DM sends per user, Stories posted, Close Friends usage
Guardrails	Teen safety reports, privacy complaints, notification opt-outs

Video and discovery

Reels	Short-form vertical video ranked by AI
Explore / Search	Interest-based discovery and keyword search
Instagram for TV	Reels channels on TV; launched Dec 2025
Instagram for iPad	Native tablet app, Reels-first, 2025
North Star	Time spent on satisfying video sessions per daily user
Key metrics	Reels watch time, reshares, original content share, session length
Guardrails	Regretted time, unoriginal or AI-slop share, creator churn

Creators and commerce

Edits	Standalone video editing app for creators
Subscriptions	Paid fan subscriptions for exclusive content
Creator Marketplace	Brand-creator deal matching and partnership ads
Ads (Feed/Reels/Stories)	Auction ads via Meta Advantage+
North Star	Advertiser conversions per ad dollar spent
Key metrics	Ad impressions, price per ad, ROAS, creator earnings
Guardrails	Ad load per session, user sentiment, policy violations in ads

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Feed and Stories ads	All users scrolling feed and Stories	Brands, SMBs, agencies	CPM/CPC auction, AI-targeted via Advantage+
Reels ads	Video viewers	Performance and brand advertisers	Interstitial video ads in Reels feed, auction priced
Click-to-message ads	Users DMing businesses	SMBs, D2C sellers	Ads open DM or WhatsApp chat, pay per result
Creator monetisation	Fans of creators	Fans (subs), brands (partnership ads)	Subscriptions with Meta/app-store cut; boosted creator content

- **Revenue mix:** Almost entirely advertising; Meta FoA ad revenue $59.4B in Q2'26 (+27%), Instagram est. roughly half.
- **Users vs payers:** ~3B users pay nothing; millions of advertisers pay, with SMBs the long tail.
- **Unit economics:** Q2'26 Meta ad impressions +14%, price per ad +12%; AI ranking lifts both time and conversions.
- **Growth levers:** Reels ad load, DMs/business messaging, India and emerging-market ARPU, new surfaces like TV.
- **Cost side:** Shares Meta's 2026 capex of $115-135B for AI infra and ranking models.

Friction points to discuss

- Feed full of strangers' Reels, fewer friends' posts
- Ad load and sponsored posts feel heavier every year
- Creators complain reach is unpredictable after algorithm changes
- Teen safety and mental-health concerns drive regulatory pressure
- Unoriginal reposts and AI slop crowd out originals

Competitors and market

- **Short video:** TikTok, YouTube Shorts, Snapchat Spotlight
- **Messaging:** Snapchat, WhatsApp (sibling), iMessage, Telegram
- **Creators:** YouTube, TikTok, Substack, Patreon for monetisation
- **India:** YouTube Shorts, Moj, Josh, ShareChat after TikTok ban
- **Edge:** Social graph plus Meta AI ranking and ads machine at 3B scale
- **Risk:** Teen-safety laws and lawsuits, EU DMA, TikTok winning Gen Z attention

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Tagged posts can appear on main profile grid, launched with Ayra Starr
- **Jul 2026:** Meta Q2: FoA revenue $60.4B (+28%), daily people 3.6B
- **Dec 2025:** Instagram for TV launches, Reels as interest channels on big screen
- **Watch:** Reels vs US TikTok JV, teen social-media laws, AI-generated content labelling

Sources: Meta 10-K FY25 and Q2 2026 earnings, Meta newsroom, Statista/SocialPilot user estimates, press coverage. Instagram revenue is an estimate. Prepared Oct 2026.

Threads

Meta's text-first public conversation app, built on Instagram's graph

Launched: **July 2023 by Meta (Instagram team)** Owner: **Meta Platforms (NASDAQ: META)** Head: **Connor Hayes (since Sep 2025)** Users: **500M+ MAU (Jun 2026); ~150M DAU**
Ads: **Global ad rollout to all markets, 2026** Revenue: **Not disclosed; analyst est. low single-digit $B** DMs: **~350M DMs sent weekly (May 2026)**
Fediverse: **ActivityPub interoperability, opt-in**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Be the open, friendly public square for real-time conversation and ideas.
- **Vision:** Replace X as the default text network for news, creators and communities, without the toxicity.
- **Cold start:** Bootstrapped from Instagram's graph: one-tap signup, imported follows; 100M signups in 5 days.
- **Core strategy:** LLM-powered recommendations drive time spent; add DMs, communities, web and fediverse to deepen habit.
- **Monetisation:** Ads only after scale: tested 2025, global rollout 2026 using Meta's existing advertiser base and Advantage+.
- **Your view:** Is Threads a true X replacement, or just Instagram's text tab with weak retention?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Threads
Instagram users	Existing IG users curious about text	Want conversation without X's toxicity or paywalls	One-tap signup, same identity and follows, friendlier tone
Creators / journalists	Writers, commentators, ex-X power users	Lost reach and trust on X after 2022	Large audience, recommendations surface new voices, cross-post from Instagram
Communities	Fans, niche topic groups (sports, books)	Hard to find topic conversations in a for-you feed	Topic tags, Meta-curated communities, custom feeds
Advertisers	Brands already on Meta Ads Manager	Want brand-safe text inventory and new reach	Same Advantage+ campaigns extend to Threads, brand-safe environment

Product portfolio and metrics

Conversation core

For You feed	Algorithmic feed of posts, LLM-improved ranking
Following / custom feeds	Chronological and topic-based feeds
Topic tags and communities	One tag per post; Meta-curated topic communities
Search and trending	Keyword search and trending topics for news
North Star	Daily users who post or reply in a meaningful conversation
Key metrics	DAU/MAU, replies per post, D30 retention, time spent
Guardrails	Engagement-bait share, harassment reports, political-content complaints

Connection and reach

Threads DMs	1:1 and group chats up to 50; web since 2026
Threads web	Desktop app with multi-column and messaging
Fediverse sharing	ActivityPub posts to Mastodon and other servers
North Star	Weekly users with two-way conversations (replies or DMs)
Key metrics	DMs per user, web share of sessions, fediverse follows
Guardrails	Spam DMs, block rate, account takeovers

Monetisation

Feed ads	Image, carousel and video ads in Threads feed
Advantage+ placement	Threads added as placement in Meta campaigns
Brand safety controls	Third-party verification and inventory filters for advertisers
North Star	Ad revenue per DAU without hurting retention
Key metrics	Ad load, CPM, CTR, advertiser adoption
Guardrails	Retention change in ad-exposed cohorts, user sentiment

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Feed ads	All Threads users in supported markets	Brands and SMBs via Meta Ads Manager	Auction CPM/CPC; image, carousel, video formats
Cross-app placement	Users across Instagram, Facebook, Threads	Advertisers running Advantage+ campaigns	Meta's AI auto-allocates spend to Threads inventory
Engagement flywheel	Instagram users posting to Threads	Indirect: more Meta ad inventory overall	Raises Meta-wide time spent and data signals

- **Revenue mix:** 100% ads, rolled out globally in 2026; not broken out from Meta's $60.4B Q2'26 FoA revenue.
- **Users vs payers:** 500M+ MAU pay nothing; payers are Meta's existing millions of advertisers.
- **Unit economics:** Near-zero marginal infra and sales cost: reuses Instagram identity, Meta ads stack and sales force.
- **Growth levers:** Raise DAU/MAU from ~30%, India and Asia growth, ad load ramp, creator incentives.

Friction points to discuss

- Feed full of engagement bait and irrelevant strangers
- Weak real-time news versus X during live events
- Many signups never return; low DAU/MAU ratio
- Political content deprioritised, frustrating news creators
- Tied to Instagram identity; separate account deletion historically hard

Competitors and market

- **Text social:** X, Bluesky, Mastodon, LinkedIn for professionals
- **Attention:** Instagram (sibling), TikTok, Reddit for discussion
- **India:** X, Koo (shut 2024), ShareChat
- **Edge:** Instagram graph distribution and Meta ads stack from day one
- **Risk:** Cannibalises Instagram time; may never become the real-time news habit

Recent news and direction

- **Jun 2026:** Threads crosses 500M monthly users, Meta's fastest app to that scale
- **May 2026:** DMs launch on web; 350M DMs sent weekly
- **Apr 2026:** Full ad inventory opened to global advertisers, 450M+ MAU
- **Watch:** DAU/MAU, Threads ad revenue disclosure, X and Bluesky share in news

Sources: Meta earnings and newsroom, The Next Web, Storyboard18, analyst estimates and press coverage. Revenue and DAU are estimates. Prepared Oct 2026.

Facebook

The world's largest social network: friends, groups, video, Marketplace

Founded: **2004 by Mark Zuckerberg and co-founders** Owner: **Meta Platforms (renamed from Facebook Inc., 2021)** HQ: **Menlo Park, California**
CEO / Head: **Zuckerberg (Meta CEO); Tom Alison, Head of Facebook** Users: **~3.07B MAU, ~2.1B DAU (2026 est.)** Meta revenue: **FY25 $201B (+22%); Q2'26 $60.8B (+28%)**
Family DAP: **3.6B daily people, Jun 2026 (+3%)** India: **Largest market by users (~375M+ est.)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Give people the power to build community and bring the world closer together.
- **Vision:** Stay the everyday app for friends, communities and local life, while winning back young adults.
- **Core strategy:** Shift from friend feed to AI-recommended video and discovery engine; recommendations lift time spent.
- **Moat:** 3B-user graph, Groups and Marketplace network effects, and the deepest ad-targeting data in the world.
- **Key bet:** Young adults: Local tab, Marketplace in nav bar, Dating Matchmaker, Messenger Communities, full-screen video.
- **Your view:** Can Facebook be cool again for 18-29s, or should it optimise for its 35+ core?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Facebook
Everyday users	25+ adults keeping up with friends, family	Want updates, events, birthdays in one place	Everyone they know is there; Groups, Events, Memories
Young adults	18-29 in US and emerging markets	Find local things, buy and sell cheaply, meet people	Marketplace, Local tab, Dating, full-screen video
Community admins	Group owners, local organisers, fan groups	Need tools to run large communities	Groups with moderation tools, admin assist, Messenger Communities
Advertisers / SMBs	200M+ businesses, D2C, local shops	Need customers at low CAC with measurement	Advantage+ AI campaigns, Pages, click-to-message, Marketplace listings
Creators / publishers	Video creators, media pages	Need reach and payouts beyond YouTube	Facebook content monetisation program, Reels reach, cross-post from Instagram

Product portfolio and metrics

Social core

Feed	Friends, Pages and AI-recommended posts
Groups	Interest and local communities, public or private
Friends tab / Events	Friend requests, birthdays, event discovery
Messenger	Chat app, Communities for topic-based group chats
North Star	Daily users having meaningful interactions with friends or groups
Key metrics	DAU, comments and shares, Group participation, Messenger threads
Guardrails	Misinformation prevalence, integrity reports, notification fatigue

Video and discovery

Video tab / Reels	Full-screen player for short, long and live
Local tab	Nearby Reels, Marketplace, Groups and Events in one place
Meta AI	Assistant integrated into feed, search and chat
North Star	Time spent on satisfying recommended video per DAU
Key metrics	Video watch time, recommended content share, young-adult DAU
Guardrails	Clickbait and unoriginal content share, user satisfaction surveys

Commerce and matching

Marketplace	Local and shipped buy-sell listings; used by 1 in 4 young-adult DAUs
Facebook Dating	Free dating with Matchmaker friend-swiping
Ads Manager / Pages	Business presence and Advantage+ campaigns
North Star	Successful transactions or matches per weekly user
Key metrics	Listings, buyer messages, sell-through, ad ROAS
Guardrails	Scam and fraud rate, counterfeit listings, user safety reports

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Feed and video ads	3B monthly users	Brands, SMBs, agencies, app developers	AI-targeted auction ads; CPM/CPC/CPA bidding
Click-to-message ads	Users chatting with businesses	SMBs, especially in India, Brazil, SE Asia	Ads open Messenger or WhatsApp threads
Marketplace ads	Shoppers browsing local listings	Retailers, auto and property sellers	Sponsored listings in Marketplace; partner catalog integrations
Meta Verified	Creators and businesses	Subscribers, monthly fee	Verification badge, impersonation protection, support

- **Revenue mix:** FoA Q2'26 $60.4B, of which $59.4B ads (+27%); Facebook app is a large share, not broken out.
- **Users vs payers:** Billions of free users; millions of advertisers pay; US/Canada ARPU far above Asia-Pacific.
- **Unit economics:** Q2'26 impressions +14%, price per ad +12%; FoA margins fund Reality Labs and AI capex.
- **Growth levers:** AI ranking and ad models, video ad load, business messaging, Marketplace and Meta AI ads.
- **Cost side:** 2026 capex guided $115-135B for superintelligence labs and AI infrastructure.

Friction points to discuss

- Feed feels cluttered with recommendations, not friends
- Seen as an 'older people' app by Gen Z
- Scams, fake accounts and spam in Marketplace and Groups
- Privacy distrust lingering since Cambridge Analytica
- Too many tabs and features; hard to navigate

Competitors and market

- **Social / video:** TikTok, YouTube, Snapchat, X; Instagram internally
- **Commerce:** Craigslist, OLX, eBay, Nextdoor, Quikr in India
- **Dating:** Tinder, Hinge, Bumble
- **Ads:** Google, Amazon Ads, TikTok, retail media networks
- **Edge:** Scale plus targeting data plus AI ad tools no rival matches
- **Risk:** Ageing user base, regulation (EU DMA, privacy), AI capex eroding margins

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Meta Q2: revenue $60.8B (+28%), DAP 3.6B, ad prices +12%
- **Jan 2026:** Meta guides 2026 capex $115-135B for AI and superintelligence labs
- **2025-26:** Young-adult push: Local tab, Marketplace in nav, Dating Matchmaker
- **Watch:** Young-adult DAU trend, Meta AI monetisation, EU less-personalised ads

Sources: Meta 10-K FY25, Q2 2026 earnings release, Meta newsroom, SocialPilot/Buffer user estimates, press coverage. App-level figures are estimates. Prepared Oct 2026.

X (formerly Twitter)

Real-time public conversation app, now part of SpaceX's xAI unit

Founded: **2006 as Twitter; renamed X in Jul 2023** Ownership: **Musk bought 2022 ($44B); merged into xAI Mar 2025** Parent now: **SpaceX acquired xAI Feb 2026; SPCX listed Jun 2026**
Leader: **Musk; no CEO since Yaccarino quit Jul 2025** Product head: **Nikita Bier** Users: **~550M MAU incl. Grok (Mar 2026 claim)** Revenue: **X ads + subs ~$3.3B 2025 (Sacra est.)**
Ads: **Q2'26 ads ~$367M vs $1.08B Q2'22 (est.)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Be the global town square and, per Musk, the 'everything app' for content, payments and AI.
- **Vision:** Super-app combining posts, video, Grok AI, X Money payments and trading via Smart Cashtags.
- **Core strategy:** Less dependence on brand ads; subscriptions (Premium), creator payouts, data and distribution for Grok.
- **AI flywheel:** X posts train and ground Grok; Grok lives inside X, driving engagement and Premium upsell.
- **Lesson:** Mass layoffs and moderation cuts kept product alive but brand-safety exodus halved ad revenue.
- **Your view:** Is X now a data asset for xAI rather than a standalone social product, and does that matter?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose X (formerly Twitter)
News and power users	Journalists, politicians, investors, sports fans	Need real-time information and direct audience reach	Fastest breaking news, open graph, Community Notes
Creators	Commentators, tech and crypto influencers	Want monetisation and long-form reach	Revenue sharing for Premium creators, subscriptions, long posts and video
Premium subscribers	Heavy users wanting verification and Grok	Want reach boost, fewer ads, AI tools	Checkmark, reply prioritisation, Grok access, edit and longer posts
Advertisers	Performance advertisers, some returning brands	Brand safety concerns and weaker measurement	Cheap CPMs, unique live-event audience, Grok-powered ad tools

Product portfolio and metrics

Social core

Timeline (For You / Following)	Algorithmic and chronological post feeds
Community Notes	Crowd-sourced fact-check context on posts
Communities and Spaces	Topic groups and live audio rooms
Video and XChat	Video tab, encrypted DMs and calls
North Star	Daily users engaging with real-time conversations
Key metrics	mDAU, posts and replies per user, time spent, retention
Guardrails	Hate and spam prevalence, bot share, advertiser brand-safety incidents

Subscriptions and AI

X Premium / Premium+	Paid tiers: verification, fewer ads, Grok access
Grok in X	xAI chatbot embedded; ~117M Grok users
Creator subscriptions	Fans pay creators monthly for exclusive posts
North Star	Paying subscribers retained month over month
Key metrics	Subs count, churn, Grok queries per user, ARPPU
Guardrails	Pay-to-win reply spam, Grok misinformation incidents

Payments and ads

X Money	P2P payments, Visa debit card; beta from Jun 2026
Smart Cashtags	Live prices and trading of stocks and crypto
X Ads	Promoted posts, video ads, Grok-assisted targeting
North Star	Monthly users completing a transaction on X
Key metrics	Payment volume, active wallets, ad revenue, CPM
Guardrails	Fraud rate, regulatory licences, chargebacks

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Advertising	All free users	Advertisers, mainly performance and SMB	Promoted posts and video ads, auction CPM
Subscriptions	Premium and Premium+ users	Users, monthly or annual	Tiered fees via app stores and web
Data licensing / API	Developers, researchers, AI firms	Enterprises; xAI internally	Paid API tiers; data feeds Grok training
X Money (emerging)	US users sending and spending money	Merchants and card network fees	Interchange, transaction fees, cashback-led adoption

- **Revenue mix:** 2025 est. ~$3.3B from ads and subs (Sacra); ads now well below $4.5B 2021 peak.
- **Users vs payers:** ~550M claimed MAU; small paying Premium base; advertisers concentrated in performance budgets.
- **Unit economics:** ~80% headcount cut lowered costs; but xAI lost $6.4B on $3.2B revenue in 2025.
- **Growth levers:** Grok bundling, X Money, Smart Cashtag trading, video, winning back brand advertisers.

Friction points to discuss

- Bots, spam and reply-guy Premium accounts in replies
- Brand-safety concerns keep major advertisers away
- Paid verification makes checkmarks less trustworthy
- Frequent rule and feature changes confuse users
- Perceived political bias pushes users to Threads, Bluesky

Competitors and market

- **Text social:** Threads (500M+ MAU), Bluesky, Mastodon, LinkedIn
- **Video / news:** YouTube, TikTok, Reddit, Substack
- **AI assistants:** ChatGPT, Gemini, Meta AI vs Grok
- **Payments:** Venmo, Cash App, PayPal, Robinhood for trading
- **Edge:** Unmatched real-time news graph plus Musk reach plus xAI compute
- **Risk:** Ad decline, EU DSA fines, Grok content controversies, key-person risk

Recent news and direction

- **Jun 2026:** SpaceX lists on Nasdaq (SPCX), bundling xAI, Grok and X
- **Jun 2026:** X Money expands to more US Premium users
- **Feb 2026:** SpaceX acquires xAI (incl. X) at ~$1.25T combined value
- **Watch:** X Money scale, ad revenue trend, X disclosure inside SpaceX filings

Sources: SpaceX/xAI merger coverage, Sacra estimates, SpaceX IPO filings coverage, Bloomberg and press reports. X metrics are company claims or third-party estimates. Prepared Oct 2026.

Snapchat (Snap Inc.)

Camera-first messaging app for close friends, with AR and Specs

Founded: **2011 by Evan Spiegel, Bobby Murphy** HQ / Listed: **Santa Monica; NYSE: SNAP (IPO 2017)** CEO: **Evan Spiegel (co-founder)** Revenue: **Q2'26 $1.60B (+19% YoY)**
Users: **Q2'26 493M DAU (+5%), 971M MAU** ARPU: **Q2'26 $3.25 per DAU (vs $2.87)** Snapchat+: **~25M subs; subs run-rate >$1B** India: **Large DAU market (~200M+ est.), low ARPU**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Snap is a camera company; we contribute to human progress by empowering people to express themselves.
- **Vision:** Computing overlaid on the world through AR glasses (Specs), built on Snapchat's camera and Lens ecosystem.
- **Core strategy:** Own close-friend communication, grow content (Spotlight, Stories), and diversify revenue via subscriptions.
- **Moat:** Opens to camera, ephemeral close-friend culture, Gen Z habit, Lens Studio AR developer ecosystem.
- **Key bet:** Specs consumer AR glasses at $2,195 shipping fall 2026; plus AI Lenses and Snapchat+ tiers.
- **Your view:** Should Snap spend on $2,195 AR glasses while ad ARPU still trails Meta by 10x?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Snapchat (Snap Inc.)
Gen Z / teens	13-24, US, Europe, India	Want private, low-pressure sharing with close friends	Disappearing Snaps, streaks, Bitmoji, no public likes on chats
Snapchat+ subscribers	Power users, streak and Memories savers	Want exclusive features and Memories storage	Early features, streak restores, 250GB-5TB storage, Platinum ad-free
Creators	Spotlight and Stories creators	Need payouts and reach with young audience	Unified creator monetisation program, Spotlight distribution
Advertisers	SMBs, D2C, entertainment, app installs	Need to reach Gen Z who skip Facebook	Sponsored Snaps in chat, AR Lens ads, improved performance ad stack
AR developers	Lens creators and Specs developers	Need distribution and tools for AR	Lens Studio, Snap OS, 300M+ daily AR users

Product portfolio and metrics

Communication

Camera and Snaps	Disappearing photo and video messages with Lenses
Chat	Messaging, calls, group chats, streaks
Snap Map	Friend location sharing and local discovery
My AI	Built-in AI chatbot companion
North Star	Daily users sending Snaps to close friends
Key metrics	DAU, Snaps sent per user, streak count, D30 retention
Guardrails	Teen safety reports, unwanted contact, location privacy complaints

Content

Spotlight	Short-form vertical video feed
Stories / Discover	Friends' and publishers' stories
Memories	Saved Snaps; paid storage above 5GB
North Star	Time spent watching content per DAU
Key metrics	Spotlight watch time, creator posts, Stories views
Guardrails	Content policy violations, creator churn

Monetisation and AR

Snapchat+ / Platinum	Subscription tiers with features, storage, ad-free
Sponsored Snaps and Lens ads	Ads in chat inbox and AR try-ons
Specs	Standalone AR glasses, $2,195, fall 2026
Lens Studio	AR creation tools for developers
North Star	Revenue per DAU (ads plus subscriptions)
Key metrics	ARPU, sub count and churn, ad CPM, Specs units
Guardrails	Ad load in chat, DAU growth, user sentiment

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Advertising	Free users in Stories, Spotlight, Chat	Brands, SMBs, app developers	Auction CPM/CPC; Sponsored Snaps, AR Lens ads
Snapchat+ subscriptions	~25M paying power users	Users monthly or annually	Tiered: Lite, Snapchat+, Platinum ad-free
Memories storage	Users over 5GB of saved Snaps	Users	Paid 100GB storage plan or bundle in Plus tiers
Hardware (Specs)	Early AR adopters and developers	Consumers	Device sales at $2,195; future app ecosystem

- **Revenue mix:** Q2'26: ads $1.28B (+9%), other revenue $316M (+85%), mostly subscriptions.
- **Users vs payers:** 493M DAU vs ~25M Snapchat+ subs (~5%); NA ARPU far above Rest of World.
- **Unit economics:** Q2'26 adj. EBITDA $250M, net loss $164M; Apr 2026 16% layoffs save ~$500M/yr.
- **Growth levers:** Subscriptions, Sponsored Snaps, SMB performance ads, India monetisation, Specs.

Friction points to discuss

- Confusing UI; hard for new or older users
- Streak pressure and anxiety among teens
- Paid Memories storage angered long-time users
- Ads appearing inside private Chat inbox
- Weak search and content discovery vs TikTok

Competitors and market

- **Messaging:** Instagram DMs, WhatsApp, iMessage, Discord
- **Short video:** TikTok, Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts
- **AR glasses:** Meta Ray-Ban Display ($799), Apple Vision Pro, Android XR
- **Ads:** Meta, TikTok, Google for Gen Z budgets
- **Edge:** Camera-first close-friend habit plus Snapchat+ proving users will pay
- **Risk:** Meta copying features, teen-safety laws, Specs cash burn, low ARPU

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** Q2: revenue $1.6B (+19%), DAU 493M, subscriptions past $1B run-rate
- **Jun 2026:** Specs AR glasses unveiled at AWE: $2,195, shipping fall 2026
- **Apr 2026:** Cuts ~1,000 jobs (16%), citing AI; $400M Perplexity deal ended
- **Watch:** Specs sales, Snapchat+ growth, North America DAU, profitability

Sources: Snap Q2 2026 8-K and 10-Q, TechCrunch, UploadVR/9to5Google, press coverage. India figures are estimates. Prepared Oct 2026.

WeChat (Weixin)

Tencent's messaging super-app: chat, pay, mini-programs, content, commerce

Founded: **Jan 2011 by Allen Zhang's team at Tencent** Owner/Listed: **Tencent Holdings, HKEX: 0700** Users: **1.439B Weixin+WeChat MAU, Q2 2026 (+2%)**
Tencent revenue: **FY25 RMB751.8B (+14%); profit RMB267B** Latest quarter: **Q2 2026 RMB204.8B (+11%); ads +22%** FinTech: **FinTech and Business Services RMB60.3B, Q2 2026 (+9%)**
Mini-programs: **~945M MAU, ~764M DAU, 2025 (est.)** Leaders: **Pony Ma (Tencent CEO); Allen Zhang (Weixin head)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Tencent: Value for users, tech for good. Weixin: connect people to people, services and information.
- **Philosophy:** Allen Zhang's restraint: use and leave, minimal pushy ads, tools serve users; platform over owning every service.
- **Core strategy:** Daily messaging habit plus wallet identity, then open platform: Official Accounts, mini-programs, Channels, Mini Shops.
- **Moat:** Social graph of 1.4B, payments built into chat, 4M+ mini-programs; switching means losing your social life.
- **Key bet:** AI agents (Yuanbao, Xiaowei) that complete tasks across mini-programs; AI ad targeting; Channels commerce.
- **Your view:** Is the super-app a China-specific accident of timing, or can X, Grab or Paytm replicate it?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose WeChat (Weixin)
Consumers	Nearly every smartphone user in China	Juggling many apps for chat, payments and daily services	One trusted app with friends, wallet and services; no new downloads
Merchants	SMBs, retailers, restaurants, offline shops	Need cheap payments, customer reach and repeat-visit tools	QR payments, mini-program storefronts, private-domain groups and Official Accounts
Developers / brands	Mini-program, mini-game and service builders	App-store fees and costly app installs	Instant distribution via chats, search, QR codes; lightweight build
Advertisers	Brands, game studios, e-commerce sellers	Need targeted reach and closed-loop conversion	Moments, Channels, search ads linked to mini-program checkout
Creators	Official Account writers and Channels creators	Monetising audience beyond Douyin's algorithmic feed	Social-graph distribution, tipping, live commerce, ad revenue share

Product portfolio and metrics

Communication and social

Chats and Groups	Messaging, voice, video; the daily habit anchor
Moments	Friends-only feed; key ad surface
Channels	Short video and live-streaming with commerce
Official Accounts	Publisher and brand content subscriptions
North Star	Daily active users sending messages
Key metrics	MAU, time spent, Channels watch time, ad load
Guardrails	Ad fatigue, spam, censorship and privacy trust

Mini-programs and commerce

Mini Programs	Lightweight in-app apps for any service, no install
Mini Games	Casual games; China mini-games market ~RMB53.5B 2025
Mini Shops	Native e-commerce storefronts with gifting and group-buy
Weixin Search	Search across chats, articles, services and mini-programs
North Star	Weekly services completed via mini-programs
Key metrics	Mini-program DAU, GMV, mini-game revenue, developer count
Guardrails	Developer take-rate disputes, low-quality spam programs

Payments and fintech

Weixin Pay	QR, P2P transfers, red packets; foreign cards supported
Licaitong	Wealth management products marketplace
WeLoan / credit	Consumer loans via WeBank partnership
North Star	Monthly payment transactions per active user
Key metrics	Commercial payment volume, take rate, wealth AUM, loan balance
Guardrails	Fraud rate, PBOC compliance, credit losses

AI

Yuanbao	Tencent AI assistant inside Weixin, Hunyuan plus DeepSeek
Xiaowei agent	Task agent calling mini-programs; beta from Jun 2026
AI ad engine	AI recommendation models raising ad conversion across Moments and Channels
North Star	Tasks completed end-to-end by AI agents
Key metrics	Agent DAU, task success rate, payments initiated via agent
Guardrails	Wrong actions, privacy leaks, compute cost per task

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Marketing services	Users see Moments, Channels, search ads	Advertisers and merchants	Performance ads, AI-targeted; RMB43.6B Q2 2026 (+22%)
FinTech (Weixin Pay)	Consumers and merchants	Merchants; wealth and loan partners	~0.6% merchant fee, withdrawal fees, wealth and loan commissions (est.)
Mini-games and VAS	Gamers, users buying stickers	Players, developers via revenue share	In-game purchases, platform fees and ad revenue share
Mini Shops / Channels commerce	Shoppers and sellers	Sellers	Technical service fees on GMV plus ads

- **Revenue mix:** Weixin is not reported alone; it powers Tencent ads, fintech and mini-games across RMB204.8B quarterly revenue.
- **Users vs payers:** Chat is free for 1.4B users; merchants, advertisers and game players fund the ecosystem.
- **Unit economics:** Low ad load versus peers leaves headroom; payments thin-margin but feeds data and ads.
- **Growth levers:** AI ad targeting, Channels and Mini Shops commerce, mini-games, AI agents booking services.
- **Why not abroad:** Outside China, Apple/Google, cards, entrenched apps and antitrust block bundling; WeChat itself stayed China-centric.

Friction points to discuss

- Bloated app; services buried under many menus
- Outsiders struggle with China ID and bank linking
- Censorship and surveillance concerns limit global trust
- Mini-program quality inconsistent, many low-value spam programs
- Group chat overload and notification fatigue for users

Competitors and market

- **China payments:** Alipay (Ant Group), UnionPay QuickPass, Douyin Pay, Meituan Pay
- **Content / commerce:** Douyin, Kuaishou, Xiaohongshu, Alibaba Taobao, PDD
- **Global super-apps:** X Money, Grab, Gojek, Paytm, Tata Neu, LINE, Kakao
- **AI assistants:** Doubao (ByteDance), Qwen (Alibaba), DeepSeek
- **Edge:** Messaging first: every service rides a daily social habit
- **Risk:** Regulation, Douyin's attention share, US app bans, AI disruption of app entry

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** Q2: revenue RMB204.8B (+11%), ads +22% from AI targeting; MAU 1.439B
- **Aug 2026:** Contrast: X Money goes live for all US Premium users; WeChat-style bet
- **Jun 2026:** Weixin begins testing Xiaowei AI agent that operates mini-programs
- **Watch:** Agent commerce in Weixin, AI capex returns, whether X Money drives daily use

Sources: Tencent FY2025 and Q2 2026 results, Tencent IR, 36Kr, industry mini-program estimates, CNBC/KrAsia super-app analysis. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

AWS (Amazon Web Services)

World's largest cloud: compute, storage, databases, custom chips and Bedrock AI

Founded: **2006 (S3, EC2), Amazon subsidiary** HQ / Listed: **Seattle; part of Amazon (NASDAQ: AMZN)** Latest quarter: **Q2 2026 $42.2B (+37% YoY, 18-qtr high)**
Profit: **Q2 2026 op inc $16.6B, ~39% margin** Backlog: **$496B end-Q2 2026 (vs $364B in Q1)** Run-rate / Capex: **~$169B ARR; Amazon 2026 capex ~$220B**
Market share: **~28% Q2 2026 (Synergy), down 2 pts YoY** CEO: **Matt Garman (since Jun 2024)** India: **Mumbai + Hyderabad regions; $21B+ pledged 2026-30**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Be Earth's most customer-centric cloud: give builders of every size the broadest, deepest set of on-demand IT primitives.
- **Vision:** Every application and AI agent runs on AWS; Jassy calls it a potential $1 trillion revenue business.
- **Core strategy:** Primitives over solutions: 200+ services, pay-as-you-go, relentless price cuts, then layer Bedrock and agents on top.
- **Moat:** Largest installed base and partner ecosystem, operational reliability record, Graviton and Trainium silicon lowering cost per workload.
- **Key bet:** Trainium plus model choice: Anthropic up to 5 GW, OpenAI ~2 GW from 2027; OpenAI models on Bedrock since Apr 2026.
- **Your view:** AWS grew 37% but lost share to Google: is being model-neutral a moat, or proof it lacks a frontier model?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose AWS (Amazon Web Services)
Enterprises	Banks, retailers, telcos migrating from data centres	Legacy data centres slow, costly; need security, compliance, global reach	Broadest services, mature security certifications, migration programs and largest SI partner network
Startups / digital natives	SaaS, consumer apps, Indian unicorns	Need to scale fast without upfront hardware capex	Credits via Activate, pay-as-you-go, default choice of most engineers
AI labs and builders	Anthropic, OpenAI, model and agent startups	GPU scarcity and soaring training and inference cost	Trainium price-performance, gigawatt-scale capacity, Bedrock distribution to enterprise buyers
Public sector	Governments, defence, regulated Indian PSUs	Data sovereignty, classified workloads, strict residency rules	GovCloud, sovereign cloud offerings, local regions in India and EU
Partners / ISVs	SIs, Marketplace sellers, MSPs	Need a channel to reach cloud budgets	AWS Marketplace lets customers burn committed spend on partner software

Product portfolio and metrics

Core infrastructure

EC2	Virtual servers incl. Graviton CPUs and Nvidia GPU instances
S3	Object storage, backbone of data lakes
Lambda / EKS	Serverless functions and managed Kubernetes
RDS / Aurora / DynamoDB	Managed relational and NoSQL databases
North Star	Compute hours consumed by active production workloads
Key metrics	Revenue growth, backlog, net revenue retention, utilisation, cost per instance-hour
Guardrails	Availability SLAs, major outage count, security incidents, customer bill shock

AI and silicon

Amazon Bedrock	Managed access to Claude, GPT, Nova, Llama and more
Trainium / Inferentia	Custom AI chips; Trainium sold out through 2027
SageMaker	Build, train and deploy ML models
Bedrock AgentCore	Runtime, memory and identity for production AI agents
North Star	Inference tokens served on AWS for paying production workloads
Key metrics	AI run-rate (~$25B), Trainium share of capacity, Bedrock active customers
Guardrails	Model latency, capacity wait times, gross margin per GW deployed

Apps and developer tools

Amazon Quick	AI assistant for work with desktop app and agents
Kiro	Agentic IDE for spec-driven coding
Amazon Connect	AI contact centre, now hiring and supply-chain agents
AWS Marketplace	Buy third-party software against AWS commits
North Star	Weekly active business users completing tasks with AWS apps
Key metrics	Seats, WAU, Connect minutes, Marketplace GMV, attach to infra
Guardrails	Partner conflict, data privacy complaints, churn after free trials

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Usage-based compute and storage	Developers, IT teams, data engineers	Enterprise and startup cloud budgets	Per second, per GB; discounts via Savings Plans and reserved instances
Committed spend contracts	Large enterprises and AI labs	CIOs, AI labs (multi-year)	Multi-year commits for discounts; builds $496B backlog
AI services (Bedrock, chips)	App builders, agent developers	Enterprises, model labs	Per token, per accelerator hour, or provisioned throughput
Marketplace and support	Customers buying partner software	ISVs (fee) and customers (support tiers)	Listing fee share; support priced as percentage of spend

- **Revenue mix:** ~17-18% of Amazon revenue but well over half of operating income; AI run-rate ~$25B within $169B ARR.
- **Users vs payers:** Engineers choose services; CIOs and CFOs sign commits; AI labs are now a few huge payers.
- **Unit economics:** Op margin ~39% Q2 2026; depreciation from $220B capex and memory price spikes pressure future margins.
- **Growth levers:** Convert $496B backlog as capacity lands, Trainium cost advantage, OpenAI on Bedrock, agents, sovereign regions.
- **Constraint:** Power and chip supply, not demand, caps growth; capacity added faster is revenue recognised sooner.

Friction points to discuss

- Complex, unpredictable bills; hard to forecast spend
- 200+ services with overlapping names confuse newcomers
- Console UX dated versus newer developer platforms
- GPU and Trainium capacity waitlists for AI workloads
- High egress fees discourage multicloud architectures

Competitors and market

- **Hyperscale:** Microsoft Azure (~20%), Google Cloud (~15%), Oracle OCI
- **AI infra:** CoreWeave, Nebius, Oracle for GPU capacity
- **India:** Azure, Google Cloud, Jio-led cloud, Yotta, CtrlS sovereign clouds
- **Edge:** Scale, reliability, custom silicon economics, and widest model choice
- **Risk:** Share loss to rivals with own frontier models; concentration in Anthropic

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** OpenAI GPT-6 Astra GA on Bedrock; Amazon Quick desktop app launched
- **Jul 2026:** Q2: $42.2B, +37%; backlog $496B; Amazon capex raised to ~$220B
- **Apr 2026:** Azure exclusivity ends; OpenAI models, Codex arrive on Amazon Bedrock
- **Watch:** Can capacity build keep pace? Trainium sales outside AWS; share versus Google

Sources: Amazon Q1-Q2 2026 results, Synergy Research Q2 2026, AWS announcements, press coverage. North star/metrics are PM judgement for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Google Cloud

Alphabet's cloud: AI-first infrastructure, TPUs, Gemini, data analytics and Workspace

Founded: **2008 (App Engine); GCP brand 2011** HQ / Listed: **Sunnyvale; Alphabet segment (NASDAQ: GOOGL)** Latest quarter: **Q2 2026 $24.8B (+82% YoY)**
Profit: **Q2 2026 op inc $8.8B, ~35.6% margin** Backlog: **$514B end-Q2 2026 (>$460B in Q1)** Capex: **Alphabet 2026 guide $195-205B (raised Jul)**
Market share: **~15% Q2 2026 (Synergy), up 2 pts YoY** CEO: **Thomas Kurian (since Jan 2019)** India: **Mumbai, Delhi regions; $15B Vizag 1 GW AI hub**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Accelerate every organisation's ability to digitally transform and reimagine its business through data and AI.
- **Vision:** The full-stack AI cloud: own chips, models, data platform, security and agent apps, sold as one.
- **Core strategy:** Lead with Gemini and TPUs to win AI workloads, then pull in BigQuery, security and Workspace.
- **Moat:** Only hyperscaler with in-house frontier model plus decade of TPUs; DeepMind research and Google-scale infrastructure.
- **Key bet:** Selling TPUs beyond Google Cloud (Blackstone JV), Wiz multicloud security, Gemini Enterprise agents.
- **Your view:** Backlog is ~5 years of revenue: is Google Cloud now a TPU wholesaler with lab concentration risk?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Google Cloud
AI labs and model builders	Anthropic, frontier labs, AI startups	Nvidia GPU scarcity and inference cost at scale	TPU price-performance, gigawatt capacity, Gemini and Vertex tooling
Data-led enterprises	Retail, media, banks running analytics	Siloed data, slow analytics, hard to apply AI	BigQuery plus Gemini on unified data; Agentic Data Cloud
Digital natives	Consumer internet, gaming, Indian startups	Need scalable Kubernetes and low-cost AI APIs	GKE heritage, generous credits, Gemini API pricing
Security buyers	CISOs on multicloud estates	Fragmented visibility across AWS, Azure, GCP risks	Wiz plus Mandiant plus Security Operations across clouds
Workspace users	SMBs, schools, frontline enterprises	Want affordable productivity with built-in AI	Gmail, Docs, Meet bundled with Gemini at lower price than Microsoft

Product portfolio and metrics

AI infrastructure

TPUs (Ironwood)	Seventh-gen custom AI accelerators, now sold to select external customers
Compute Engine / GKE	VMs with Nvidia GPUs and managed Kubernetes
Cloud Storage / Spanner	Object storage and globally distributed database
North Star	Accelerator hours sold under paying multi-year contracts
Key metrics	Backlog conversion, TPU utilisation, capacity online (GW), revenue per chip
Guardrails	Outage minutes, single-customer revenue concentration, delivery delays

AI platform and agents

Gemini Enterprise	Agent platform and AI workspace for every employee
Vertex AI	Model garden, tuning and deployment incl. Gemini, Claude
Gemini API	Developer access to Gemini models by token
Customer Engagement Suite	AI agents for contact centres
North Star	Enterprise agents running weekly in production on Gemini
Key metrics	Tokens processed, paid seats, agent deployments, API revenue growth
Guardrails	Hallucination incidents, data leakage, cost per token versus price

Data, security, productivity

BigQuery	Serverless data warehouse with built-in AI
Wiz	Multicloud security, acquired for $32B (closed Mar 2026)
Mandiant / SecOps	Threat intelligence, incident response and SIEM
Google Workspace	Gmail, Docs, Meet with Gemini built in
North Star	Customers using three or more Google Cloud product families
Key metrics	Cross-sell rate, Wiz ARR growth, Workspace paid seats, NRR
Guardrails	Wiz neutrality perception on AWS/Azure, seat churn, price-hike backlash

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Infrastructure (GCP)	Developers, AI labs, IT teams	Enterprises, startups, labs	Usage-based compute, storage; multi-year committed contracts
TPU capacity deals	Frontier labs, Blackstone JV customers	AI labs, neoclouds	Multi-GW reserved capacity; external chip sales ramping through 2026
AI platform	App and agent builders	Enterprises, ISVs	Per token, per agent, per seat for Gemini Enterprise
Workspace and security	Employees, security teams	IT and CISO budgets	Per-user subscriptions; Wiz priced by workloads protected

- **Revenue mix:** ~$99B annualised; GCP infra and AI now the bulk; Workspace a steady, slower-growing base.
- **Users vs payers:** Developers and data teams adopt; CIOs sign; a few AI labs drive outsized backlog.
- **Unit economics:** Margin up from 20.7% to 35.6% in a year; TPUs avoid Nvidia margin, but depreciation is rising.
- **Growth levers:** Convert $514B backlog, external TPU sales, Gemini Enterprise seats, Wiz cross-sell, new regions.
- **History:** Lost money until 2023; AI turned Google Cloud from distant third into fastest-growing hyperscaler.

Friction points to discuss

- Smaller enterprise sales and partner network than rivals
- Reputation for killing products hurts enterprise trust
- Capacity constraints delay large AI deployments
- Fewer regions and services than AWS in some markets
- TPU software stack less familiar than Nvidia CUDA

Competitors and market

- **Hyperscale:** AWS (~28%), Microsoft Azure (~20%), Oracle OCI
- **AI chips:** Nvidia, AWS Trainium, Microsoft Maia, AMD
- **Productivity:** Microsoft 365 Copilot dominates enterprise suites
- **Edge:** Only full stack: own model, own chips, data platform, security
- **Risk:** Backlog concentrated in few labs; capex drag if AI demand cools

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q2: $24.8B, +82%; backlog $514B; Alphabet capex raised to $195-205B
- **Apr 2026:** Next 2026: new TPUs, Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform; Vizag AI hub groundbreaking
- **Mar 2026:** Closes $32B Wiz acquisition, largest in Google history
- **Watch:** External TPU sales ramp, margin as depreciation grows, share gains versus Azure

Sources: Alphabet Q1-Q2 2026 results, Synergy Research Q2 2026, Google Cloud Next 2026, press coverage. North star/metrics are PM judgement for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Microsoft Azure

Microsoft's enterprise cloud: infrastructure, OpenAI-powered Foundry and hybrid, sold with Microsoft 365

Founded: **2010 (Windows Azure), Microsoft** HQ / Listed: **Redmond; Microsoft (NASDAQ: MSFT)** Azure growth: **Q4 FY26 (Jun 2026) +43%; FY26 >$100B**
Intelligent Cloud: **Q4 FY26 $39.3B (+32% YoY)** Microsoft Cloud: **Q4 FY26 $59.3B (+27%)** Backlog / Capex: **Commercial RPO $678B (+84%); Q4 capex $41B**
Market share: **~20% Q2 2026 (Synergy), flat YoY** Leaders: **Satya Nadella CEO; Scott Guthrie, Cloud + AI** India: **4 regions; Hyderabad live Aug 2026; $20.5B pledged**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Empower every person and every organisation on the planet to achieve more.
- **Vision:** The AI platform for the enterprise: one cloud from silicon to Copilot agents, trusted and compliant.
- **Core strategy:** Bundle Azure with Microsoft 365, Windows Server, SQL licences and Copilot; win via enterprise agreements.
- **Moat:** Deepest enterprise relationships, hybrid heritage, Entra identity, and privileged OpenAI IP rights.
- **Key bet:** Microsoft Foundry multi-model agent platform plus Fairwater AI datacentres and Maia chips to cut OpenAI dependence.
- **Your view:** OpenAI exclusivity ended Apr 2026 yet Azure accelerated: was OpenAI the moat, or the distribution?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Microsoft Azure
Microsoft-stack enterprises	Fortune 500, banks, governments on Windows/M365	Migrating legacy Windows, SQL, SAP workloads securely	Licence portability (Hybrid Benefit), single contract, existing Microsoft trust
AI app builders	Enterprise dev teams, ISVs building agents	Need frontier models with enterprise security and compliance	Foundry: OpenAI GPT-5.x first, plus Claude, Llama, Mistral, under Entra controls
OpenAI and AI labs	OpenAI, other model labs needing compute	Massive training and inference capacity at short notice	Fairwater supercomputer sites, Nvidia GB300 scale, long-term partnership
Regulated / sovereign	Public sector, defence, Indian BFSI	Data residency and sovereign control requirements	Sovereign cloud offerings, Azure Local, four in-country regions in India
Partners / CSPs	SIs, resellers, Marketplace ISVs	Need a channel into enterprise IT budgets	Huge partner program; Marketplace purchases count against Azure commits

Product portfolio and metrics

Infrastructure and hybrid

Azure Virtual Machines	Compute incl. Nvidia GPU and Cobalt Arm instances
Azure Kubernetes Service	Managed Kubernetes for containerised apps
Azure Arc / Azure Local	Manage on-prem and multicloud from Azure
Azure SQL / Cosmos DB	Managed relational and global NoSQL databases
North Star	Consumed Azure revenue from production workloads under enterprise agreements
Key metrics	Azure growth %, consumption vs commit, migration wins, capacity online
Guardrails	Outage frequency, capacity shortfalls, licence-change backlash

AI platform

Microsoft Foundry	Models, Agent Service, Foundry IQ; renamed at Build 2026
Azure OpenAI models	GPT-5.5/5.6 with enterprise security and data residency
Maia / Cobalt chips	In-house AI accelerator and Arm CPU
GitHub Copilot	AI coding agent driving Azure developer pull-through
North Star	Enterprise agents in production on Foundry each week
Key metrics	Tokens served, Foundry customers, AI revenue contribution to Azure points
Guardrails	Responsible-AI incidents, inference gross margin, OpenAI dependence share

Data and security

Microsoft Fabric	Unified analytics and data lake SaaS
Entra ID	Identity and access, the enterprise control plane
Defender / Sentinel	Cloud security posture and SIEM
North Star	Organisations running data and security estates on Microsoft
Key metrics	Fabric paid customers, Sentinel ingestion, cross-sell to Azure
Guardrails	Security breaches (trust), regulatory bundling complaints

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Azure consumption	IT and dev teams	Enterprises via enterprise agreements and MACC commits	Pay-as-you-go or prepaid commits with discounts
AI services (Foundry)	App and agent builders	Enterprises, ISVs	Per token, provisioned throughput units, agent runtime
OpenAI compute	OpenAI	OpenAI (large multi-year commitment)	Reserved capacity; major share of $678B RPO growth
Server licences in IC	On-prem and hybrid IT	Enterprises	Windows Server, SQL Server licences and subscriptions

- **Revenue mix:** Intelligent Cloud ~$39B/qtr: Azure plus server products, GitHub, Nuance; Azure is the growth engine.
- **Users vs payers:** Developers use; CIOs sign enterprise agreements; OpenAI is a mega-customer inflating backlog.
- **Unit economics:** AI infra lowers cloud gross margin; FY27 guide op margin down under a point; capex ~$175B.
- **Growth levers:** Convert RPO (~30% in 12 months), Foundry agents, capacity adds, Microsoft 365 Copilot pull-through.
- **Disclosure:** Microsoft reports Azure only as growth %; FY26 crossed $100B annual revenue for first time.

Friction points to discuss

- Capacity shortages delay customers' AI deployments
- Portal and service naming change often, confusing users
- Licensing rules seen as locking in Microsoft customers
- High-profile security incidents dent trust
- Costs hard to predict across consumption and commits

Competitors and market

- **Hyperscale:** AWS (~28%), Google Cloud (~15%), Oracle OCI
- **AI platforms:** Amazon Bedrock (now with OpenAI), Google Vertex, Anthropic direct
- **India:** AWS, Google Cloud, Yotta, Jio-led and sovereign clouds
- **Edge:** Enterprise distribution and bundling with Microsoft 365, Entra and GitHub
- **Risk:** OpenAI multicloud shift, capacity shortfalls, regulatory scrutiny of bundling

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** India South Central region (Hyderabad) goes live; part of $20.5B India pledge
- **Jul 2026:** Q4 FY26: Azure +43%, Intelligent Cloud $39.3B, RPO $678B
- **Apr 2026:** OpenAI deal amended; Azure no longer exclusive third-party cloud for OpenAI
- **Watch:** Q1 FY27 Azure growth, capacity adds, OpenAI share of backlog

Sources: Microsoft FY26 Q3-Q4 results, Synergy Research Q2 2026, Microsoft India announcements, press coverage. North star/metrics are PM judgement for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Netflix

World's largest subscription streamer, now adding ads, live events and games

Founded: **1997 (DVD rental), streaming since 2007** HQ: **Los Gatos, California, USA** Owner/Listed: **Public, NASDAQ: NFLX** Revenue: **2025 $45.2B (+16% YoY); 2026 guide ~$51B**
Members: **325M+ paid (Q4 2025, last disclosed)** Ads: **Ad tier 250M+ MAV; 2026 ad revenue target ~$3B** Margin: **2025 op. margin 29.5%; 2026 target 31.5%**
CEO/Head: **Co-CEOs Ted Sarandos and Greg Peters** India: **FY25 ₹3,769 cr (+32%); ~20M subs est.**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Entertain the world: whatever your taste, wherever you live, give you stories and joy on demand.
- **Vision:** Become the default home for TV time, the first app opened on every screen, globally.
- **Core strategy:** Global originals plus local-language hits that travel; scale spreads content cost thinner than any rival can.
- **Moat:** Recommendation data, brand, 190-country distribution, and a self-funding $18B+ content engine with no legacy TV to protect.
- **Key bet:** Ads and live events (NFL Christmas, WWE Raw, boxing) to lift ARM; walked from WBD, took $2.8B fee.
- **Your view:** Having stopped reporting subscribers, should Netflix chase reach in India with a cheaper ad tier or protect premium pricing?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Netflix
Binge viewers	Global households, 18-45, multi-screen	Scattered content across many apps; too much time choosing what to watch	Deep originals slate, best-in-class recommendations, reliable streaming quality worldwide
Price-sensitive	Emerging markets, mobile-first, students	Premium price unaffordable; password sharing crackdown removed free access	Mobile plan, ad tier, telco bundles (Jio, Airtel) lower entry price
Live/event fans	Sports, WWE and event viewers	Live sports locked in pay-TV bundles and many apps	Marquee live events included in existing subscription, no extra fee
Advertisers	Brands and agencies buying premium video	Linear TV reach declining; CTV inventory fragmented and poorly measured	Engaged, hard-to-reach audiences, in-house ad tech suite, programmatic buying
Creators/studios	Producers, local-language studios, talent	Limited global distribution for local stories	Upfront funding plus instant reach across 190 countries

Product portfolio and metrics

Subscription streaming

Standard with ads	Low-cost ad tier, now ~12 markets
Standard/Premium	Ad-free tiers, 4K and extra screens on Premium
Mobile plan (India etc.)	Single phone, SD, cheapest ad-free entry
Extra member	Paid sharing add-on after password crackdown
North Star	Monthly hours viewed per paying household
Key metrics	Net adds, churn, ARM, engagement share of TV time
Guardrails	Churn after price hikes, content spend per hour viewed

Advertising and live

Netflix Ads Suite	In-house ad server, measurement and programmatic
Live events	NFL Christmas games, WWE Raw, boxing, specials
Interactive ads	New formats, pause and AI-generated creative
North Star	Ad revenue per ad-tier monthly active viewer
Key metrics	MAV, fill rate, CPMs, ad load, live concurrency
Guardrails	Ad-tier engagement and churn vs ad-free, stream failures

Games and consumer products

Netflix Games	TV party games and mobile games, no ads
Netflix House	Physical fan experiences in US malls
Licensing/merch	Franchise merchandise from Stranger Things, Squid Game
North Star	Members engaging with an IP beyond the show
Key metrics	Game DAU, retention lift, merch revenue
Guardrails	Distraction from core video investment, brand fit

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Subscriptions	Paid households in 190 countries	Members monthly; telcos via bundles	Tiered monthly plans, regular price increases, paid sharing
Advertising	Ad-tier members	Brands and agencies	CPM-based upfronts and programmatic via own ad stack
Live events	All members	Members plus premium sponsors	Drives acquisition, retention and high-CPM ad inventory
Licensing/consumer products	Fans, partners	Licensees, visitors	Royalties, experiences, merchandise

- **Revenue mix:** ~94% subscription; ads ~6% of 2026 revenue (~$3B) but roughly doubling yearly.
- **Users vs payers:** One payer per household, several viewers; ad tier 250M+ monthly active viewers in mid-2026.
- **Unit economics:** Content is largely fixed cost; each new member is near-pure margin, lifting op. margin toward 31.5%.
- **Growth levers:** Price hikes, ad monetisation, live events, paid sharing, emerging-market bundles.
- **Capital:** ~$12.5B 2026 FCF; $25B buyback; $2.8B WBD break fee banked.

Friction points to discuss

- Endless scrolling; choice paralysis at home screen
- Repeated price hikes push serial churners to cancel
- Password-sharing crackdown felt punitive to families
- Shows cancelled after one season erode trust
- Ad tier lacks some titles and downloads

Competitors and market

- **Global SVOD:** Prime Video, Disney+, Paramount+ with HBO Max, Apple TV
- **Free/attention:** YouTube (top US TV share), TikTok, FAST channels
- **India:** JioHotstar, Prime Video, ZEE5, SonyLIV, microdrama apps
- **Advertising:** YouTube CTV, Amazon Prime Video ads, Roku, Hulu
- **Edge:** Scale, global hit factory, recommendation engine, profitability rivals cannot match
- **Risk:** YouTube winning TV time; ad ramp slower than promised; Paramount-WBD scale

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q2 revenue $12.6B (+13%); ads $618M missed; $25B buyback authorised
- **May 2026:** Upfront: ad tier reaches 250M+ global monthly active viewers
- **Feb 2026:** Walks away from $83B WBD deal; Paramount pays $2.8B break fee
- **Watch:** Q3 2026 results mid-Oct; can ads hit $3B and live sports scale?

Sources: Netflix shareholder letters Q4 2025 and Q2 2026, Netflix India RoC filings FY25, S&P Global, press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Amazon Prime Video

Amazon's streaming service, bundled with Prime, now ad-led with live sports

Launched: **2006 (Amazon Unbox); Prime Video 2011, global 2016** HQ: **Culver City / Seattle, USA (Amazon)** Owner/Listed: **Amazon.com Inc., NASDAQ: AMZN**
Revenue: **Not disclosed; Amazon ads Q2 2026 $19.8B (+26%)** Reach: **315M+ monthly ad-supported viewers globally (2026)** US ads: **115M+ Americans see Prime Video ads monthly**
Sports: **TNF, NBA (11-yr deal from 2025-26), NASCAR, WNBA** CEO/Head: **Mike Hopkins, SVP Prime Video and MGM Studios** India: **Prime ₹1,499/yr; ads since Jun 2025; MX Player merged**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make Prime irresistible: give members premium entertainment that raises Prime retention and shopping frequency.
- **Vision:** Be the one-stop TV destination: originals, live sports, and third-party channels in a single app.
- **Core strategy:** Video as Prime flywheel loss-leader; ads-on-by-default monetises the huge bundled base without new subscriptions.
- **Moat:** Prime bundle distribution, Amazon shopping data for closed-loop ad attribution, deep pockets for sports rights.
- **Key bet:** Live sports (NBA, TNF) and Amazon MGM IP like James Bond to win premium ad dollars.
- **Your view:** Should Prime Video be judged on its own P&L, or only on Prime retention and ad revenue it drives?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Amazon Prime Video
Prime shoppers	Households already paying for Prime delivery	Paying separately for many streaming apps	Video included free with Prime; no extra subscription decision needed
Sports fans	NFL, NBA, NASCAR viewers in US	Games scattered across cable and multiple streamers	Exclusive TNF and NBA package within existing Prime membership
India value seekers	Mobile-first, regional-language viewers	Expensive premium OTT; wants free regional content	Prime Lite, free MX Player content now inside Prime Video, Indian originals
Advertisers	Brands, especially Amazon sellers and CPG	Cannot link TV ad spend to actual sales	Amazon purchase data enables closed-loop measurement and shoppable ads
Channel partners	Apple TV, HBO Max, Paramount+, local apps	High customer acquisition cost for standalone apps	Prime Video Channels gives instant distribution and billing

Product portfolio and metrics

Prime Video core

Prime Video (with ads)	Default tier bundled with Prime membership
Ad-free add-on	US $2.99/mo; India ₹129/mo or ₹699/yr
Amazon MGM originals	Reacher, The Boys, Bond franchise, Indian originals
Prime Lite (India)	₹799/yr cheaper Prime with ad-supported video
North Star	Weekly active Prime members streaming
Key metrics	Hours per member, Prime renewal lift, original title reach
Guardrails	Churn after ads introduced, content cost per viewing hour

Live sports and free streaming

Thursday Night Football	Exclusive NFL package, top ad inventory
NBA on Prime	11-year rights including playoff games
Amazon MX Player	Free AVOD unified into Prime Video India, May 2026
FAST channels	Free linear channels inside the app
North Star	Ad-supported monthly reach
Key metrics	Avg minute audience, sell-through, CPM, new Prime sign-ups
Guardrails	Stream latency and outages, ad load complaints

Marketplace and transactions

Prime Video Channels	Resold add-on subscriptions like HBO Max, Apple TV
Rent/Buy store	Transactional new movies, TVOD
Amazon DSP / ads	Self-serve and programmatic CTV buying
North Star	Paid add-on subscriptions per Prime household
Key metrics	Channel attach rate, TVOD revenue, revenue share
Guardrails	Confusing paywalls inside app, partner churn

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Prime membership	Prime members worldwide	Members (bundled fee)	Video raises renewal and shopping spend; cost absorbed by Prime
Advertising	Ad-tier viewers, sports audiences	Brands, Amazon sellers	CPM ads, sports sponsorship, shoppable and interactive formats
Ad-free add-on	Ad-averse members	Members	Monthly or annual upcharge to remove ads
Channels and TVOD	Members and non-members	Viewers	Revenue share on resold subscriptions; rentals and purchases

- **Revenue mix:** Not reported; ads plus subscriptions inside Amazon segments. Live sport sold out in Q2 2026.
- **Users vs payers:** Viewers pay via Prime, often not for video; advertisers pay for 315M+ monthly ad reach.
- **Unit economics:** Content cost justified by Prime retention and higher basket; ads turned video into a margin line.
- **Growth levers:** NBA and sports, ads in more markets, India free tier via MX, channel add-ons.

Friction points to discuss

- Ads switched on without lowering Prime price
- Cluttered UI mixes free, rent and channel content
- Paywall surprises: title needs extra purchase or channel
- Sports scattered across Prime, apps and blackouts
- India viewers confused by Prime vs Lite vs MX

Competitors and market

- **Global SVOD:** Netflix, Disney+, Paramount+ with HBO Max, Apple TV
- **Sports/AVOD:** YouTube, Peacock, ESPN DTC, FAST services
- **India:** JioHotstar, Netflix, ZEE5, SonyLIV, YouTube
- **Retail media:** Walmart Connect plus Vizio, Roku, Google
- **Edge:** Free-with-Prime distribution and shopping data for ad attribution
- **Risk:** Seen as afterthought; ad fatigue; sports rights cost escalation

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Amazon ads $19.8B (+26%); TNF, NBA, NASCAR inventory sold out
- **Jun 2026:** First NBA season on Prime ends; global NBA viewing up 28%
- **May 2026:** Amazon MX Player unified into Prime Video in India
- **Watch:** TNF season ad yields, first Amazon-made Bond film progress

Sources: Amazon earnings Q2 2026, Amazon Ads 2026 upfront, aboutamazon.in, press coverage. Prime Video revenue undisclosed; metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

JioHotstar (formerly Disney+ Hotstar)

India's largest streamer: cricket, Disney/HBO content, regional shows, microdramas

Founded: **Hotstar 2015; JioHotstar launched 14 Feb 2025** Ownership: **JioStar JV: Reliance ~63%, Disney ~37% (Nov 2024)** Revenue: **JioStar FY26 ~₹35,000-36,000 cr (incl. TV)**
Latest qtr: **Q1 FY27 ₹10,946 cr (+14%), EBITDA ₹933 cr** Users: **530M avg MAU (Q1 FY27); ~700M during IPL** Paid subs: **~300M claimed peak (2025); 100M in 5 weeks**
Pricing: **Mobile ₹79/mo, Super ₹149/mo, Premium ₹2,199/yr** CEO/Head: **Kiran Mani, CEO Digital, JioStar** Rights: **IPL, ICC (to 2027), HBO Max, Disney, Peacock**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Bring every Indian premium sport and entertainment at a price as low as a cup of chai.
- **Vision:** Be India's single default screen across mobile and connected TV, from cricket to microdrama.
- **Core strategy:** Cricket as acquisition funnel; regional and global libraries retain; Jio telecom bundles convert free users to paid.
- **Moat:** Near-monopoly on Indian cricket rights plus Jio distribution to ~500M telecom users and Star TV library.
- **Lesson:** JioCinema's free IPL in 2023 forced the merger; free sports built reach but not profits, hence paywall return.
- **Your view:** With cricket rights locked, is the real risk now regulatory (CCI dominance) or user fatigue with price hikes?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose JioHotstar (formerly Disney+ Hotstar)
Cricket fans	Mass India, mobile-first, all ages	Need IPL and India matches live, cheaply, without lag	Exclusive IPL and ICC streaming, multi-cam, regional commentary, ₹79 mobile entry
Family CTV viewers	Urban households with smart TVs	Paying for Netflix, Prime and others separately	Disney, HBO Max, Star serials, live sports in one Premium plan
Bharat/regional	Tier 2-3 viewers, regional languages	Little affordable content in own language	Star regional channels, dubbed films, Tadka microdramas free with ads
Advertisers	FMCG, fantasy-alternatives, auto, D2C brands	Need mass reach beyond TV with targeting	IPL scale (700M users), CTV growth, Jio data for targeting
Telcos/partners	Jio, other telcos, content studios	Need sticky content to drive ARPU	Bundled prepaid packs boost recharge value and retention

Product portfolio and metrics

Streaming subscriptions

Mobile plan	₹79/mo, one phone, ad-supported HD
Super plan	₹149/mo or ₹1,099/yr, two devices incl. TV
Premium plan	₹2,199/yr, ad-free (non-live), 4K, four devices
Jio bundles	Subscriptions packaged with Jio prepaid and JioFiber
North Star	Paid subscribers retained 90 days after IPL ends
Key metrics	Paid subs, post-IPL churn, ARPU, Premium mix
Guardrails	Price-hike churn, piracy share, payment failure rate

Entertainment and short-form

Hotstar Specials	Indian originals across Hindi and regional languages
Global libraries	Disney, Marvel, HBO Max exclusive, Peacock content
Star serials	Next-day TV shows, the daily habit driver
Tadka	Free vertical microdramas, 100M users in two months
North Star	Weekly active non-sports viewers
Key metrics	Non-sport watch time, D30 retention, Tadka sessions
Guardrails	Content cost per hour, CPM dilution from short-form

Live sports

IPL and WPL	Exclusive digital and TV rights through 2027
ICC cricket	World Cups including T20 World Cup 2026
Other sports	Premier League, Wimbledon, kabaddi, regional leagues
North Star	Peak concurrent viewers per marquee match
Key metrics	Reach, watch time, CTV share, ad sell-through
Guardrails	Stream latency and buffering, ad load per over

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Subscriptions	Paid viewers, cricket-driven spikes	Consumers, Jio via bundles	Tiered monthly/annual plans, IPL-season conversion
Digital advertising	All viewers, especially live cricket	Brands and agencies	Per-over sponsorships, CPM ads, CTV and Tadka ads
TV (Star network)	Linear TV households	Advertisers and DTH/cable distributors	TV ads plus subscription fees; declining but cash-rich
Syndication/international	Global diaspora	Partners like STARZPLAY	Licensing content and sports rights abroad

- **Revenue mix:** JioStar spans TV and digital; digital subs and ads growing while TV ad income softens.
- **Users vs payers:** 530M MAU vs ~300M claimed paid peak; heavy non-paying, bundle-driven base.
- **Unit economics:** IPL rights (₹48,390 cr cycle, shared TV/digital) need ads plus subs; low ARPU limits margins.
- **Growth levers:** CTV upsell, price hikes, post-IPL retention via Tadka and serials, international licensing.

Friction points to discuss

- Subscribers churn right after IPL ends
- Frequent plan and price changes confuse users
- Ads still shown on live sports in Premium
- Device limits annoy shared family households
- Clunky discovery across sports, serials and Tadka

Competitors and market

- **Global SVOD:** Netflix, Prime Video (with MX Player), Apple TV
- **Indian OTT:** ZEE5, SonyLIV, Sun NXT, Aha, ALTT
- **Free/short-form:** YouTube, Instagram Reels, microdrama apps like Kuku TV
- **Piracy:** Illegal cricket streams and Telegram channels
- **Edge:** Cricket monopoly, Jio distribution and the biggest Indian content library
- **Risk:** Rights renewal costs post-2027, CCI scrutiny, low ARPU, WBD ownership change

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q1 FY27 revenue ₹10,946 cr; IPL 2026 reached ~700M on JioHotstar
- **Jun 2026:** Tadka microdrama hub crosses 100M users within two months
- **Jan 2026:** Price hikes and new monthly plans from 28 Jan 2026
- **Watch:** Post-IPL retention, HBO deal after Paramount-WBD, IPL 2028 rights

Sources: JioStar quarterly results, Reliance AGM 2026, jiostar.com releases, exchange4media, press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

WhatsApp

World's largest private messenger, now monetising businesses, Channels and Status

Founded: **2009 by Jan Koum, Brian Acton** Owner/Listed: **Meta (NASDAQ: META), acquired 2014 for $19B** HQ: **Menlo Park, California (Meta)** Revenue: **Not split; Meta other rev $1.0B Q2'26 (+73%)**
Users: **3B+ MAU (2025); ~3.3B est. 2026** Businesses: **200M+ business accounts; 1M+ weekly business-agent users** Head: **Kunal Shah (CRED founder) since Jun 2026** India: **Largest market, ~580M users (est.)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Simple, reliable, private messaging and calling for everyone, anywhere in the world.
- **Vision:** Become the default way people talk to businesses, creators and AI, not just friends and family.
- **Core strategy:** Keep Chats free, ad-free and encrypted; monetise businesses via paid messaging, Click-to-WhatsApp ads and Updates tab ads.
- **Moat:** Phone-number graph and network effects; default app in India, Brazil, Indonesia; works on low-end phones and weak networks.
- **Key bet:** Business AI agents and Meta AI in chats; India commerce and payments under Kunal Shah after $900M CRED stake.
- **Your view:** Can WhatsApp scale Status ads and AI agents without breaking the private, ad-free promise that built it?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose WhatsApp
Consumers	3B+ people chatting with family and groups	Need free, reliable, private messaging and calls across countries and networks	Everyone they know is already there; free calls; E2EE; works on cheap phones
Small businesses	Shops, tutors, clinics using Business app	Need a cheap way to reach customers, share catalogues, take orders	Free app, customers already on it, catalogues and quick replies replace a website
Enterprises	Banks, airlines, D2C brands via Business Platform	SMS and email get ignored; need verified, rich, two-way customer channel	High open rates, green tick trust, APIs via BSPs, AI agents automate support
Advertisers	Brands buying CTWA and Status ads	Need leads that convert into real conversations, not cheap clicks	Meta targeting plus chat handoff; Status ads reach 1.5B+ daily Updates-tab users (est.)
Channel creators	Publishers, celebrities, brands running Channels	Need a broadcast audience and a way to monetise followers	Massive reach, promoted channels for discovery, paid channel subscriptions

Product portfolio and metrics

Personal messaging

Chats and Groups	End-to-end encrypted 1:1 and group messaging, media, voice notes
Calls	Free voice and video calls, group calls up to 32
Communities	Umbrella for related groups with admin announcements
Meta AI	AI assistant inside chats and search, Llama-powered
Status	24-hour Stories-style updates for contacts
North Star	Daily active messaging users sending at least one message
Key metrics	DAU/MAU, messages and call minutes per user, group creation, retention
Guardrails	Message delivery latency, spam reports, encryption integrity, battery and data usage

Business

WhatsApp Business app	Free SMB app with catalogues, labels, quick replies
Business Platform (Cloud API)	Paid API for enterprises via BSPs, per-message pricing
Meta Business Agent	AI agent that answers, books, sells across Meta apps
Click-to-WhatsApp ads	Facebook/Instagram ads that open a WhatsApp chat
Flows and catalogues	In-chat forms, product lists and checkout journeys
North Star	Weekly business conversations that end in a resolved query or sale
Key metrics	Paid messages, revenue per business, CTWA conversations, agent resolution rate
Guardrails	User block/report rate on businesses, marketing opt-outs, quality rating drops

Updates tab (Channels and ads)

Channels	One-way broadcast from creators, publishers and brands
Status ads	Full-screen ads between Status updates, click to chat
Promoted channels	Paid placement in Channels discovery directory
Channel subscriptions	Monthly paid tier for exclusive channel content
North Star	Daily Updates-tab users engaging with Status or Channels
Key metrics	Ad impressions, CPM, ad-to-chat rate, channel follows, paid subscribers
Guardrails	Ad hide/block rate, Chats engagement unchanged, Status posting rate, uninstalls

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Paid messaging	Enterprises sending OTPs, alerts, marketing via API	Businesses (through BSPs like Gupshup, Twilio)	Per delivered template since Jul 2025; India marketing ₹0.86, utility ₹0.13
Click-to-WhatsApp ads	Users on Facebook and Instagram	Advertisers	Auction-priced ads; revenue booked in Meta ads, not WhatsApp
Status ads and promoted channels	Users browsing the Updates tab	Advertisers and channel owners	Ads Manager auction; global rollout from 2025, ad-free option in parts of Europe
Channel subscriptions	Fans of creators and publishers	Subscribing users	Monthly fee to admins; Meta and app stores take a cut (terms evolving)
Business AI subscriptions	SMBs automating chats with Business Agent	Businesses	Free at launch; planned paid tier under Meta One

- **Revenue mix:** Meta 'other revenue' hit $1.0B in Q2'26 (+73%), mostly WhatsApp paid messaging and subscriptions; CTWA sits inside the $59B ads line.
- **Users vs payers:** 3B+ users pay nothing; businesses and advertisers pay. Chats stay ad-free and encrypted, so ads live only in Updates.
- **Unit economics:** Near-zero marginal cost per message; service replies free within 24 hours; utility rates tiered by volume to drive adoption.
- **Growth levers:** Scale Status ads, paid AI agents, payments and commerce in India and Brazil, more enterprise utility traffic moving off SMS.
- **Lesson:** Monetise the side of the network that gets ROI (businesses) and protect the side that creates the network effect.

Friction points to discuss

- Marketing message overload from brands feels like spam
- Status ads clutter a previously ad-free Updates tab
- Forwarded misinformation spreads fast in large groups
- Phone number exposure until usernames fully roll out
- Old Android phones dropped in Sep 2026

Competitors and market

- **Messaging:** Telegram, Signal, iMessage, Google Messages (RCS), WeChat, LINE
- **Business messaging:** SMS/CPaaS, RCS Business Messaging, Apple Messages for Business
- **Broadcast/creators:** Telegram channels, Instagram broadcast channels, YouTube, X
- **Edge:** 3B+ users, default in emerging markets, Meta ads feed CTWA demand
- **Risk:** Ads and AI erode trust; EU DMA interoperability; India traceability demands

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Stopped supporting phones below Android 6.0 from 8 Sep; hits India, Africa
- **Jul 2026:** Meta other revenue crossed $1B, up 73%, led by WhatsApp paid messaging
- **Jun 2026:** Kunal Shah replaces Will Cathcart; Meta buys 20% of CRED for $900M
- **Watch:** Status ads scale, paid Business Agent pricing, Shah's India payments and commerce push

Sources: Meta Q2 2026 results, Meta and WhatsApp announcements, Conversations 2026, press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Messenger

Facebook's chat app, being folded back into the Facebook app

Founded: **2011 standalone app (Facebook Chat 2008)** Owner/Listed: **Meta Platforms (NASDAQ: META)** HQ: **Menlo Park, California**
Revenue: **Not split; inside Meta FoA $60.4B Q2'26** Users: **~950M MAU est. (947M ad reach, 2025)** Top markets: **US ~195M users; Philippines, Mexico, Brazil**
Org: **Run within the Facebook app org (est.)** Desktop: **Win/Mac apps retired; messenger.com closed Apr 2026**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Meta: build the future of human connection and the technology that makes it possible.
- **Vision:** Messaging as the social layer of Facebook: discover content in feed, discuss it with friends in chat.
- **Core strategy:** Re-merge with Facebook (inbox in app, web via facebook.com/messages), cut standalone surfaces, double down on mobile.
- **Moat:** Facebook identity and friend graph, Marketplace buyer-seller chats, Pages inbox for millions of businesses.
- **Key bet:** Meta AI in chat and Business Agent automating Page and Marketplace conversations; E2EE by default since Dec 2023.
- **Your view:** Should Messenger survive as a standalone app, or is it a feature of Facebook that Meta should fully absorb?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Messenger
Facebook-native users	25+ users in US, Philippines, LatAm	Want to chat with Facebook friends without sharing phone numbers	Friends already on Facebook; no phone number needed; easy Reels and link sharing
Marketplace users	Buyers and sellers of used goods	Need quick, trusted negotiation with strangers about listings	Chat is built into Marketplace with profile identity and listing context
Groups and Communities	Admins of hobby, school, local groups	Need group coordination beyond feed posts	Communities up to 5,000 members tied to Facebook groups
Businesses/Pages	SMBs answering Page and ad enquiries	Too many repetitive customer questions across channels	Unified Meta inbox, automated replies, Business Agent handles bookings and sales
Advertisers	Brands running Click-to-Messenger ads	Need leads that turn into conversations	Meta targeting plus conversational follow-up and sponsored messages to opted-in users

Product portfolio and metrics

Consumer chat

Chats and Calls	E2EE 1:1 and group chat, voice and video calls
Communities	Group spaces for up to 5,000 people
Meta AI in Messenger	AI assistant, image generation, chat summaries
Messenger Kids	Parent-controlled messaging for children
Facebook inbox	Messenger inside Facebook app and facebook.com/messages
North Star	Weekly users sending messages to Facebook friends
Key metrics	DAU, messages per user, Reels shares to chat, call minutes
Guardrails	Scam message reports, chat-history restore failures, app uninstalls

Business messaging

Click-to-Messenger ads	Facebook and Instagram ads that open a Messenger chat
Messenger Platform API	APIs for bots and CRM integrations on Pages
Meta Business Agent	AI agent answering, booking, selling across Meta apps
Sponsored messages	Paid outbound messages to users who chatted before
Marketplace chat	Buyer-seller messaging attached to listings
North Star	Business conversations resolved or converted per week
Key metrics	Ad-initiated conversations, cost per conversation, agent resolution rate
Guardrails	Block/report rate on businesses, response time, Marketplace scam reports

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Click-to-Messenger ads	Users on Facebook and Instagram	Advertisers	Auction CPC/CPM; optimised for conversations started
Sponsored messages	Users who previously messaged a Page	Businesses	Paid re-engagement messages via Ads Manager
Inbox and Stories ads	Messenger app users	Advertisers	Native ad units sold in Meta's unified ads auction
Business AI subscriptions	SMBs automating Page chats	Businesses	Business Agent free at launch; paid tier planned under Meta One

- **Revenue mix:** No disclosed figure; value is mostly indirect, lifting Facebook ad conversion via chat-based ads and Marketplace.
- **Users vs payers:** ~950M users pay nothing; advertisers and businesses pay; monetisation is thin versus Facebook feed.
- **Unit economics:** Shared Meta infrastructure keeps cost low; retiring desktop apps and messenger.com cuts maintenance overhead.
- **Growth levers:** Deeper Facebook integration, content sharing in chat, Meta AI, paid Business Agent, Marketplace growth.
- **Lesson:** Unbundling (2014) built scale; rebundling (2024-26) shows a standalone app needs a unique job to justify itself.

Friction points to discuss

- Desktop users forced onto facebook.com after shutdown
- Phone-only users lost web access in 2026
- E2EE chat-history PIN restore confuses users
- Scam and spam message requests from strangers
- Overlaps with WhatsApp and Instagram DMs

Competitors and market

- **Inside Meta:** WhatsApp and Instagram DMs cannibalise usage, especially under-30s
- **Messaging:** iMessage, Google Messages (RCS), Snapchat, Telegram, Discord
- **Business chat:** WhatsApp Business, Intercom/live chat, RCS Business Messaging
- **Edge:** Facebook graph, Marketplace, no phone number needed, Meta ads engine
- **Risk:** Slow irrelevance as Facebook ages; becomes a feature rather than a product

Recent news and direction

- **Jun 2026:** Meta Business Agent launched for Messenger, WhatsApp and Instagram at Conversations 2026
- **Apr 2026:** messenger.com shut on 14 Apr; redirects to facebook.com/messages
- **Dec 2025:** Messenger desktop apps for Windows and Mac retired
- **Watch:** Full inbox merge into Facebook app, Meta AI usage, Business Agent pricing

Sources: Meta Q2 2026 results, Meta announcements, DataReportal, press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Telegram

Cloud messenger and channel platform with crypto-powered mini-app economy

Founded: **2013 by Pavel and Nikolai Durov** HQ: **Dubai, UAE** Owner: **Private, Durov-controlled; $1.7B convertible bonds (2025)** Revenue: **H1'25 $870M (+65%), unaudited; FY25 target $2B**
Profit: **2024 first profit ~$540M; H1'25 loss $220M+** Users: **1B+ MAU (Mar 2025)** Premium: **15M+ paid subscribers (May 2025)** CEO: **Pavel Durov; French probe, Russian warrant Jul 2026**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Fast, secure, free messaging that no government or advertiser controls.
- **Vision:** An open super-app: chats, channels, bots, mini apps and a TON-based wallet in one platform.
- **Core strategy:** Free core for all; monetise power users (Premium), channel ads, Stars purchases and TON ecosystem deals.
- **Moat:** Cloud sync across devices, 200K-member groups, unlimited channels, open bot and mini-app APIs, neutrality brand.
- **Key bet:** Crypto and mini-apps economy on TON plus AI partnerships (announced xAI Grok deal, unconfirmed by Musk).
- **Your view:** Is a business relying on Toncoin deals and a founder facing two criminal cases investable or IPO-ready?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Telegram
Power users	Multi-device, privacy-minded, large-group users	Want fast sync, big files, no phone-number exposure	Cloud sync, usernames, 2–4GB files, rich features, no ads in private chats
Channel creators	News, crypto, education, media publishers	Need direct reach to millions without algorithmic suppression	Unlimited subscribers, 50% ad revenue share, paid posts and Stars
Developers	Bot, mini-app and Web3 builders	Need distribution and payments without app store gatekeepers	Free Bot API, mini apps reach 1B users, Stars and TON payments
Advertisers	Brands, crypto projects, apps buying Telegram Ads	Need to reach niche, hard-to-target communities	Context-targeted sponsored messages in large public channels
Censored audiences	Users in Iran, Russia, Ukraine, Middle East	Need uncensored news and coordination	Channels as news source; resistance to government takedown

Product portfolio and metrics

Messaging

Cloud chats	Synced chats across devices, large files, usernames
Secret chats	Opt-in end-to-end encrypted 1:1 chats
Groups	Up to 200,000 members with admin tools and topics
Calls	Voice, video and group calls
North Star	Daily active users engaging in chats or groups
Key metrics	DAU/MAU, opens per day (~21), time spent, multi-device users
Guardrails	Spam and scam reports, illegal content takedown time, delivery latency

Channels and creators

Channels	Unlimited-subscriber broadcast feeds
Telegram Ads	Sponsored messages in channels, revenue shared with owners
Stars and paid content	In-app currency for paid posts, reactions, subscriptions
Gifts	Collectible digital gifts, tradable as NFTs on TON
Stories	Ephemeral updates for users and channels
North Star	Monthly creator earnings paid out via ads and Stars
Key metrics	Channel views, ad CPM, Stars volume, paying-subscriber count
Guardrails	Ad relevance complaints, fraud in Stars/gifts, creator churn

Platform and premium

Telegram Premium	Subscription for bigger limits, speed, extra features
Bot API	Free bots for automation, payments, games
Mini Apps	Web apps running inside Telegram, games and commerce
TON wallet	Built-in self-custody crypto wallet
Fragment	Auction marketplace for usernames and anonymous numbers
North Star	Paying users and mini-app transactions per month
Key metrics	Premium subs, conversion rate, mini-app MAU, TON transaction volume
Guardrails	Crypto scam reports, regulator actions, refund and chargeback rates

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Telegram Premium	Power users wanting higher limits	Subscribers (~$5/month, varies by country)	Monthly or annual subscription via app stores or Stars
Telegram Ads	Readers of large public channels	Advertisers, often paying in TON	CPM sponsored messages; 50% shared with channel owners
Stars and digital goods	Users buying in mini apps, paid posts, gifts	Users	Stars bought via app stores; Telegram takes a margin
TON exclusivity deals	TON ecosystem and wallet users	TON Foundation and partners	~$300M of H1'25 revenue from exclusivity agreements
Fragment auctions	Users wanting rare usernames or numbers	Bidders in TON	Auction sales with platform commission

- **Revenue mix:** H1'25 $870M: roughly one-third TON-linked exclusivity deals, rest Premium, ads and Stars; FY25 target $2B, unaudited.
- **Users vs payers:** 1B+ users, ~15M Premium payers (~1.5%); advertisers and crypto partners fill the gap.
- **Unit economics:** ~30 core engineers and lean ops; profits swing with Toncoin price, causing H1'25 write-down loss.
- **Growth levers:** Premium conversion, ad fill in channels, mini-app commerce, AI partnerships, eventual IPO.
- **Lesson:** Tying revenue to a volatile token boosts topline but makes earnings and governance hard to underwrite.

Friction points to discuss

- Default chats are not end-to-end encrypted
- Scams, crypto spam and illicit content in public channels
- Feature overload overwhelms new and casual users
- Government throttling and blocks disrupt access
- Founder legal risk shakes trust and partners

Competitors and market

- **Messaging:** WhatsApp, Signal, Messenger, iMessage; Russia's state-backed Max
- **Broadcast:** WhatsApp Channels, X, YouTube, Discord, Substack
- **Mini apps:** WeChat, LINE, Kakao super-apps; app stores
- **Edge:** Open APIs, huge groups, cloud sync, neutrality brand, crypto-native economy
- **Risk:** Durov legal cases, Russian throttling, Toncoin volatility, content-moderation regulation

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Russia charges Durov with aiding terrorism, issues international arrest warrant
- **Feb 2026:** Roskomnadzor throttles Telegram in Russia, pushes state messenger Max
- **Jan 2026:** $500M of Telegram bonds frozen in Russia due to Western sanctions
- **Watch:** FY25 audited numbers, IPO plans, French case outcome, Russia block escalation

Sources: FT-reported unaudited financials, Durov posts, Telegram announcements, press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Gmail

World's largest email service, becoming a Gemini-powered AI inbox

Launched: **1 April 2004, Google** Owner/Listed: **Alphabet (NASDAQ: GOOGL)** HQ: **Mountain View, California** Revenue: **Not split; in Workspace and Google Cloud ($24.8B Q2'26)**
Users: **~1.8B+ est. Gmail users** Workspace: **11M paying customers, 3B+ users (Q4'25)** Market share: **~24% of email client opens (est.)**
Leaders: **Sundar Pichai (Alphabet); Thomas Kurian (Google Cloud)**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Google: organise the world's information and make it universally accessible and useful.
- **Vision:** Email as a proactive assistant that summarises, prioritises and acts, not a list to triage.
- **Core strategy:** Free Gmail as identity and data hub; upsell storage and AI (Google One AI Pro/Ultra) and Workspace seats.
- **Moat:** Google Account identity, best-in-class spam filtering, 15GB free storage, deep Calendar, Drive, Meet integration.
- **Key bet:** Gemini 3 in Gmail: AI Overviews, AI Inbox, Help Me Write; Gemini bundled into every Workspace plan.
- **Your view:** Will AI Inbox make users open Gmail less, and if so how does Google measure success?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Gmail
Consumers	Free users needing personal email and login	Overflowing inbox, promotions, missed bills and bookings	Free, reliable, great spam filter, identity for Android and Google services
AI subscribers	Google One AI Pro/Ultra users	No time to read long threads or search old emails	Inbox-wide Q&A, Proofread, AI Inbox, 2TB storage bundled
SMBs	Startups and small firms on Workspace	Need professional email on own domain without IT team	$7/user Starter with Gemini included, easy admin, Docs and Meet bundled
Enterprises and education	Large firms, universities, schools	Need secure, compliant email with AI at scale	Data not used to train models, admin controls, cheaper than Microsoft 365 Copilot
Senders/advertisers	Brands sending newsletters, buying Promotions ads	Need inbox placement and attention	Promotions tab ads, sender guidelines reward good senders

Product portfolio and metrics

Gmail core

Inbox and tabs	Primary, Promotions, Social, Updates categorisation
Spam and security	AI filters blocking phishing and malware
Search	Fast full-mailbox search with filters
Manage subscriptions	One-tap unsubscribe from bulk senders
North Star	Weekly users who reach inbox clarity (important mail handled)
Key metrics	DAU, emails read and sent, spam catch rate, search success
Guardrails	False-positive spam rate, deliverability complaints, load time

Monetisation layer

Google Workspace	Paid business email, Docs, Meet, Gemini bundled
Google One storage	Paid storage beyond 15GB shared across Google
Google AI Pro/Ultra	Consumer AI plans unlocking advanced Gmail features
Gmail ads	Sponsored messages in Promotions and Social tabs
North Star	Paid seats and subscribers retained month over month
Key metrics	Workspace seats, ARPU, Google One subs, ad revenue per user
Guardrails	Churn after price rises, ad complaints, migration to Microsoft 365

Gemini in Gmail

AI Overviews	Thread summaries free; inbox-wide Q&A for paid tiers
AI Inbox	Prioritised topics and suggested to-dos, limited rollout
Help Me Write	Drafts and polishes emails, now free for all
Suggested Replies and Proofread	Context-aware replies; Proofread for paid users
Gemini side panel	Chat assistant across Gmail, Drive, Calendar
North Star	Weekly users completing an email task with AI help
Key metrics	AI feature adoption, drafts accepted, summaries viewed, AI Pro conversions
Guardrails	Hallucination reports, privacy complaints, AI opt-out rate, latency

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Workspace subscriptions	Businesses, schools, governments	Organisations per seat	Starter $7, Standard $14, Plus $22 per user/month, Gemini included
Google One / AI plans	Consumers needing storage or advanced AI	Individual subscribers	Monthly storage tiers; AI Pro and Ultra unlock Gmail AI features
Gmail ads	Free Gmail users	Advertisers via Google Ads	Auction-priced native ads in Promotions and Social tabs
Ecosystem value	All Google Account holders	Indirect, via Search, Android, Play	Gmail anchors identity and retention across Google services

- **Revenue mix:** No Gmail figure; mostly Workspace seats and Google One subs, plus Gmail ads inside Google advertising.
- **Users vs payers:** ~1.8B users mostly free; 11M paying Workspace customers and Google One subscribers fund the product.
- **Unit economics:** Storage and AI inference costs rise per user; Gemini bundling lifted Workspace prices 17–22% in 2025.
- **Growth levers:** AI Pro upsell, Workspace price-to-value, AI Inbox global rollout, India and emerging-market SMBs.
- **Lesson:** Bundle AI into the paid tier rather than sell an add-on: higher price, higher perceived value, less churn.

Friction points to discuss

- Best AI features locked behind paid plans
- AI Inbox only in US/English, limited rollout
- Promotions clutter and newsletters overwhelm inbox
- Privacy worries about Gemini reading emails
- 15GB free storage fills, forcing upgrades

Competitors and market

- **Consumer email:** Outlook.com, Apple iCloud Mail, Yahoo Mail, Proton Mail
- **Business suites:** Microsoft 365 with Copilot, Zoho Workplace, Zoho Mail
- **AI email clients:** Superhuman, Shortwave, Spark; ChatGPT and Claude connectors
- **Edge:** Google identity, spam filtering, Gemini integration, free tier scale
- **Risk:** AI agents bypass the inbox; Microsoft enterprise lock-in; privacy regulation

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Google Cloud revenue $24.8B in Q2; Gemini app near 1B MAU
- **Feb 2026:** Workspace reported 11M paying customers, up from 8M a year earlier
- **Jan 2026:** Gmail enters 'Gemini era': AI Overviews, AI Inbox, free Help Me Write
- **Watch:** AI Inbox global rollout, India languages, agentic actions on email

Sources: Alphabet Q2 2026 results, Google Workspace blog, press coverage, third-party Gmail estimates. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

YouTube

World's largest video platform: long-form, Shorts, TV, music and live

Founded: **2005; acquired by Google 2006 for $1.65B** HQ: **San Bruno, California, USA** Owner/Listed: **Alphabet (NASDAQ: GOOGL), Google Services segment**
Revenue: **2025: $60B+ total; ads $40.4B (+12% YoY)** Latest quarter: **Q2 2026 ads $11.06B (+13% YoY)** Subscriptions: **125M Music/Premium subs; YouTube TV ~10M**
Shorts: **200B+ daily views; TV 1B+ hours/day** CEO/Head: **Neal Mohan (since Feb 2023)** India: **Largest user market; Shorts filled TikTok ban gap**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Give everyone a voice and show them the world.
- **Vision:** Be the default screen for all video, from 15-second Shorts to living-room TV and live sports.
- **Core strategy:** Two-sided flywheel: share ~55% of ad revenue with creators, attract more content, more watch time, more advertisers.
- **Moat:** Largest creator library, Google ad stack, search intent data, recommendation engine and Content ID rights system.
- **Key bet:** Connected TV plus subscriptions; Premium, Music and NFL Sunday Ticket now growing faster than ads.
- **Your view:** Shorts monetises below long-form per hour; is Shorts cannibalising YouTube's most valuable watch time?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose YouTube
Viewers	2.5B+ logged-in users, all ages	Endless choice, need free entertainment, learning and music on any screen	Deepest catalogue anywhere, free with ads, great recommendations, works on phone and TV
Creators	Partners from hobbyists to media studios	Need audience, predictable income and tools to grow	Partner Program revenue share, global reach, evergreen search traffic, multiple monetisation levers
Advertisers	Brands, performance marketers, SMBs, agencies	Reach cord-cutters and Gen Z with measurable outcomes	Google Ads targeting, CTV reach rivalling TV networks, Demand Gen and shoppable ads
Subscribers	Heavy users, music fans, families	Ads interrupt, need offline and background play	Premium removes ads and bundles YouTube Music; cheaper than separate services
Rights holders	Labels, sports leagues, TV networks	Piracy and fragmented distribution of their content	Content ID monetises user uploads; huge reach for licensed and live content

Product portfolio and metrics

Core video

YouTube main app	Long-form on-demand video, search and recommendations
Shorts	Vertical short-form feed competing with TikTok and Reels
YouTube Live	Livestreams, premieres, Super Chat and live shopping
YouTube on TV	Connected-TV app; living-room is fastest growing screen
North Star	Daily engaged watch time per logged-in user across all formats
Key metrics	DAU, watch hours, Shorts views, CTV share, session starts
Guardrails	Policy violations, misinformation reports, creator churn, user satisfaction surveys

Subscriptions

YouTube Premium	Ad-free, background play, downloads; Lite tier cheaper
YouTube Music	Music streaming app competing with Spotify
YouTube TV	US virtual cable bundle, ~10M subscribers
NFL Sunday Ticket / Channels	Sports package and third-party channel subscriptions
North Star	Paid subscribers retained beyond month three
Key metrics	Paid subs, trial conversion, ARPU, churn, family plan adoption
Guardrails	Price-hike churn, carriage disputes, ad-tier engagement not collapsing

Creator and ad platform

YouTube Partner Program	Ad and Shorts revenue sharing with creators
YouTube Studio + AI tools	Analytics, Dream Screen, auto-dubbing, inspiration tab
YouTube Shopping	Product tagging and affiliate commissions inside videos
Google Ads video formats	Skippable, bumper, Demand Gen and CTV ads
North Star	Creator earnings per active monetising channel
Key metrics	Monetising channels, RPM, ad load, advertiser count, ROAS
Guardrails	Ads per hour, skip rates, brand-safety incidents, demonetisation appeals

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Advertising	All free viewers on mobile, web and TV	Advertisers via Google Ads and DV360	CPM/CPV auctions; creators get ~55% long-form, 45% Shorts pool
Premium and Music	Heavy viewers and music listeners	Consumers, monthly or family plans	Subscription fee; share paid to creators and labels by watch time
YouTube TV and Sunday Ticket	US cord-cutters and NFL fans	Households paying ~$80+/month	Resells network channels; thin margins due to carriage fees
Channels, Super Chat, memberships	Fans of specific creators or networks	Fans and channel subscribers	YouTube takes a platform cut, typically ~30%

- **Revenue mix:** 2025: ~$40B ads (67%) and ~$20B subscriptions (33%); subscriptions growing faster than ads in 2026.
- **Users vs payers:** Billions watch free; ~125M pay for Music/Premium, so most users monetised through ads only.
- **Unit economics:** No content production cost; creators paid revenue share, so margins scale; TV bundle is low-margin.
- **Growth levers:** Shorts monetisation, CTV ad pricing, Premium price/Lite tier, shopping, sports rights, AI dubbing for global reach.
- **Lesson:** Revenue-share model turns creators into an unpaid-upfront content studio; ad business funds the flywheel.

Friction points to discuss

- Rising ad load and unskippable ads frustrate free users
- Shorts feed interrupts long-form intent on home page
- Creator demonetisation and opaque policy strikes
- Premium price hikes feel steep in emerging markets
- Low-quality AI-generated content cluttering recommendations

Competitors and market

- **Short video:** TikTok, Instagram Reels, Moj, Josh
- **Streaming TV:** Netflix, Disney+, Prime Video, JioHotstar for living-room time
- **Music:** Spotify, Apple Music, JioSaavn
- **Live:** Twitch, Kick for gaming and live creators
- **Edge:** Only platform spanning short, long, live, music, TV plus Google ads
- **Risk:** TikTok attention share, AI slop, regulation on minors and content moderation

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q2 ads $11.06B, +13%; subscriptions growing faster than ads per Alphabet
- **Feb 2026:** Alphabet discloses YouTube 2025 revenue above $60B, surpassing Netflix
- **Mar 2025:** Music and Premium reach 125M subscribers including trials
- **Watch:** Shorts monetisation gap, CTV ad growth, AI content policy, Premium Lite expansion

Sources: Alphabet Q4 2025 and Q2 2026 earnings, YouTube blog, MBW and press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Spotify

Freemium audio platform: music, podcasts, audiobooks and now video

Founded: **2006, Stockholm, by Daniel Ek and Martin Lorentzon** HQ: **Stockholm, Sweden** Owner/Listed: **Spotify Technology S.A., NYSE: SPOT** Revenue: **FY25 €17.2B (+10%); op. margin ~13%**
Latest quarter: **Q2 2026 €4.78B (+14%), op. income €655M** Users: **Q2 2026: 777M MAU, 300M Premium subs** Profit: **FY25 net income ~$1.17B; consistently profitable since 2024**
CEO/Head: **Co-CEOs Alex Norström, Gustav Söderström (2026); Ek chairman** India: **Launched 2019; big MAU, low ARPU market**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Unlock the potential of human creativity by giving creators a living and fans enjoyment of their art.
- **Vision:** Be the world's audio and creator platform, ubiquitous on every device, in every country.
- **Core strategy:** Freemium funnel: free ad tier acquires users, personalisation converts them to Premium, price rises lift margin.
- **Moat:** Personalisation data (Discover Weekly, Wrapped, DJ), habit, playlists and device ubiquity across cars, speakers, consoles.
- **Key bet:** Beyond music: video podcasts, audiobooks in Premium, AI DJ; diversify away from label royalties eating ~70% revenue.
- **Your view:** Ad revenue shrank in 2025 while subs grew; should Spotify keep a free tier at all?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Spotify
Free listeners	Students, emerging-market and casual users	Want music free, accept ads, low willingness to pay	Biggest free catalogue, good recommendations, on every device
Premium subscribers	Daily listeners, families, commuters	Ads, shuffle limits, no offline listening	Ad-free, offline, best personalisation, audiobook hours, family and duo plans
Artists and labels	Majors, indies, independent artists	Discovery and fair royalties in crowded market	Largest paying audience; Spotify for Artists, Marquee, Discovery Mode promotion
Podcasters	Video and audio creators, studios	Monetisation and audience beyond YouTube	Partner Program pays for Premium consumption; video podcasts, built-in ads
Advertisers	Brands targeting young, logged-in audiences	Reach audio-first users with measurable impact	Spotify Ad Exchange, streaming audio and podcast ads, first-party data

Product portfolio and metrics

Music

Spotify Free	Ad-supported shuffle listening, the top of funnel
Spotify Premium	Individual, Duo, Family, Student ad-free plans
Personalisation	Discover Weekly, AI DJ, AI playlists, Daylist, Wrapped
Spotify for Artists	Analytics, Marquee and Discovery Mode promotion tools
North Star	Weekly listening hours per MAU that drive Premium conversion
Key metrics	MAU, free-to-paid conversion, Premium ARPU, churn, streams per user
Guardrails	Royalty cost per stream, artist sentiment, price-hike churn

Podcasts and video

Video podcasts	~500K video shows; 390M+ users have streamed one
Spotify Partner Program	Pays creators for Premium video podcast consumption
Spotify for Creators	Hosting, recording and analytics, formerly Anchor
North Star	Weekly podcast listeners who also stream music
Key metrics	Podcast MAU share, video watch time, show count, ad fill
Guardrails	Content cost per hour, brand safety, music engagement not dropping

Audiobooks and ads

Audiobooks in Premium	15 hours monthly included; top-ups and add-on
Spotify Ad Exchange	Programmatic audio, video and podcast ad marketplace
Spotify Audience Network	Ad network across Spotify and partner podcasts
North Star	Ad and audiobook gross profit per user
Key metrics	Ad revenue growth, CPMs, audiobook hours, attach rate
Guardrails	Ads per hour, free-user retention, publisher payout disputes

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Premium subscriptions	300M paid subscribers worldwide	Consumers, monthly; US individual $12.99 from 2026	Flat fee; ~2/3 of revenue paid to rights holders
Ad-supported	~480M free listeners	Advertisers and agencies	Audio, video and podcast ads sold direct and programmatically
Audiobooks	Premium users and add-on buyers	Subscribers via plan, top-ups, add-on	Monthly listening hours bundled; publishers paid per usage
Marketplace	Artists and labels seeking promotion	Labels and artists	Marquee, Showcase, Discovery Mode lower royalty for promotion

- **Revenue mix:** FY25: Premium €15.35B (89%), ad-supported €1.84B (11%, down 1%).
- **Users vs payers:** 777M users, 300M payers (~39%); free tier is the acquisition funnel, not the profit engine.
- **Unit economics:** Gross margin hit record 33.4% Q2 2026; royalties variable, so price hikes and non-music content lift margin.
- **Growth levers:** Price increases, superfan tier, video podcasts, audiobooks, emerging-market subs, ad-tech rebuild.
- **Lesson:** Aggregator without owned supply: profitability came only after cost cuts, pricing power and bundling non-music.

Friction points to discuss

- Free tier shuffle and skip limits on mobile
- Home feed cluttered by podcasts, audiobooks and video
- Price hikes across all tiers in 2026
- Artists complain about low per-stream payouts
- Audiobook hour caps confuse Premium users

Competitors and market

- **Music streaming:** Apple Music, YouTube Music, Amazon Music, JioSaavn
- **Podcasts and video:** YouTube (biggest podcast platform), Apple Podcasts, Netflix video podcasts
- **Audiobooks:** Audible, Apple Books, Pocket FM in India
- **Attention:** TikTok and Shorts as music discovery engines
- **Edge:** Best-in-class personalisation, platform-agnostic ubiquity, cultural moments like Wrapped
- **Risk:** Label leverage, Apple/Google platform fees, YouTube bundling music with video

Recent news and direction

- **Jul 2026:** Q2: 300M subs, 777M MAU, €655M operating income, record 33.4% gross margin
- **Jan 2026:** Norström and Söderström become co-CEOs; Daniel Ek moves to executive chairman
- **Jan 2026:** US price hikes: individual $12.99, Family $21.99, Student $6.99
- **Watch:** Superfan tier launch, video podcast monetisation, ad business turnaround

Sources: Spotify 20-F FY25, Q2 2026 6-K, MBW and press coverage. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Twitch

Live-streaming community platform for gaming, IRL and creators

Founded: **2011 as Justin.tv spin-off; Amazon bought 2014 ($970M)** HQ: **San Francisco, California, USA** Owner/Listed: **Amazon (NASDAQ: AMZN); not separately reported**
Revenue: **~$1.75B est. annual; not disclosed by Amazon** Usage: **2025: ~19.2B hours watched (-10% YoY), est.** Market share: **~54% of live-streaming hours watched, 2025 est.**
CEO/Head: **Dan Clancy (since Mar 2023)** Profit: **Long loss-making; 35% staff cut 2024 to chase profit** Korea exit: **Shut South Korea service Feb 2024 over costs**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Empower communities to create together, live; a place to hang out with people who share your interests.
- **Vision:** The home of live: where creators build real-time communities, not passive audiences.
- **Core strategy:** Monetise community, not views: subs, Bits, gifting and ads; extend reach via clips on TikTok, Shorts, Reels.
- **Moat:** Live chat culture, emotes, raids, subscriber identity and gaming network effects built over 15 years.
- **Key bet:** Vertical and dual-format streaming, clips and Recaps feed for mobile discovery; cost discipline under Amazon.
- **Your view:** Should Twitch chase short-form discovery or double down on long, live community where it is uniquely strong?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Twitch
Viewers	Gamers, Gen Z, esports and IRL fans	Want real-time interaction and belonging, not passive watching	Live chat, emotes, community rituals and favourite streamers live daily
Streamers	Partners, affiliates, aspiring creators	Hard discovery, uneven income, competing revenue splits	Built-in monetisation: subs, Bits, ads, Partner Plus 60/40 and 70/30 splits
Advertisers	Game publishers, energy drinks, tech brands	Reach hard-to-target young male gaming audience	Highly engaged live audience, sponsorship integrations, Amazon Ads stack
Prime members	Amazon Prime subscribers	Want perks for games and streamers	Free monthly Prime Gaming sub to support a streamer
Publishers and esports	Game studios, leagues, event organisers	Launch hype and event distribution	Drops, category pages and co-streaming rights drive game discovery

Product portfolio and metrics

Viewer experience

Live streams	Gaming, Just Chatting, IRL, music and esports channels
Chat, emotes, raids	Real-time community layer that defines the platform
Clips and Recaps feed	Short highlight reels from streams for mobile discovery
Vertical / dual-format live	Stream portrait and landscape together, launched 2026
North Star	Weekly hours watched by returning chatters
Key metrics	Hours watched, concurrent viewers, chat participation, new viewer retention
Guardrails	Viewbotting, harassment reports, ad complaints, stream latency

Creator monetisation

Subscriptions and gift subs	Tiered monthly fan support; Gift 'Em All tool
Bits and Power-Ups	Virtual currency cheers and Custom Power-Ups
Partner Plus	Path to 60/40 and 70/30 sub revenue splits
Ads Incentive Program	Pays streamers for running ad breaks
North Star	Median monthly earnings of active mid-tier streamers
Key metrics	Payouts, streamers earning, sub conversion, Bits per viewer
Guardrails	Creator defection to Kick/YouTube, platform take-rate erosion

Ads and partnerships

Pre-roll and mid-roll ads	Video ads sold through Amazon Ads
Drops	In-game rewards for watching publisher streams
Prime Gaming sub	Free monthly sub bundled with Amazon Prime
North Star	Ad revenue per hour watched without hurting retention
Key metrics	Fill rate, CPM, ad minutes per hour, advertiser count
Guardrails	Viewer churn after ads, brand-safety incidents

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Subscriptions	Fans supporting a streamer	Viewers ($4.99+) or Amazon via Prime Gaming	Split 50/50 by default; 60/40 or 70/30 via Partner Plus
Advertising	Free viewers	Brands via Amazon Ads	Pre/mid-rolls; streamers get share of ad revenue
Bits and gifting	Engaged chatters	Viewers buying Bits	Twitch keeps margin on Bits purchase; streamer gets $0.01 per Bit
Sponsorships and Drops	Publishers and brands	Game studios, marketers	Campaigns, Drops integrations, branded content deals

- **Revenue mix:** Estimated ~$1.75B/year split across subs, ads and Bits; Amazon does not disclose.
- **Users vs payers:** Most viewers never pay; a small core of subscribers and gifters funds creators.
- **Unit economics:** Live video bandwidth is costly; $1B+ paid to streamers yearly; high take on subs, thin ad CPMs.
- **Growth levers:** Mobile vertical live, clips for off-platform discovery, better ad tech, mid-tier creator retention.
- **Lesson:** Strong community does not equal profit: serving costs and creator splits squeeze margins under parent scrutiny.

Friction points to discuss

- New streamers struggle to be discovered
- Long, frequent mid-roll ads frustrate viewers
- Mobile app weaker than TikTok or YouTube
- Moderation controversies and inconsistent enforcement
- Revenue split worse than Kick's 95/5

Competitors and market

- **Live streaming:** YouTube Live, Kick, TikTok Live, Facebook Gaming
- **Short video:** TikTok, Shorts, Reels capturing attention and clips
- **India/Asia:** Loco, Rooter, SOOP (AfreecaTV) in Korea
- **Creator payouts:** Kick 95/5 split and big streamer deals
- **Edge:** Unmatched live chat culture and gaming identity
- **Risk:** Hours-watched decline, creator defection, Amazon patience on profitability

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** Recaps feed turns creator-chosen clips into short stream highlight reels
- **May 2026:** TwitchCon: dual-format vertical streaming, Custom Power-Ups, Gift 'Em All
- **May 2026:** Viewbot crackdown caps concurrent viewers for repeat offenders
- **Watch:** Kick share gains, Amazon profitability push, clips-driven discovery results

Sources: Press coverage (GamesBeat, Tubefilter, TechCrunch), Streams Charts estimates. Revenue and hours are third-party estimates. Prepared Oct 2026.

Moj (ShareChat / Mohalla Tech)

Indian vernacular short-video app, pivoting to micro-dramas

Founded: **Moj launched Jun 2020 after TikTok ban; parent 2015** HQ: **Bengaluru, India** Owner/Listed: **Mohalla Tech (private); IPO up to $400M planned**
Revenue: **FY25 ₹723 cr (~$85M), flat vs ₹718 cr** Losses: **FY25 adj. EBITDA loss ₹219 cr (-72% YoY)** Run-rate: **2026 annualised ~₹1,400 cr, 30%+ growth (company)**
Users: **ShareChat + Moj ~150M MAU; QuickTV 3M subs** CEO/Head: **Ankush Sachdeva, co-founder and CEO** Merger: **Absorbed MX TakaTak in 2022**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Give Bharat's next billion a social platform in their own language.
- **Vision:** Be India's vernacular entertainment layer: short video, live and micro-dramas for tier-2+ audiences.
- **Core strategy:** Pivot from chasing Reels on scale to owning profitable niches: micro-dramas, live gifting, regional creators.
- **Moat:** 15+ Indian languages, regional creator network, low-cost AI content production, Bharat user insight.
- **Key bet:** Micro-dramas: 65M monthly viewers, 700M episodes daily, QuickTV paywall, ₹100 cr AI content push.
- **Your view:** Moj won the TikTok-ban land grab then lost to Reels and Shorts; was retreat to niches inevitable?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Moj (ShareChat / Mohalla Tech)
Viewers	Tier-2+ Indians, vernacular-first, mobile-only	English-heavy apps, want entertainment in own language	Regional language feeds, local creators, micro-dramas, works on low-end phones
Creators	Regional influencers, actors, dancers	Hard to stand out on Instagram or YouTube	Less competition, language communities, live gifting income, creator fund
Advertisers	FMCG, D2C, gaming, BFSI brands	Reach Bharat audiences cost-effectively	Vernacular targeting, cheaper CPMs than Meta, influencer brand integrations
Paying micro-drama fans	Binge viewers of serialised short dramas	Want cliffhanger stories in Hindi and regional languages	QuickTV episodic paywall, cheap coin packs, TV-actor led stories
Live gifters	Engaged users supporting hosts	Want recognition and interaction with creators	Virtual gifts in audio and video chatrooms

Product portfolio and metrics

Social and short video

Moj	Vernacular short-video feed, merged with MX TakaTak
ShareChat	Regional-language social feed of posts, memes and video
Live and chatrooms	Audio/video live rooms monetised through virtual gifts
North Star	Daily time spent per active user in vernacular feeds
Key metrics	MAU, DAU/MAU, minutes per user, creator uploads, gifting ARPPU
Guardrails	Content moderation incidents, adult content, creator churn to Reels

Monetisation

Moj/ShareChat Ads	Self-serve and direct video ads for brands
Virtual gifting	Coins and gifts in live rooms
Subscriptions	QuickTV memberships and episode unlocks
North Star	Contribution margin per MAU
Key metrics	Ad revenue, CPM, gifting revenue, subscription ARPU
Guardrails	Ad load per session, payment failures, fraud

Micro-dramas

QuickTV	Paid micro-drama app with 3M subscribers
Moj micro-dramas	Free ad-supported episodes; 30M+ monthly viewers
AI content studio	AI tools to produce dramas cheaply at scale
North Star	Episodes completed per viewer per week
Key metrics	Paid conversion, episodes/day, cost per episode, series completion
Guardrails	Payback period per show, refund rate, content quality complaints

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Advertising	Free users of Moj and ShareChat	Brands, agencies, app advertisers	In-feed video ads, brand challenges, influencer integrations
Live gifting	Engaged fans in live rooms	Users buying virtual coins	Platform keeps share of gifts sent to hosts
Micro-drama subscriptions	Binge viewers on QuickTV	Subscribers and episode unlockers	Free first episodes, then paywall or coins
Ad-supported dramas	Free micro-drama viewers on Moj	Advertisers	Ads between episodes; funnel to paid QuickTV

- **Revenue mix:** FY25 mostly ads plus gifting; micro-drama subscriptions now driving 30%+ growth in 2026.
- **Users vs payers:** ~150M MAU but only ~3M QuickTV subscribers; low Bharat ARPU forces ad-heavy model.
- **Unit economics:** Losses cut 72% via layoffs and cost controls, not ad growth; cash-flow positive core business.
- **Growth levers:** AI-made micro-dramas, regional languages, paid conversion, IPO capital, brand-funded drama series.
- **Lesson:** TikTok-ban windfall was rented demand; once Reels and Shorts arrived, scale without moat collapsed.

Friction points to discuss

- Feed full of repetitive, low-quality reposted clips
- Top creators migrated to Reels and Shorts
- Heavy ad load on low-end devices
- Micro-drama paywalls hit mid-cliffhanger
- App bloat and battery drain on budget phones

Competitors and market

- **Short video:** Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, Josh (VerSe)
- **Micro-dramas:** Kuku TV, Pocket FM, Stage, ReelShort
- **Vernacular social:** Koo (shut 2024), Chingari, Facebook groups
- **Live gifting:** Chamet, Eloelo, Instagram Live
- **Edge:** Deep vernacular data and ~65M micro-drama viewers, two-thirds of Indian format
- **Risk:** Meta/Google ad dominance, IT Rules moderation burden, micro-drama copycats

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** Mohalla Tech commits ₹100 cr to AI-driven micro-drama production
- **Jul 2026:** Turns operationally profitable; plans up to $400M IPO within 4-5 quarters
- **2025:** FY25 revenue flat at ₹723 cr; adjusted EBITDA loss cut 72%
- **Watch:** FY26 audited numbers, IPO filing, QuickTV paid conversion, Reels share gains

Sources: Mohalla Tech FY25 filings via Entrackr/Inc42, Business Standard, Business Today, company statements. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Dream11 (Dream Sports)

India's fantasy sports leader, forced into a free-to-play sports-engagement pivot

Founded: **2008, Harsh Jain and Bhavit Sheth** HQ: **Mumbai, India** Owner/Listed: **Dream Sports, private; $8B valuation (Nov 2021)** Revenue: **FY25 ₹6,759 cr (-15% YoY), net loss ₹479 cr**
Post-ban: **~95% revenue, 100% profit lost after Aug 2025** Users: **250M+ registered users** Market share: **~70% of Indian fantasy sports (2024)** CEO/Head: **Harsh Jain, co-founder and CEO**
Status: **Paid contests stopped 22 Aug 2025; free-to-play now**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Make sports better for fans: from paid fantasy contests to a free, AI-personalised second screen for sports.
- **Vision:** Global sports engagement platform: content, live scores, watchalongs, community and social contests across sports and markets.
- **Ban response:** Complied overnight without suing, kept 250M users, no layoffs, cut sponsorships, split group into eight startup-mode units (Dec 2025).
- **Key bets:** Ad-supported free fantasy in India plus 11 overseas markets; Dream Money for gold, SIPs and broking; FanCode streaming expansion.
- **Moat:** Brand synonymous with fantasy cricket, 250M accounts, deep sports data and a large war chest from 2021 raise.
- **Your view:** Can a 250M-user audience built on cash prizes be monetised through ads and fintech, or was the prize the product?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Dream11 (Dream Sports)
Casual cricket fans	Tier 1–3 Indian men, 18–35	Want stakes and bragging rights during matches without spending money	Familiar team-building game, social leagues with friends, now free with no deposit risk
Ex-power players	High-frequency former cash-contest players	Lost cash prizes; free contests feel low-stakes and less thrilling	Habit, deep stats and player tools; the alternatives are offshore betting apps they distrust
Global diaspora fans	Cricket fans in US, UK, UAE, Australia	Few fantasy products built around cricket in their country	Free-to-play Dream11 launched in 11 markets (Oct 2025) with familiar formats
Advertisers and brands	Swiggy, Tata Neu, Astrotalk and similar consumer brands	Need to reach engaged sports audiences during live matches at scale	Huge live-match attention, sports-context targeting, sponsorship of free contests and watchalongs
Creators and leagues	Cricket creators, leagues, sports bodies	Need distribution and monetisation for live sports commentary	Creator-led watchalongs reach 100K+ viewers in minutes on Dream11 surfaces

Product portfolio and metrics

Dream11 sports engagement

Free fantasy contests	Team-building contests for points, rewards and leaderboards, no cash
Watchalongs	Creator-led live match commentary rooms for second-screen viewing
Scores and stats	Live scores, player stats, AI-personalised feeds per team
Dream11 Global	Free-to-play app in 11 markets incl. US, UK, UAE
North Star	Weekly engaged fans per match day (contest joined or watchalong watched)
Key metrics	Match-day DAU, contests per user, ad impressions per session, D30 retention
Guardrails	No cash-like rewards breaching PROGA; ad load vs session time; churn

Sports media and experiences

FanCode	Sports streaming and live scores; expanding to South and Southeast Asia
DreamSetGo	Sports travel and premium match experiences
Dream Game Studios	Casual mobile games such as Dream Cricket
Cricbuzz stake	Reported $50M investment in cricket news leader
North Star	Paid and ad-supported viewing hours per fan per month
Key metrics	Subscribers, streaming hours, rights cost per hour, ARPU
Guardrails	Rights spend within budget; buffering/QoS; subscriber churn

Fintech (Dream Money)

Digital gold	Buy gold from ₹10 via Augmont partnership
SIPs and FDs	Mutual fund SIPs and fixed deposits for first-time investors
Stock broking	Discount brokerage vs Zerodha, Groww, Angel One
North Star	Monthly active investors funded from Dream11 audience
Key metrics	Dream11-to-Money conversion, AUM, SIP persistence, cost per funded account
Guardrails	SEBI/RBI compliance, mis-selling complaints, speculation-like behaviour

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Advertising and sponsorship	Fans playing free contests and watching watchalongs	Consumer brands and sponsors	In-app ads, sponsored contests, branded watchalongs on match days
FanCode streaming	Fans watching niche leagues and cricket	Subscribers and advertisers	Match/tour passes, subscriptions, ads, merch discontinued
Dream Money fintech	Young retail investors from Dream11 base	Investors and product partners	Brokerage, distribution commissions, gold spreads
Former: cash contests (banned)	Paid fantasy players	Players via entry fees	~15–20% platform rake on entry fees; ended 22 Aug 2025

- **Revenue mix:** Pre-ban ~95% from contest rake; now ads, sponsorships, FanCode and early fintech, all sub-scale (est.).
- **Users vs payers:** 250M registered, previously a minority paying entry fees; now users are free, advertisers pay.
- **Unit economics:** Rake gave high take-rate per user; ad ARPU is a small fraction, so costs and sponsorships were slashed.
- **Growth levers:** Global free fantasy, AI personalisation, creator watchalongs, cross-sell to Dream Money, FanCode in new markets.
- **Cash cushion:** Runs on reserves from $840M 2021 raise; GST disputes over ₹28,000 cr remain an overhang.

Friction points to discuss

- Free contests lack the thrill that cash stakes provided
- Rewards must avoid anything resembling money under PROGA
- Ad-heavy match screens dilute fast team-building flow
- Fintech cross-sell feels unrelated to sports intent
- Users wary after abrupt wallet shutdown and withdrawals

Competitors and market

- **Fantasy (pre-ban):** MPL, My11Circle, MyTeam11; all exited cash contests
- **Sports media:** JioHotstar, Cricbuzz, ESPNcricinfo, SonyLIV for live-match attention
- **Fintech:** Zerodha, Groww, Angel One, Jar for investing
- **Grey market:** Offshore betting apps capturing ex-RMG users illegally
- **Edge:** Largest fantasy audience and brand, cash reserves, strong sports data
- **Risk:** Ad ARPU far below rake; Supreme Court outcome; GST liabilities

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** Completes pivot to global sports engagement platform; drops all prizes
- **Dec 2025:** Dream Sports splits into eight independent units in startup mode
- **Oct 2025:** Free-to-play Dream11 launches in 11 countries incl. US, UK
- **Watch:** PROGA constitutional challenge before Supreme Court; Dream Money traction

Sources: Dream Sports FY25 filings (via Entrackr/Inc42), press coverage 2025–26, MeitY PROGA rules. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

WinZO

Vernacular real-money casual games app, collapsed after ban and ED action

Founded: **2018, Saumya Singh Rathore and Paavan Nanda** HQ: **New Delhi (ops in Bengaluru, Gurugram)** Owner/Listed: **Private; backers incl. Griffin, Kalaari, Makers Fund**
Revenue: **FY24 ₹1,055 cr (+57%), adj. PAT ₹315 cr** FY25: **Financials not filed as of 2026** Users: **~25 cr registered users claimed (pre-ban)**
Status: **RMG shut 22 Aug 2025; ~70% staff gone** Enforcement: **ED froze ₹500–800 cr; founders arrested Nov 2025** Legal: **ED chargesheet Jan 2026; both founders on bail**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Pre-ban: bring Bharat's 'desi' casual games (Ludo, Carrom, Rummy) online with small cash stakes in 12 languages.
- **Old model:** Platform fee on micro-stake peer contests across 100+ games, plus a developer program letting studios list real-money games.
- **Ban response:** Shut cash games, launched ZO TV short video, micro-dramas, digital gold and free games; pushed into US, Brazil, Germany.
- **Enforcement:** ED alleges bots against users, ₹43 cr unrefunded balances, $55M routed to US shell, overseas RMG run from India.
- **Lesson:** Regulatory risk is existential: governance, user-fund segregation and honest matchmaking matter more than growth when rules change.
- **Your view:** Was WinZO's pivot doomed because its audience valued winning money, or because trust collapsed under enforcement?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose WinZO
Bharat casual gamers	Tier 2–4 smartphone users, regional languages	Want quick fun and small winnings on low-end phones	Familiar desi games, ₹1-level stakes, vernacular UI, fast UPI payouts (pre-ban)
Wallet holders post-ban	Users with balances on 22 Aug 2025	Withdrawals delayed or blocked; ₹43 cr allegedly unrefunded	Stayed only to recover funds; trust largely gone
Game developers	Indian indie studios in WinZO program	Hard to monetise casual games and reach Bharat users	Distribution to crore-scale users and revenue share on contests (pre-ban)
Overseas players	Users in US, Brazil, Germany	Want social skill games with prizes	Expansion bet post-ban; ED says these ran from Indian entity
Advertisers and partners	Paytm and ad networks, payment gateways	Need paying, compliant clients	Was a top ad spender; Paytm later sued for ₹3.6 cr dues

Product portfolio and metrics

Real-money games (shut in India)

Ludo, Carrom, Rummy	Cash-stake versions of desi classics, withdrawn Aug 2025
Poker, Fantasy	Card and fantasy contests, advertised heavily before ban
Developer program	Third-party studios listing games on WinZO platform
WinZO US / Brazil	International apps; ED alleges post-ban RMG operations
North Star	Weekly paying players with healthy repeat play (pre-ban)
Key metrics	Entry-fee GMV, take rate, payer conversion, withdrawal SLA
Guardrails	Bot-free fair matchmaking, user fund segregation, responsible-play limits

Post-ban pivots

ZO TV	Short-video and micro-drama app; little progress amid crisis
Free-to-play games	Casual games without stakes, ad-monetised
Digital gold	Small-ticket gold savings for existing user base
North Star	Weekly active viewers/players retained from old base without stakes
Key metrics	DAU, watch time per user, ad ARPU, D30 retention
Guardrails	No prize mechanics breaching PROGA, refund backlog cleared, content safety

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Contest platform fee (banned)	Players in micro-stake games	Players via entry fees	Commission on each pooled contest, ended 22 Aug 2025
Developer revenue share	Third-party game studios	Players; WinZO shares rake with studios	Split of contest fees on partner games, ended with ban
Ads on ZO TV and free games	Casual viewers and players	Advertisers	In-feed and rewarded ads; negligible scale so far (est.)
Digital gold	Small savers from user base	Buyers via spread	Margin on gold buy/sell via partner vault

- **Revenue mix:** Pre-ban almost entirely contest fees; FY24 ₹1,055 cr. Post-ban revenue near zero, accounts unfiled.
- **Users vs payers:** Claimed ~25 cr users; a small paying minority drove rake. Free users monetise far worse.
- **Unit economics:** Profitable pre-ban (adj. PAT ₹315 cr) on cheap Bharat CAC; ED alleges bots inflated house wins.
- **Liquidity:** ₹500–800 cr frozen by ED, ~₹15 cr usable cash; vendors and Paytm pursuing dues.
- **Growth levers:** Realistically survival: unfreeze funds, settle refunds, win cases; then ads-led content or overseas apps.

Friction points to discuss

- Withdrawals frozen; users cannot access remaining balances
- Bot opponents allegedly undisclosed, destroying fairness trust
- Free games offer no reason to stay without winnings
- ZO TV pivot unrelated to core gaming habit
- Founder arrests and frozen accounts stall product shipping

Competitors and market

- **Casual RMG (exited):** MPL, Zupee, Gameskraft, Junglee Rummy, A23
- **Free casual:** Ludo King, Rush, Indian casual studios, Play Store hits
- **Short video:** Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, Moj, Josh, micro-drama apps
- **Grey market:** Offshore betting and rummy apps targeting ex-RMG users
- **Edge:** Vernacular Bharat distribution and multi-game catalogue, now largely eroded
- **Risk:** PMLA prosecution, insolvency pleas, brand toxicity, no lawful core revenue

Recent news and direction

- **Feb 2026:** Paavan Nanda gets bail; ED seeks to cancel Rathore's bail
- **Jan 2026:** ED chargesheet alleges ₹734 cr users duped via bots
- **Nov 2025:** ED raids, freezes ~₹505 cr, arrests both co-founders under PMLA
- **Watch:** PMLA trial, fund defreezing pleas, Paytm NCLT case, PROGA verdict

Sources: MCA filings FY24 (via Inc42), ED statements, court reports (LiveLaw, Storyboard18) 2025–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Zynga (Take-Two)

Free-to-play mobile games label powering half of Take-Two's bookings

Founded: **2007, Mark Pincus, San Francisco** HQ: **San Francisco, USA** Owner/Listed: **Take-Two (NASDAQ: TTWO), acquired 2022 for $12.7B**
Revenue: **FY26 Take-Two mobile $3.3B (+15%), mostly Zynga** Group: **Take-Two FY26 net bookings $6.72B (+19%)** Mix: **Mobile 53% of Take-Two bookings (Q1 FY27)**
Users: **Not disclosed; tens of millions MAU (est.)** CEO/Head: **Frank Gibeau, President of Zynga** India: **Bengaluru studio; no real-money games**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Connect the world through games: free-to-play titles monetised by in-app purchases and ads, never cash payouts.
- **Core strategy:** Multi-studio portfolio (Peak, Rollic, Small Giant, StarLark, NaturalMotion) with relentless live ops on evergreen puzzle and casual hits.
- **Contrast to RMG:** Players pay for fun (boosters, lives, virtual chips) but can never cash out, so not a money game under PROGA.
- **Moat:** Live-ops expertise, Take-Two cross-promotion and ad network, data-driven UA at scale, Rollic hyper-casual funnel.
- **Key bet:** Grow casual hits (Toon Blast, Match Factory!, Color Block Jam) and new launches like Top Goal, CSR 3.
- **Your view:** Is Zynga Poker's virtual-chip social casino one regulator decision away from being treated like real-money gaming?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Zynga (Take-Two)
Casual puzzle players	Adults 25–55, often women, global	Want short relaxing sessions with a sense of progress	Polished match/puzzle loops, daily events, fair free play, optional boosters
Social casino players	Zynga Poker and slots fans	Want poker thrills without gambling money or legal risk	Virtual chips, social tables, no cash-out keeps it entertainment
Word and social players	Friends and families on Words With Friends	Want asynchronous play to stay connected	Turn-based social play, long-lived friend graphs, brand familiarity
Spenders (whales)	Top ~2–5% paying players (est.)	Want to progress faster and keep streaks	Bundles, battle passes, events; fair value and limited-time offers
Advertisers	App marketers and brands buying in-game ads	Need scaled mobile reach with measurable installs	Huge casual audience, rewarded video, Take-Two/Zynga ad stack

Product portfolio and metrics

Casual and puzzle

Toon Blast / Toy Blast	Peak's cube-blast puzzle franchises, top revenue drivers
Match Factory!	Triple-match puzzle hit with strong live-service events
Color Block Jam	Rollic puzzle, now a top-five Zynga title
Empires & Puzzles	Small Giant match-3 RPG hybrid
North Star	Daily active players completing at least one session
Key metrics	DAU, D1/D7/D30 retention, ARPDAU, payer conversion, event participation
Guardrails	Difficulty spikes, ad fatigue, refund and complaint rates

Sports, racing and hyper-casual

CSR Racing / CSR 3	NaturalMotion drag racing; CSR 3 upcoming
Golf Rival	StarLark competitive mobile golf
Top Goal	Upcoming mobile football title
Rollic hyper-casual	Ad-funded quick games feeding UA funnel
North Star	Monthly players graduating from hyper-casual to core titles
Key metrics	CPI vs LTV, ad revenue per DAU, cross-promo installs
Guardrails	UA payback period, store rating, launch kill-rate discipline

Social and casino

Zynga Poker	Social Texas Hold'em with virtual chips, no cash-out
Words With Friends	Asynchronous social word game
FarmVille 3	Farm sim continuing Zynga's original social franchise
North Star	Weekly socially connected players (played with or against a friend)
Key metrics	Friend invites, sessions per day, chip purchase conversion, ARPPU
Guardrails	Problem-play signals, spend limits, regulator complaints on social casino

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
In-app purchases	All players of free titles	Small share of spenders	Boosters, lives, virtual chips, passes; items have no cash value
In-game advertising	Non-paying casual and hyper-casual players	Advertisers and app marketers	Rewarded video, interstitials, offerwalls via ad network
Social casino	Zynga Poker and slots players	Chip buyers	Virtual chip packs; winnings cannot be redeemed for money
Licensed IP games	Fans of licensed franchises	Players via IAP	Revenue share with IP owners; Star Wars Hunters shut Oct 2025

- **Revenue mix:** Mostly IAP, with meaningful advertising; mobile was 49% of Take-Two FY26 bookings ($3.3B).
- **Users vs payers:** Typically 2–5% of players pay (est.); whales fund free play for the rest.
- **Unit economics:** LTV must beat CPI; long-lived live-ops titles amortise development, new launches carry high kill risk.
- **Growth levers:** Live ops on evergreen hits, new launches, Rollic funnel, GTA VI (19 Nov 2026) halo for cross-promotion.
- **RMG lesson:** No cash-out means no gambling classification: Zynga avoided India's ban that erased Dream11 and WinZO revenue.

Friction points to discuss

- Paywalled difficulty spikes frustrate non-paying players
- Frequent ads interrupt short casual sessions
- Social casino can feel like gambling to regulators
- Shutdowns like Star Wars Hunters strand paid purchases
- Notification and offer overload drives uninstalls

Competitors and market

- **Casual puzzle:** King (Candy Crush), Playrix, Dream Games (Royal Match)
- **Social casino:** Playtika, Aristocrat/Product Madness, SciPlay
- **Hyper-casual:** Voodoo, Supersonic, Homa
- **India casual:** Ludo King, Nazara titles, ex-RMG firms going free-to-play
- **Edge:** Live-ops depth, diversified studio portfolio, Take-Two balance sheet
- **Risk:** UA cost inflation, platform fee/privacy changes, social casino regulation

Recent news and direction

- **Aug 2026:** Take-Two Q1 FY27: mobile 53% of $1.39B bookings, Zynga steady
- **May 2026:** FY26: Zynga best-ever quarter; mobile bookings $3.3B, up 15%
- **Oct 2025:** Star Wars Hunters servers shut less than 18 months after launch
- **Watch:** Top Goal and CSR 3 launches; GTA VI cross-promo; social-casino rules

Sources: Take-Two 8-K earnings releases FY26 and Q1 FY27, press coverage 2025–26. Metrics are PM estimates for interview prep. Prepared Oct 2026.

Adobe

Software to create, manage and deliver digital content and customer experiences

Founded: **1982, Warnock and Geschke** HQ: **San Jose, CA** Listed: **NASDAQ: ADBE** Q3 FY26 revenue: **$6.76B (+13% YoY)** Total ARR: **$27.5B (+11.2%)** FY26 guidance: **Up to $26.6B**
CEO: **Anil Chakravarthy from 1 Dec 2026 (Narayen to Exec Chair)** India: **Major R&D hub: Noida, Bengaluru, Hyderabad**

Mission, vision and strategy

- **Mission:** Changing the world through personalized digital experiences
- **Values:** Genuine, Exceptional, Innovative, Involved
- **Responsible AI:** Firefly trained on licensed content; Content Credentials to show how content was made
- **Vision:** AI-first creativity and marketing; creation for everyone, depth for pros and enterprises
- **Two customer groups:** Business Professionals and Consumers; Creative and Marketing Professionals
- **Your view:** Is Adobe balancing pro depth with mass-market simplicity, or stretched between the two?

Customers and users

Segment	Who	Pain point	Why they choose Adobe
Creative professionals	Designers, photographers, video editors, 3D artists	Need precise control, fast turnaround and client-safe assets across image, video and 3D	Industry-standard tools and file formats; one integrated suite; commercially safe AI
Marketing teams and agencies	Brand, content and campaign teams	Must produce huge volumes of on-brand content for many channels, quickly	GenStudio, Firefly, Frame.io and Express connect creation, review and delivery
Business professionals	Knowledge workers, legal, finance, HR	Editing, reviewing, signing and making sense of long documents	Adobe invented PDF; Acrobat is the trusted default, now with AI Assistant and Sign
Consumers, students, SMBs	Casual creators, small business owners	Want good-looking content without design skills or big budgets	Free Express and Firefly tiers, templates, brand trust (Canva is the strong rival here)
Enterprises	CMOs, digital and IT leaders	Fragmented customer data, weak personalisation, hard to prove marketing ROI	End-to-end stack from content to customer data to delivery, tied to creative tools

Product portfolio and metrics

Creative Cloud

Photoshop	Image editing, compositing and retouching, with AI Generative Fill
Illustrator	Vector graphics for logos, icons and illustrations
Premiere Pro	Professional video editing for film, YouTube and social
After Effects	Motion graphics and visual effects
Lightroom	Photo organising and editing across desktop and mobile
Frame.io	Cloud video review, feedback and collaboration
North Star	Weekly active paid creators exporting finished work
Key metrics	Creative Cloud net new ARR; Paid subscriber retention (churn rate)
Guardrails	App performance (crash rate, launch time); Cancellation complaints and NPS

AI and everyday creation

Firefly	Gen AI for image, video, audio, vector; commercially safe, IP indemnity
Firefly Foundry	Custom models trained on a brand's own assets for enterprises
Adobe Express	Quick templates for social posts, flyers and short videos
Adobe in ChatGPT	Photoshop, Express and Acrobat usable directly inside ChatGPT
North Star	Weekly AI-generated assets that are exported or published
Key metrics	Free to paid conversion; Monthly active users of Express and Firefly
Guardrails	Inference cost per generation (margin); IP or unsafe content incidents

Document Cloud

Acrobat Reader	Free PDF viewer; top of the funnel with a massive user base
Acrobat Pro	Create, edit, convert, compare and protect PDFs
Acrobat AI Assistant	Chat with, summarise and query documents
Acrobat Sign	E-signatures and approval workflows
North Star	Documents actioned per week (edited, signed, summarised)
Key metrics	Reader to paid Acrobat conversion; AI Assistant attach rate
Guardrails	Security and privacy incidents; Free Reader quality

Experience Cloud

AEM	Manage websites, content and digital assets at scale
Real-Time CDP	Unify customer data into live profiles for targeting
GenStudio	AI content supply chain to plan, create and activate content
Marketo Engage	B2B marketing automation and lead management
Semrush	SEO and AI search visibility (acquisition announced Nov 2025)
North Star	Personalised customer journeys activated for enterprise clients
Key metrics	Net revenue retention; Products adopted per customer
Guardrails	Platform uptime against SLA; Time to value

Business model

Line	Who uses	Who pays	How they pay
Creative Cloud	Individual creatives, in-house design teams, students	Individuals on monthly or annual plans; employers buy seats	Per-seat subscription, single app or full suite; student discounts
Firefly and Express	Casual creators, SMBs, social and marketing teams	Most use free; power users upgrade; enterprises pay for Foundry	Freemium plus generative credit tiers ($9.99 to $199.99 per month)
Document Cloud	Anyone who opens a PDF (free Reader)	Professionals and companies buying Acrobat seats	Per-seat subscription; AI Assistant as paid add-on
Experience Cloud	Marketers, analysts, web and data teams	CMO and CIO budgets via multi-year enterprise contracts	Priced by usage (profiles, traffic, volume) plus services

- **Revenue mix:** Subscription is $6.58B of $6.76B Q3 revenue (up 14% YoY)
- **Users vs payers:** Huge free user base (Reader, Express, Firefly) is the acquisition funnel; in B2B, users rarely hold the budget
- **Channels:** adobe.com and app stores for individuals; direct enterprise sales and resellers for teams
- **Growth levers:** Free to paid upgrades, cross-sell across suites, AI credit upsell, price increases
- **Structure:** Now one reporting segment for unified selling and product development

Friction points to discuss

- Steep learning curve on pro apps
- Confusing credit system; premium features drain credits fast
- Native AI output often trails best rivals
- Complex, overlapping plans and pricing
- Past criticism of cancellation terms

Competitors and market

- **Design:** Canva, Figma, CapCut, Affinity
- **Gen AI:** OpenAI, Google, Microsoft, Midjourney, Runway
- **Documents:** Microsoft, DocuSign, Foxit
- **Experience:** Salesforce, Oracle, HubSpot
- **Edge:** Pro tools, brand trust, safe AI, content-to-marketing workflow
- **Risk:** AI-native tools make creation cheap for non-pros

Recent news and direction

- **Sep 2026:** CEO transition; record Q3, guidance raised
- **AI push:** Heavy spend on AI models and agentic apps; Firefly Foundry
- **Distribution:** Semrush deal; apps inside ChatGPT; Runway, YouTube, Google Cloud partnerships
- **Watch:** Stock down on free-tier shift, AI costs, AI-native rivals

Sources: Adobe newsroom and Q3 FY26 results, SEC 10-Q, analyst coverage. Suite metrics are PM estimates for interview prep, not Adobe-published. Prepared Sep 2026.